Working With Your Benefits

A Prestige Path Participant Textbook — A Plain-Language Guide for People on SSI & SSDI

2027 Edition — Prestige Path Consulting LLC



Free one-on-one help is real, and it is never sold: call the Ticket to Work Help Line at 1-866-968-7842 (TTY 1-866-833-2967, Mon–Fri 8am–8pm ET), or visit choosework.ssa.gov to find an Employment Network or a WIPA counselor. Published by Prestige Path Consulting LLC — itself an Employment Network you can choose.

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How to Use This Book

This book teaches you the rules of working while you receive SSDI or SSI — in plain words, with steps you can do yourself.

You do not have to read it front to back. Each chapter stands on its own. If a letter from Social Security is sitting on your table right now, go straight to Part 6 and find the situation that matches yours.

The free-help promise behind this book. Benefits advisement comes first. Before you act on any number in this book, you can sit down — free — for **BWIA (Benefits and Work Incentive Advisement)**: a one-on-one look at your benefits, your months, and your plan, with an Employment Network you choose or a WIPA project (reach both through the Ticket to Work Help Line, 1-866-968-7842, or choosework.ssa.gov). Ticket to Work services cost you **$0**. Even the Job Accommodation Network's own job-search guide for people with disabilities gives the same advice this book does: if you receive Social Security benefits, ask an Employment Network for help under Ticket to Work. (JAN's other specialty — workplace accommodations — gets its own chapter: Chapter 20.)

One honest warning, up front. This book is general information, not personal advice. Only Social Security has your official record — your exact Trial Work months, your dates, your amounts. The numbers in this book are the real 2027 rules,

verified against Social Security's own publications (see Appendix D), but how they land on your check depends on your record. That's what the free advisement is for.

About the dollar amounts — read this once. Every dollar amount in this book is the official amount for **2027**. Social Security updates most of these amounts **every January** — the Trial Work amount, the SGA amounts, the SSI payment amounts, the student limits. So if you are reading this in 2028 or later, the rules and the steps are exactly the same, but the dollars will have moved a little. Before you act on any number in a new year, check the current amount first: at ssa.gov, with your benefits counselor, or on our always-current numbers page — prestigepathconsulting.com/numbers.

Words we use. SSDI is Social Security Disability Insurance (Title 2). SSI is Supplemental Security Income (Title 16). Some people receive both — if that's you, both roads in Part 1 apply to you, one for each benefit. SSA means the Social Security Administration.

About the type. The chapters of this book — the reading text — are set in a clear 14-point type. The reference appendices at the back (the resource directory, the glossary, the sources, and the forms index) are set in smaller, compact type: they are for looking things up, not for reading start to finish, and the compact type keeps this book from growing out of hand.

Start Here If…

Don't read the whole book. Start with your situation.

Your situation	Go straight to
"I got a letter from SSA"	SSA Letter Decoder (next pages) → then the chapter it names
"Social Security says I was overpaid"	Scenario 1 + Chapter 6
"I just got a job offer"	Chapter 19 (First Week) + Scenario 2 (SSDI) or 3 (SSI)
"I got my first paycheck"	Scenario 2 (SSDI) or Scenario 3 (SSI)
"I already work"	Chapter 21 + Find Your Phase
"Something about the job itself is in my way"	Chapter 20 — Your Rights at Work
"My check changed / stopped"	Chapter 2 (SSDI) or Chapter 3 (SSI) → Letter Decoder
"I was offered a raise or more hours"	Scenario 4 + Chapter 22
"I want to save money"	Part 2 — start with The Easy Order
"Work costs me money to do"	Chapter 4 — the Big IRWE List
"How do I build savings without losing SSI?"	Chapter 11 — Building Wealth While on SSI or SSDI

Start Here If...

Your situation	Go straight to
"My job ended"	Scenario 6 (disability) or Scenario 9 (unemployment)
"I got turned down — again"	Scenario 12 + Chapter 1
"I work for myself / gig apps / 1099 work"	Chapter 24 + Appendix E-11 (NESE log)
"I don't even know where I stand"	Find Your Phase (Part 1) + My Numbers (below)

My Numbers — Your Private Page

This page is YOURS. Fill it in pencil. It is your private notebook page — never mail it, photograph it for strangers, or hand it to anyone but your own benefits counselor in a session YOU chose. A second copy is in Appendix A, because numbers change.

- I receive: ☐ SSDI ☐ SSI ☐ Both
- My monthly benefit amount: $_____ (SSDI) · $_____ (SSI)
- My phase (from Find Your Phase + my BPQY): ☐ Phase 1 Protected ☐ Phase 2 Adjusting ☐ Phase 3 Independent ☐ SSI Monthly Path
- Trial Work months used (from my BPQY): ____ of 9 · Date I confirmed it: _____
- My EPE months (if Phase 2): started _____ · ends _____
- My SGA number: $1,770/mo (2027, non-blind) · $2,950 (blind) — mine: $_____
- I report wages by: ☐ phone (1st–6th) ☐ online ☐ mail/in person · My deadline: SSI 6th / SSDI 10th
- My employer's name and my start date:

  _____
- My Ticket is assigned to: _____ (my Employment Network's name)
- My Employment Network contact: _____ · Phone:

  _____

- My BPQY request date: _____ · Received: _____
- Notes: _____

SSA Letter Decoder

SSA letters look alarming by design. Most are routine. Find yours, do the first step, breathe.

Award letter

- **What it is:** Your approval and amounts when benefits start or are decided
- **Urgent?** No — good news
- **Do this first:** File it; note your amounts on My Numbers
- **In this book:** Ch. 2–3

Overpayment notice

- **What it is:** SSA says it paid you too much and wants it back
- **Urgent? Yes — 60-day appeal clock**
- **Do this first:** Don't agree to anything; pull your pay stubs; call for free help
- **In this book:** Scenario 1, Ch. 6

BPQY printout

- **What it is:** Your official status snapshot: TWP months, EPE dates, Medicare
- **Urgent?** No
- **Do this first:** Use it to fill My Numbers and Find Your Phase
- **In this book:** Find Your Phase

Medical review (CDR) notice

- **What it is:** SSA is reviewing whether your condition improved
- **Urgent? Yes — answer on time**
- **Do this first:** Note the deadline; complete **SSA-454-BK** if SSA sent the Continuing Disability Review Report; if your Ticket is assigned and you're making progress, ask why it started; call your Employment Network or a WIPA counselor
- **In this book:** Ch. 7, Appendix E

Medical cessation decision

- **What it is:** SSA says your disability ended for medical reasons
- **Urgent? Yes — 60 days; continuation election is urgent**
- **Do this first:** Appeal with **SSA-789** (not SSA-561); ask about **SSA-792** to keep benefits going; update your case with **SSA-3441-BK** and sign **SSA-827** so SSA can get records
- **In this book:** Ch. 7, Appendix E

Reconsideration denial

- **What it is:** SSA looked again and still said no
- **Urgent? Yes — 60 days to ask for a hearing**
- **Do this first:** File **HA-501** to ask an Administrative Law Judge to decide; use **SSA-1696** if a representative will handle it
- **In this book:** Ch. 6–7, Appendix E

Extra Help decision

- **What it is:** Part D Extra Help was denied, ended, or set at an amount you dispute
- **Urgent?** Sometimes — appeal promptly
- **Do this first:** Appeal with **SSA-1021**; mail it to the address printed on that form, not the local office
- **In this book:** Ch. 8, Appendix E

Medicare surcharge (IRMAA) notice

- **What it is:** Your Part B or Part D premium is higher because SSA used an older, higher-income tax year
- **Urgent?** Sometimes
- **Do this first:** If work stopped or hours dropped, ask about **SSA-44** for a life-changing event
- **In this book:** Ch. 8, Appendix E

Benefit change notice

- **What it is:** Your payment amount is changing, and why
- **Urgent?** Sometimes
- **Do this first:** Check the reason against Ch. 2/3 math; if the reason is wrong, that's appeal territory
- **In this book:** Ch. 2, 3, 6

Work activity / review letter (SSA-821-BK or similar)

- **What it is:** SSA is reviewing your earnings
- **Urgent? Yes — return in 15 days**

- **Do this first:** Complete it fully; claim every deduction (Ch. 4) BEFORE they decide
- **In this book:** Ch. 4–5, Scenario 5

Medicare / premium notices

- **What it is:** Part B or Part D premium and enrollment information
- **Urgent?** Sometimes
- **Do this first:** Don't let Part B lapse by accident; ask about Savings Programs
- **In this book:** Ch. 8

The universal first steps for ANY scary letter: (1) write the date you received it on the envelope; (2) find the deadline and circle it; (3) never ignore it; (4) when in doubt, call the Help Line (1-866-968-7842) or your Employment Network before the deadline — that's what they're for.

Your Progress Tracker

Check boxes off as you go. This page is proof — to yourself — that you're moving. Go in order — each step sets up the next.

1. ☐ I read "How to Use This Book" and Chapter 1
2. ☐ I filled in My Numbers
3. ☐ I requested my BPQY
4. ☐ My Ticket is assigned to an Employment Network I chose, and my IWP is signed
5. ☐ I opened my my Social Security account
6. ☐ I found my phase (worksheet done)
7. ☐ I read my road chapter (SSDI Ch. 2 / SSI Ch. 3 / both)
8. ☐ I read the deductions chapter (Ch. 4)
9. ☐ I know my reporting deadline and method (Ch. 5)
10. ☐ I applied to my first job from a verified lead
11. ☐ I started work — and reported it to SSA
12. ☐ My pay-stub folder exists and is growing
13. ☐ Monthly routine done this month (report → stub → tracker → phase check)

Calls I've made (date · who · what was decided):

-
-
-

Chapter 1: Why Work — Your Reasons

Most people who receive SSDI or SSI and think about working feel two things at once: I want more than this — and I'm scared a paycheck will cost me everything.

That fear is the number one reason people wait. And here is the truth this whole book is built on: **the fear is almost always bigger than the rules.** The rules were written with safety nets most people have simply never had explained to them. Once you can see them, the decision gets a lot clearer.

Four things are true, and every chapter after this one proves them:

1. **Working leaves you with more money, not less.** On SSI, Social Security counts less than half of what you earn — every paycheck makes your total income go up. On SSDI, you can test work for nine months and keep your full check no matter what you earn. The math is in Chapters 2 and 3. Run it yourself.
2. **Trying is not a one-way door.** Trial Work Periods, grace months, benefits that pause instead of ending, and a reinstatement path if work doesn't hold — the nets are real, and they are described in plain words in this book.

3. **A paycheck is not the only thing work pays.** Work brings structure to your week, people around you, skills that grow, and proof — to yourself most of all — that you can do it. Those count.
4. **You don't have to figure it out alone.** Free help exists for exactly this: an Employment Network or WIPA counselor can walk it with you — benefits advisement first, then job leads matched to you, resume help, interview practice, and support after you start.

Worksheet: Find Your Reason

Motivation that lasts isn't a slogan. It's your reason. Fill this in — honestly, for yourself. Nobody grades it.

- **My reason for working is:** (a bill you want gone, a goal, a person, a thing you want, a feeling you want back)

  _____
- **My first small goal is:** (something reachable in 1–3 months — not the whole mountain) _____
- **The first step I will take this week is:** (read one chapter, call my Employment Network or the Help Line, update my resume, apply to one job) _____
- **When a bad day hits, I will:** (see the Bad-Day Plan in Scenario 12) _____

Bring this page to your first meeting with your Employment Network. It becomes the seed of your **Individual Work Plan (IWP)** — the written plan you and your Employment Network build together, with your goals in your words.

> **You can do this.** You don't need the whole road mapped today. You need your reason, one small goal, and one step this week. The rest of this book handles the rules.

Part 1 — Rules for Beneficiaries



Everything in this part is general information about how the programs work. Your own numbers get confirmed in a free BWIA session.

Find Your Phase

SSDI work moves through three phases. Knowing your phase tells you which rules matter most right now. **This finder is for SSDI** (and for the SSDI side if you get both SSDI and SSI).

On SSI only? You never enter the Trial Work phases. Your road is the monthly math in Chapter 3 — your payment adjusts gradually from your first paycheck. Skip to Chapter 3.

The questions, in order

Question 1: Have you worked at all since your SSDI started? - **No** → You are in **Phase 1 — Protected.** All nine of your Trial Work months are still in front of you. Read Chapter 2. - **Yes** → Go to Question 2.

Question 2: In any single month, did you earn over $1,270 (the 2027 Trial Work amount), or work more than 80 hours in self-employment? Each month like that, inside a rolling 60-month (5-year) window, uses **one Trial Work month**. Count yours as best you can from pay stubs and old letters. - **Fewer than 9 used** → **Phase 1 — Protected.** You still have Trial Work months left. During them, you keep your full check no matter how much you earn. Read Chapter 2. - **All 9 used** → Go to Question 3.

Question 3: When did you use your 9th Trial Work month? The month after your 9th Trial Work month, your **36-month Extended Period of Eligibility (EPE)** clock started — whether

you kept working or not. - **Still inside those 36 months** → **Phase 2 — Adjusting.** Now earnings steer the check: months at or below SGA ($1,770 a month in 2027, $2,950 if you're blind) are paid; months above are paused. The first month you go over SGA, that month **plus the next two** are still paid — those are your grace months. Read Chapter 2 and Scenario 5. - **The 36 months are over** → Go to Question 4.

Question 4: Are you still earning over the SGA amount? - **Yes** → **Phase 3 — Independent.** Your earnings have replaced your benefits — and it is not a cliff edge (see Question 5 and Chapter 2). - **No, and my benefits stopped because of work** → Go to Question 5.

Question 5: Did your benefits stop because of work within the last 5 years? - **Yes** → You are in the **EXR safety-net position.** If your disability keeps you from working at the SGA level, Expedited Reinstatement can restart your benefits without a brand-new application — with up to six months of provisional payments while Social Security decides. Read Chapter 2 and Scenario 6.

The honesty box — read this

This finder gives you an **estimate**. Only Social Security holds the official count of your Trial Work months and dates. The document that settles it is the **BPQY (Benefits Planning Query)** — a printout from SSA showing your benefit status, your Trial Work months used, your EPE dates, and your Medicare information.

How to get yours: ask your local Social Security office for a BPQY, or get one reviewed line by line in a free benefits counseling session (a WIPA project or your Employment Network's BWIA). Bring your pay stubs and any SSA letters you have — they are the supporting records that prove your months.

Worksheet: My Phase

- My benefit(s): ☐ SSDI ☐ SSI ☐ Both
- Have I worked since my SSDI started? ☐ No ☐ Yes
- Months I earned over the Trial Work amount (best count): ____
- My 9th Trial Work month (if used): _____
- My phase estimate: ☐ Phase 1 ☐ Phase 2 ☐ Phase 3 ☐ EXR safety-net position ☐ SSI road (Chapter 3)
- Next chapter I'll read: _____
- ☐ I will ask for my BPQY to confirm this.

Cheat Sheet — Phase Finder

- **SSI only?** No phases. Your payment adjusts monthly — Chapter 3.
- **Worked, but fewer than 9 months over $1,270 (2027)?** Phase 1 — Protected. Full check during Trial Work months.
- **All 9 used, inside 36 months after?** Phase 2 — Adjusting. At/below $1,770 (2027) = paid; above = paused. First over-SGA month + 2 more = grace months, still paid.
- **EPE done, still earning over SGA?** Phase 3 — Independent.

- **Benefits stopped for work in the last 5 years?** EXR can restart them — Scenario 6.
- **Only SSA has the official count.** Ask for your **BPQY**.

Go Deeper

- Justice in Aging (webinar): Social Security Benefits for Older Adults
- Justice in Aging: Changes to SSI/SSDI Rules for Disabled Applicants and Beneficiaries

The Phase Walkthroughs — Your Guided Path

Chapters 2 and 3 teach the rules. These walkthroughs put the rules in order — the way a good benefits counselor would walk you through your phase in person, step by step. Find your phase above, then live in your walkthrough until your phase changes.

How Employment Networks work, honestly: an EN's whole job is opening doors for you. But hear this clearly: **Phase 1 help gets you started. It cannot get you hired.** Your EN opens doors — job links, fairs, career-center connections, benefits answers. Walking through them is your part, in every phase.

On SSI only? Skip to **The SSI Monthly Path** below — your road is the monthly math, not phases. **On both SSI and SSDI?** Follow both tracks: the SSDI phases for your SSDI check, the SSI path for your SSI payment.

Walkthrough — Phase 1: Protected (Trial Work Period)

You are here if… your BPQY (or your best count) shows **fewer than 9 Trial Work months used** — including zero. This is the testing ground: full SSDI checks while you try work.

What is protected: your full SSDI payment, no matter what you earn, during Trial Work months. Your Medicare. Your Ticket's medical-review protection (Chapter 7) while you make progress.

What changes: only your Trial Work month count. A month uses one month when gross pay tops **$1,270** (2027) or self-employment passes 80 hours.

Your job in this phase — in order:

1. **Before you start:** assign your Ticket and have your BWIA session (Easy Order, Stop 1). Get your BPQY so your count is real.
2. **When you get the job:** report starting work to SSA (Easy Order, Stop 2). Start the pay-stub folder and the work-expense folder the same week.
3. **Every month:** run the Monthly Routine (below). Mark your Trial Work Counter.
4. **Apply like it matters:** same-day applications, follow-ups, interviews (Part 4). Your Employment Network sends leads — you land jobs.
5. **Around month 6–7 of 9:** book a BWIA session to plan Phase 2 before it arrives.

Tracker — Trial Work Month Counter (shade a box for each month you earned over $1,270 and write the month and year under it; copy your BPQY count first)

1 ☐	2 ☐	3 ☐	4 ☐	5 ☐	6 ☐	7 ☐	8 ☐	9 ☐
____	____	____	____	____	____	____	____	____

Letters SSA may send in this phase: a work-activity letter when you report (routine — answer it), your BPQY (gold — file it). See the Letter Decoder.

If this happens… - Raise offered → wonderful — during the TWP it cannot touch your check. Still run it through Chapter 22 so Phase 2 doesn't surprise you. - Job ends → report the end; unused Trial Work months simply stay unused. Keep looking (Scenario 12 if it stings).

What to say — asking your Employment Network for leads

> "I'm in Phase 1 with [number] Trial Work months left. I'm looking for [job titles]. Please send me matched leads and fair dates for [my area] — I'll apply the same day they land."

Before you move on ☐ My counter matches my BPQY ☐ My reporting routine is automatic ☐ I know my EPE start month (the month after my 9th Trial Work month) ☐ I have a plan for Phase 2 earnings around the SGA line.

Next phase preview: Phase 2 — Adjusting. Your check starts moving with your earnings, month by month, for 36 months. It is manageable — thousands do it — and Chapter 2 maps it.

Walkthrough — Phase 2: Adjusting (Extended Period of Eligibility)

You are here if… all 9 Trial Work months are used and you're inside the **36 months** that began the month after. Your BPQY shows your EPE dates — copy them into My Numbers.

What is protected: your eligibility. Any month your countable earnings are at or below SGA (**$1,770** in 2027; $2,950 blind), you're paid. Above SGA, that month pauses — after cessation + grace. Earnings alone cannot terminate you during the EPE. Medicare continues (at least 93 months past the TWP).

What changes: your check, month to month. Planning replaces coasting: deductions (Chapter 4) now have cash value.

Your job in this phase — in order:

1. **Know your two dates:** cessation month (first over-SGA month, if it's happened) and whether grace months are used.

2. **Every month:** run the Monthly Routine and log the month in the EPE Tracker below — gross, deductions, countable, paid or paused.
3. **Claim every deduction** with receipts (Chapter 4). A claimed $110 of IRWE kept a whole check payable in Scenario 4.
4. **Before any raise or hours change:** Chapter 22 check first, accept second.
5. **If a review form arrives:** the form gives you 15 days to return it, deductions and UWA/income-averaging claims included before they decide (Scenario 5).

Tracker — EPE Month-by-Month SGA Log (one row for every month of your EPE — all 36 months are printed here; if you fill them up or need a fresh copy, just print these pages again)

Month	Gross	Deductions	Countable	Over $1,770?	Check paid?

Letters SSA may send in this phase: work review forms (answer fully, on time), benefit change notices when a month pauses or restarts (check the math against your log before worrying), overpayment notices if reporting slipped (Scenario 1).

If this happens… - A month goes over SGA → Scenario 5. Paused ≠ terminated. - Job ends because of your disability → your EPE may still protect you; if benefits later end for work, EXR (Phase 3 walkthrough) is the way back. - You want steadier income → a slightly-lower-hours job under the line can pay more in total than an over-line job that pauses checks. Run both totals with your counselor.

What to say — calling SSA about a paused month

> "I'm in my Extended Period of Eligibility. My countable earnings for [month] were [amount] after the deductions I'm reporting. Can you confirm whether that month is payable, and tell me what my record shows for my EPE end date?"

Before you move on ☐ My log is current ☐ I know my EPE end month ☐ I know my EXR deadline if benefits end (5 years from the stop) ☐ My Medicare end-of-premium-free date is on My Numbers.

Next phase preview: Phase 3 — Independent. Cash benefits have ended because of earnings. The safety net doesn't vanish — it changes shape: EXR for 5 years, Medicare for years more.

Walkthrough — Phase 3: Independent (Benefits Ended Because of Earnings)

You are here if… your SSDI cash benefits ended because of work — after the EPE, while earning above SGA. Congratulations is the right word: you out-earned the benefit. This walkthrough keeps your safety net oiled.

What is protected: Expedited Reinstatement for 5 years from the month benefits ended — restart without a new application if your disability stops you working at SGA level, with up to 6 months of provisional payments while SSA decides (Chapter 2). **Medicare:** premium-free Part A for at least 93 months after your TWP ended. After 24 months of reinstated payments (if you ever use EXR), you earn a **fresh Trial Work Period and a fresh 5-year EXR window**.

What changes: no monthly check to protect — instead, two dates to guard: your **EXR deadline** and your **Medicare dates**. Put both on My Numbers and on a calendar.

Your job in this phase — in order:

1. Write down your EXR deadline (benefits-end month + 5 years) where future-you will see it.
2. Keep Part B (and Part D) enrolled and paid — lapsing is expensive to undo.
3. If your premiums get hard to afford, get screened for a Medicare Savings Program (Chapter 8) — higher income doesn't always mean no help.

4. Keep working, growing, saving — ABLE and retirement saving are yours now (Chapter 9).
5. **If work becomes impossible because of your disability:** Scenario 6, immediately — EXR is a request you make when you need it, inside the window.

Tracker — Phase 3 Dates

Date to guard	Mine
Benefits ended (month/year)	
EXR deadline (end + 5 years)	
Premium-free Part A ends (at least 93 months after TWP)	
Part B premium amount & due date	

Letters SSA may send in this phase: Medicare premium notices (pay them; ask about Savings Programs), an annual statement (file it). An EXR decision letter only if you file — answer any follow-up fast.

If this happens… - Hours cut / laid off but you can still work → unemployment rules are in Chapter 23; your EXR window only matters if disability is what stops SGA work. - You get a big raise → no benefit math left to break. This is the destination the whole road was built for.

What to say — if you ever need EXR (the full script is in Scenario 6)

> "My SSDI stopped because of work in [month/year]. My condition has worsened and I can no longer work at the substantial level. I want to request Expedited Reinstatement."

Before you "move on" — you don't graduate out of the net; you carry it. ☐ EXR deadline calendared ☐ Medicare protected ☐ I know Scenario 6 exists and where it is.

The SSI Monthly Path — Your Parallel Walkthrough

No phases, no Trial Work months — your road is a monthly rhythm. It has four stretches; you may move back and forth between them as life changes, and that's normal.

Stretch 1 — First paycheck. Report by the 6th (Chapter 5). The formula (ignore $20, ignore $65, count half) means your total always rises (Scenario 3). Students: SEIE first (Scenario 8). Start the stub folder and expense folder now.

Stretch 2 — Steady work. Monthly Routine every month. Claim deductions (Chapter 4) — IRWE, or BWE if you're blind (dollar-for-dollar). Watch your balance on the 1st against the $2,000 resource line; route savings into ABLE or a PASS (Part 2, Easy Order).

Stretch 3 — Higher earnings, cash reaches $0. If **earnings alone** did it, **1619(b)** keeps your Medicaid and your SSI status — no signup, it's automatic, but know your state's earnings threshold exists (your counselor can look it up). If unearned income (like

unemployment) did it, 1619(b) does NOT apply — Chapter 23 and Scenario 9. Payments can restart in any month earnings drop — you're suspended, not terminated, while earnings are the reason.

Stretch 4 — Saving with accounts. ABLE for disability-cost savings (first $100,000 protected), PASS for a priced work goal, and matched savings through an Individual Development Account (IDA) if a local program exists. The Easy Order (Part 2) puts each one at the right moment.

If this happens… a non-work problem stops payments (missed review, unreported resource) → the 12-month clock starts: **suspended up to 12 months → terminated → new application.** Act in month one (Chapter 3). A raise is offered → Scenario 4: on SSI, the answer is almost always "take it, report it."

Your job on this path, always: report by the 6th · keep stubs · mind the 1st-of-month balance · claim deductions · call before big changes.

Self-employed or gig work instead of (or besides) a paycheck? Your stretches are the same — but the counting runs on net earnings and hours. Read Chapter 24 and keep the NESE log (Appendix E-11). SSDI readers: the phase walkthroughs above are your track; Chapter 24 plugs into every phase.

Your Monthly Routine — The Habit Loop

Print this page. Same loop, every month you work, whatever your phase or path.

1. **Payday** → photograph the pay stub; file it in the folder.
2. **Report wages** → by your deadline (SSI 6th · SSDI 10th) using your chosen method. **Get the receipt.**
3. **Save the proof** → receipt goes with the stub.
4. **Update your tracker** → Trial Work Counter, EPE Log, or SSI notes. Update My Numbers if anything changed.
5. **Check your phase** → still where you thought? Anything coming (9th month? EPE end? EXR window)?
6. **One growth action** → apply to one better job, ask about one training, claim one deduction you missed, add one dollar to the ABLE/PASS. Small, monthly, compounding.

Six steps, maybe 30 minutes. This loop is what "keeping your net" actually looks like.

Stop and Get One-on-One Help — The Red-Flag List

This book walks you through the standard path on your own. These situations are NOT standard. Stop and get one-on-one help — your Employment Network, a WIPA project, or the Help Line (1-866-968-7842) — before you act:

- ☐ An overpayment you **dispute** — or any letter whose deadline is **under 30 days away**

- ☐ You receive **both SSI and SSDI** and the two programs' letters seem to contradict each other
- ☐ A **medical review (CDR)** notice or any medical cessation decision
- ☐ Anything about **trusts, inheritances, settlements, or a lump sum** arriving
- ☐ A **workers' comp settlement** is on the table (it changes SSDI math)
- ☐ Your **Medicaid or Medicare** gets a termination notice
- ☐ You're told you were **never eligible**, or fraud is mentioned — ever
- ☐ **Unfiled back taxes**, or self-employment income while you receive **both SSDI and SSI** (Chapter 24)
- ☐ Anything you don't understand with a deadline attached

Everything else in this book, you can do yourself — that was the point of writing it. For the rest, free one-on-one help is one call away.

Chapter 2: The SSDI Road

The SSDI road has three phases and a safety net. Here is the whole road, in order.

Step 1: The Trial Work Period (TWP) — your protected test drive

- You get **9 Trial Work months** inside a rolling 60-month window. They do **not** have to be in a row.
- During a Trial Work month, you keep your **full SSDI check, no matter how much you earn** — as long as you report your work and your disabling condition continues.
- In **2027**, a month counts as a Trial Work month if your gross earnings top **$1,270** — or, if you're self-employed, you work more than **80 hours** in the month (or your net earnings top the same amount).
- Social Security looks at gross earnings during the TWP. Deductions like work expenses (Chapter 4) do **not** apply yet — they matter later, in the EPE.
- Practical tip: **track every work month yourself** (a notebook or phone note: month, employer, gross pay). Ask for a receipt every time you report earnings — SSA's reporting systems can produce one. Your own records are gold if a question ever comes up.

Step 2: The Extended Period of Eligibility (EPE) — 36 months of adjusting

- Your EPE starts the month **after** your 9th Trial Work month. Its first 36 months run whether or not you work in them — the clock does not pause.
- Each month, Social Security compares your **countable earnings** (gross pay minus approved deductions — Chapter 4) to **SGA — Substantial Gainful Activity: $1,770 a month in 2027** for non-blind beneficiaries, **$2,950** if you're blind.
- Month at or below SGA → your check is **paid**. Month above SGA → your check is **paused (suspended), not terminated**. During the EPE, earnings alone cannot terminate your benefits.
- **Grace period:** the first month Social Security finds you worked above SGA is called your cessation month. You are still paid for that month **and the two months after it** — three paid months to land on your feet.
- If your earnings drop back to SGA or below during the EPE, your benefits **start again for those months without a new application**.
- At some point Social Security may do a **Work Activity Review**: you'll get a form (SSA-821-BK for wage work, SSA-820-BK if self-employed) asking about your job, pay, and any help you get at work. Fill it in honestly and on time — you

usually have about 20 days — and keep a copy. These reviews are exactly where deductions like IRWE and subsidy get claimed (Chapter 4).

Step 3: After the EPE — and the net beneath you

If you keep earning above SGA after the EPE ends, cash benefits end. Even then:

- **Medicare continues.** Your premium-free Medicare Part A runs for **at least 93 months (7 years, 9 months) after your Trial Work Period**, even if cash benefits stop because of earnings — as long as your disabling condition continues. Part B and Part D can continue too if you stay enrolled and pay those premiums. (Chapter 8 covers help paying them.)
- **Expedited Reinstatement (EXR)** — the way back, for **5 years** after benefits end because of work. If your disability stops you from working at the SGA level, you can ask Social Security to restart your benefits **without a brand-new application**. The basic requirements, in plain words: you are not working at SGA level in the month you ask; your condition — the same as, or related to, the one you got benefits for — keeps you from SGA-level work; you stopped working above SGA within the last 60 months; and you sign a statement (Form SSA-371) certifying your condition. The local office must explain the choice between EXR and a new application before you decide — ask them to.

- While SSA decides, you can receive **up to 6 months of provisional payments**. If EXR is denied, provisional payments usually do **not** have to be paid back — unless you knew, or should have known, you weren't eligible. Be straight in the application.
- **The EXR payoff most people never hear about:** once you've received **24 months of reinstated payments** (they don't have to be in a row), you earn a **brand-new Trial Work Period, a new EPE, and a fresh 5-year EXR window**. The whole road opens again.

DIY steps — walking the SSDI road

1. Count your Trial Work months (Find Your Phase, above) and write them down.
2. Report every job and every earnings change (Chapter 5) — and keep your pay stubs.
3. Before month 7 of your TWP, book a free BWIA session and plan your EPE months on paper.
4. In the EPE, check your countable earnings against the SGA line every month — after deductions (Chapter 4).
5. Keep every SSA letter, in date order, in one folder.

Checklist — SSDI road

- ☐ I know my phase (or I've asked for my BPQY)
- ☐ I track my work months myself
- ☐ I report earnings on time, every time

- ☐ I know the 2027 lines: $1,270 (Trial Work month) · $1,770 / $2,950 blind (SGA)
- ☐ I know my Medicare runs at least 93 months past my Trial Work Period

What to say — asking SSA about your record

> "Hello, I'm calling about my SSDI record. I'd like to know how many Trial Work months I've used and the dates of my Extended Period of Eligibility. Can I also get a copy of my BPQY? I keep records of my earnings and I want my file to match."

Cheat Sheet — The SSDI Road

- **TWP:** 9 months in a rolling 60-month window. Over **$1,270**/mo (2027) or 80+ self-employment hours = one month. Full check paid, any earnings.
- **EPE:** the 36 months after the TWP. At/below **SGA $1,770** (blind **$2,950**) = paid. Above = paused, not terminated.
- **Grace:** first over-SGA month + next 2 months still paid.
- **Earnings drop in the EPE?** Benefits restart for those months — no new application.

- **After benefits end for work:** Medicare Part A premium-free for **at least 93 months** after the TWP. **EXR** within **5 years** — restart without a new application; up to **6 months** provisional pay; **24 reinstated payments** earn a fresh TWP and a fresh 5-year window.

Go Deeper

- SSA's own guide: The Red Book
- Justice in Aging (webinar): Social Security Benefits for Older Adults

Chapter 3: The SSI Road

SSI works differently from SSDI. There is no Trial Work Period and no cliff. Instead, your payment **adjusts gradually** — and the math always favors working.

The math (learn this once, use it forever)

When you earn money, Social Security:

1. Ignores the first **$20** of income.
2. Ignores the first **$65** of what you earn.
3. Counts only **half** of what's left.

Worked example (2027 figures): You earn **$400** in a month. - $400 − $20 − $65 = $315 - Half of $315 = **$157.50** — that's all that counts against you. - If you were receiving the maximum SSI payment of **$1,029**, it becomes $1,029 − $157.50 = **$871.50**. - Your total for the month: $400 + $871.50 = **$1,271.50** — instead of $1,029.

Read that again: you worked, and you have $242.50 more. There is no earnings cliff in SSI. Every paycheck leaves you with more total money than not working.

Two timing facts that prevent panic: - SSI figures out this month's income against a payment about **two months later**. A raise today doesn't shrink tomorrow's check — and a job ending takes a couple of months to fully flow through. Keep reporting anyway; the

lag is normal, not an error. - The most you can receive from SSI itself in 2027 is **$1,029** a month for an individual, **$1,544** for an eligible couple (some states add a small supplement on top).

Keeping SSI while you work — 1619(a) and 1619(b)

- While your countable income is below the point where your payment reaches $0, you simply keep receiving a smaller SSI payment as you earn. (Advocates call this situation **1619(a)**.)
- **1619(b)** is the bigger protection: if your earnings grow high enough that your SSI **cash payment reaches $0**, you can **keep your Medicaid** — and keep your SSI eligibility status — as long as: you still have your disabling condition; you received SSI in the month before; you meet the other SSI rules besides earnings; you **need Medicaid in order to work**; and your earnings stay under your **state's 1619(b) threshold** (thresholds are set by state and updated yearly — ask your counselor for yours). If your countable income later falls, cash payments can start again automatically — no new application. Keep reporting your earnings the whole time; your status stays alive only if SSA can see you.
- ⚠️ **The "but for" watch-out — important.** 1619(b) protects you when **earnings alone** pushed your payment to $0. If what pushed you over was **unearned income** — unemployment benefits, a spouse's income, or too much in resources — **1619(b) does NOT apply.** (Scenario 9 walks through the unemployment case.) If you're receiving unemployment or other unearned income and working, get a benefits check before you assume your Medicaid is safe.

Resources — the $2,000 line

SSI counts what you own, measured on the **first day of the month**. The limit is **$2,000** for an individual, **$3,000** for a couple. Things that do **not** count include: the home you live in, household goods, one automobile (in most cases), burial spaces, **burial funds up to $1,500**, money in a **PASS plan** (Chapter 10), money in an **ABLE account up to $100,000** (Chapter 9), back payments from SSI/SSDI for 9 months after you receive them, and tax refunds including the Earned Income Tax Credit for 12 months.

Watch-out — the last-day paycheck trap: if a paycheck lands on the last day of the month and pushes your bank balance over $2,000 on the first day of the next month, that can break the resource rule. Many people pay rent on the last day of the month for exactly this reason. Ask your counselor if this applies to you.

If your SSI stops for a non-work reason, know the real sequence: payments are **suspended for up to 12 months**. If the problem isn't fixed within those 12 months, eligibility **ends (terminates)** — and getting SSI again means a **brand-new application** and a new determination. It is not an automatic restart. (Work-related stops are different — see EXR in Chapter 2 and 1619(b) above.) If you get a suspension notice, act on it in the first month, not the eleventh.

Living arrangements can change your payment

SSI assumes housing has value. If you live in someone else's household and pay nothing toward your shelter — rent and utilities — your payment can be cut by about **one-third** (in 2027, to $686 for an individual). Help with rent or utilities from someone else can also count as income in some situations. **Food no longer counts:** since September 30, 2024, SSA does not count food someone gives you — groceries or meals from family, friends, or a pantry do not lower your SSI. (Cash or a gift card handed to you for food is different — SSA counts that as income.) **The fix is paperwork, not worry:** pay your fair share of the shelter costs, or put a simple written rental agreement in place. Ask your Employment Network or a WIPA counselor to look at your living arrangement before it surprises you.

Students: the Student Earned Income Exclusion (SEIE)

If you're **under 22 and regularly attending school**, Social Security can exclude up to **$2,500 a month** of your earnings, up to **$10,080 a year** (2027), before any of the other math happens — the SEIE comes **first**, ahead of the $20 and $65 exclusions. Many working students keep their full SSI payment. Scenario 8 shows it in action.

DIY steps — the SSI road

1. Learn your math with your own numbers (use the example above as the template).

2. Report earnings **monthly** (Chapter 5) and keep every pay stub.
3. Watch the first-of-the-month bank balance against the $2,000 line.
4. If you save toward anything, use the protected tools in Part 2 (ABLE, PASS).
5. Tell SSA — and your Employment Network, if you have one — about changes in living arrangements, other income, or resources before they become letters.

Checklist — SSI road

- ☐ I can do my own payment math ($20, then $65, then half)
- ☐ I know my payment adjusts about two months behind my earnings
- ☐ I know the resource limit: $2,000 / $3,000 (couple), counted on the 1st
- ☐ I understand 1619(b) Medicaid protection — and the "but for" watch-out
- ☐ Students: I know the SEIE numbers ($2,500/mo, $10,080/yr in 2027)

Cheat Sheet — The SSI Road

- **Math:** ignore $20, ignore $65 of earnings, count half the rest. Work always raises your total.
- **2027 maximums:** $1,029 individual / $1,544 couple.

- **1619(b):** earnings alone take your cash to $0 → Medicaid can continue (state threshold applies). Unearned income over the line → 1619(b) does **not** apply.
- **Resources:** $2,000 / $3,000 on the 1st of the month. Home, one car, burial funds to $1,500, PASS money, and ABLE money to $100,000 don't count.
- **Non-work stop:** 12 months suspended → terminated → **new application**. Act early.
- **SEIE (under 22, in school):** $2,500/mo and $10,080/yr excluded, applied first.

Go Deeper

- Justice in Aging (webinar): Supplemental Security Income (SSI) Basics
- Justice in Aging: FAQ: Supplemental Security Income (SSI)
- Justice in Aging: SSI 101: A Guide for Advocates
- Justice in Aging: Supplemental Security Income (SSI): In-Kind Support Rules

Chapter 4: Deductions That Lower What Counts

In the EPE (and for SSI payments), Social Security doesn't always judge you on your gross pay. Certain costs and supports can be **subtracted first** — and a lower countable number can keep your check alive. These tools only work if you **claim them, document them, and tell SSA before decisions are made.** Keep receipts for everything.

IRWE — Impairment-Related Work Expenses

Costs you pay out of pocket, because of your disability, that you need in order to work. The three-question test: (1) Is it related to my disability? (2) Do I need it to work? (3) Did I pay for it myself (not reimbursed)? If yes to all three, it may be deductible.

Examples that often qualify: specialized transportation or taxis when your disability prevents regular transit; attendant care that helps you get ready or work; assistive technology and devices; certain medications and medical services you pay for (including co-pays); a service animal's costs; vehicle modifications; job coaching you pay for. Big one-time items can sometimes be spread (prorated) across months — ask your counselor how to time a large purchase.

The Big IRWE List — What People Actually Claim

The examples above are just the start. Here is the full list, taken from Social Security's own Red Book — its IRWE chapter and its table of deductible and non-deductible examples. Most people who work are already paying for two or three things on this list and claiming none of them.

> **The tests — an expense counts only if ALL of these are true:**
>
> - It helps you work.
> - You need it because of a physical or mental impairment.
> - **You** pay for it, and nobody reimburses you — not Medicare, Medicaid, private insurance, your employer, or an Employment Network.
> - The cost is "reasonable" — the normal charge for that item or service in your community.

Where IRWE works:

- **SSDI:** SSA subtracts IRWE from your gross earnings before testing them against SGA ($1,770 / $2,950 in 2027). This is the deduction that can pull a paycheck that looks over SGA back under it.
- **SSI:** SSA excludes IRWE from your earned income when figuring your monthly payment.

- It does **not** matter if you also use the item outside of work. A hearing aid you wear all day still counts, because you need it to work.
- General rule: you must be working in the month you pay. In some situations SSA can deduct amounts paid just before you start or just after you stop work.
- Keep every receipt. SSA decides claim by claim — a doctor's note explaining why you need the item to work makes approval far more likely.

Medications and medical care you pay for

- Prescription drugs that control your disabling condition — your copays count
- Over-the-counter drugs prescribed for your disabling condition
- Anti-convulsant (seizure) medication
- Antidepressant medication
- Psychotropic (mental health) medication
- Insulin and diabetic supplies you pay for out of pocket
- Blood-level monitoring (labs that track your medication or condition)
- Radiation treatment you pay for
- Chemotherapy you pay for
- Corrective surgery for a spinal disorder
- Counseling and mental-health therapy that keeps you able to work

- Physical or occupational therapy tied to your disabling condition
- Your doctor's fees for the treatments above
- Insurance deductibles you pay toward treatment of your disabling condition
- Hemp/CBD products with no more than 0.3% THC, when medically needed (federally legal since Dec. 20, 2018)

Checkups and testing tied to your condition

- Brain scans and other imaging of your disabling condition
- Electroencephalograms (EEGs)
- Diagnostic procedures used to control, treat, or evaluate your disabling condition

Medical devices and equipment

- Wheelchairs
- Dialysis equipment
- Pacemakers
- Respirators and breathing equipment
- Traction equipment
- Braces
- Hearing aids
- Artificial limbs and other prosthetics (see below)

- An electric air cleaner — unusual cases only, when a doctor verifies you need it to control a severe respiratory condition at home or work

Prosthetics

- Artificial hip
- Artificial arm
- Artificial leg
- Artificial replacement of another body part

Attendant care — help getting ready, getting there, and on the job

- An attendant who helps you at the work site
- Help bathing so you can get ready for work
- Help dressing for work
- Help cooking and eating around your workday
- Help during the trip to and from work
- Services that also happen to help your family (for example, a meal you share) — still deductible
- Paying a family member cash to help — **only** if that family member loses income by cutting back or quitting their own work to help you (example: your spouse reduces their work hours to get you ready)

Service animals

- Buying a guide dog or other service animal
- Training the animal
- Food
- Licenses
- Veterinary care and vet supplies
- Travel costs for the animal's training and vet visits
- Any other cost directly tied to caring for the animal

Transportation — because your disability changes how you must travel

- Structural or operating changes to your vehicle that you need to drive to work (hand controls, lifts, ramps) — counts even if you also use the vehicle off the clock
- A driver or driver assistance you need because of your disability
- Taxis you need because of your disability (not just because no bus exists)
- Paratransit fares
- Special bus or other disability transportation services
- Mileage at SSA's approved rate, in an approved vehicle, for trips to and from work only

Home modifications (only these two setups)

- If you work **outside** the home: changes to the **outside** of your house so you can get to the street or your ride — exterior ramps, railings, pathways
- If you are **self-employed at home**: changes **inside** your home to build a workspace that fits your impairment — widening an office doorway, modifying a workroom for dexterity limits (only if you are not also deducting the same cost as a business expense)

Supplies, tools, and technology

- Expendable medical supplies: incontinence pads
- Elastic stockings
- Catheters
- Assistive technology used for work: accessibility software (screen readers, speech-to-text)
- Computer support services tied to your assistive technology
- Special tools designed around your impairment

NOT deductible — do not waste a claim on these

- The cost of the vehicle itself, modified or not (only the modifications count)
- Vehicle changes not tied to your impairment or needed to operate it (paint, pinstriping)
- Travel to get medical care

- Attendant help on non-workdays, or general housekeeping (cleaning, laundry) and shopping help
- Babysitting or care for other family members
- Paying a family member "in kind" (room and board instead of cash)
- Paying a family member who loses no income by helping — including a non-working spouse
- Routine annual physicals, routine dental exams, routine eye services unrelated to a disabling visual impairment
- Allergy treatment and other care for minor problems unrelated to your disabling condition
- Anything primarily cosmetic
- Health insurance premiums
- Software or apps unrelated to your disability and your job
- Exercise equipment (a fitness bike, for example) unless your doctor verifies it is medically necessary

Subsidy and Special Conditions

Sometimes your job is worth less than your paycheck because someone is helping you succeed:

- **Subsidy:** your employer gives extra support — extra supervision, longer breaks, removed tasks, tolerance for lower output. Social Security can subtract the value of that support from your countable earnings. SSA generally accepts your employer's stated value.

- **Special Condition:** the support comes from someone else — a job coach from an agency, for example. The value is figured from the coach's time helping you, at your rate of pay.

Social Security may ask your employer to complete a questionnaire about exactly this support. Tell your counselor if you get extra help at work — most people never claim this, and it can be the difference between "over SGA" and "under."

Blind Work Expenses (BWE) — for SSI recipients who are blind

If you receive SSI based on blindness, you have a **stronger** deduction than IRWE. Blind Work Expenses cover **any ordinary, necessary cost of earning your income** — it does not have to be related to your disability. Deductible items can include: **income and payroll taxes (including FICA)**, transportation to work, work meals, uniforms and safety shoes, childcare you pay so you can work, guide dog costs (purchase, food, vet care), training, equipment, and attendant care.

BWE is subtracted **after** the SSI "half" step in the math — so every BWE dollar comes back to you **dollar for dollar**, better than almost any other deduction. If you are blind and on SSI, claim BWE — and never let anyone file your SSI work expenses as IRWE instead; BWE is the better tool for you.

Income Averaging — smoothing out up-and-down months

If your earnings bounce around the SGA line from month to month but your work pattern is steady, Social Security can **average** your earnings over a period instead of judging each month alone. Averaging can **delay or prevent a cessation** — the decision that starts your grace months and pauses checks. It has to be raised **before** the cessation decision is made, so speak up early, at the first sign of a work review.

Unsuccessful Work Attempt (UWA)

A job (or stretch of work) at SGA level that **ends within about 6 months because of your disability** — or because essential special help was removed — may not count against you at all. Changing jobs because your disability made the first one impossible can qualify. Like income averaging, a UWA can delay or prevent a cessation, and like averaging it must be claimed **before** the cessation decision. Tell your counselor about every job that didn't last, even short ones — they may be worth more than you think.

(Note: income averaging and UWA do not apply during an EXR Initial Reinstatement Period — Chapter 2. Different stage, different rules.)

Worked illustration

Gross pay $1,720 in a month. A paid job coach supports you for part of your hours (special condition worth $240), and you pay $125 out of pocket for disability-related transportation (IRWE). $1,720 − $240 − $125 = **$1,355 countable** — under the 2027 SGA line of $1,770. The deductions kept that month payable. (Your numbers will differ — the point is: claim them, with proof.)

The Toolkit — Every Legal Way to Lower Countable Income

Everything in this chapter, plus the exclusions built into the SSI formula itself, in one spread. Every item below is a mechanism Social Security itself publishes — there are no tricks here that SSA does not print in its own Red Book. Each item is tagged with who it covers.

- **The $20 general exclusion** — **SSI** — The first $20 of income in a month is never counted (it comes off unearned income first; any leftover applies to earnings). **The move:** automatic — but know it exists before you panic over a small check or a small pension.
- **The $65 earned exclusion, then half** — **SSI** — After the $20, the first $65 of earnings is excluded, and SSA counts only **half** of what remains. **The move:** this is why working on SSI almost always leaves you with more total money than not working. Run the formula (Chapter 3) before you turn down hours.

- **IRWE (the Big List, above)** — **SSI + SSDI** — Money you pay for disability items and services you need to work comes off your earnings: it lowers countable earned income for SSI, and it pulls earnings down before the SGA test for SSDI. **The move:** keep receipts all year, report the expenses, and claim them — most people never do.
- **Blind Work Expenses (BWE)** — **SSI, blind recipients only** — Any expense you need to earn your income — it does **not** have to be related to blindness (even the taxes withheld from your pay can count). SSA applies BWE after the half-exclusion, which always produces a higher SSI payment than IRWE alone. **The move:** if you are blind, claim BWE instead of IRWE for the same expense — never both for the same dollar.
- **PASS set-aside** — **SSI** (and it can create SSI eligibility alongside SSDI) — Income you set aside under an approved PASS is excluded from countable income entirely, and the saved money is excluded from resources (Chapter 10). **The move:** when a lump of income (a job, an SSDI check, a settlement earmarked for a goal) would cut your SSI, a written, approved PASS can legally reroute it toward your work goal.
- **SEIE — Student Earned Income Exclusion** — **SSI, students under 22 who regularly attend school** — SSA excludes up to **$2,500 of earnings per month, up to $10,080 per year** (2027), applied **before** the $20/$65 exclusions. **The move:** if you are a student under 22, your first dollars of pay are simply invisible to SSI — do not let anyone talk you out of a job "to protect the check."

- **Income averaging** — **SSDI (SGA decisions)** — When your earnings bounce up and down over a work period, SSA may average them across that period instead of judging the single biggest month alone. **The move:** if one overtime spike put you "over SGA," ask — in writing — for your earnings to be averaged over the whole work attempt.
- **Unsuccessful Work Attempt (UWA)** — **SSDI (and SSI at initial application)** — If you tried a job and had to stop or cut back within about 6 months because of your impairment (or because special supports were pulled), SSA can disregard those earnings in an SGA decision as if the attempt never counted against you. **The move:** a failed job try is not a benefits disaster — document why it ended (your condition, or supports removed) and report it as a UWA.
- **Employer subsidy** — **SSDI (SGA decisions; does not change the SSI payment formula)** — If your employer pays you more than your work is actually worth (extra breaks, slower pace, a co-worker's help, a job coach's support), SSA subtracts the subsidy value before the SGA test. **The move:** get the employer to state the subsidy in writing (SSA uses Form SSA-3033) — supported and sheltered work often passes SGA once the subsidy comes out.
- **Special conditions** — **SSDI (SGA decisions)** — Work done under special conditions (close supervision, a job coach on site, work in a setting arranged because of your impairment) is valued at what the work is really worth, not the paycheck

number. **The move:** same paperwork as a subsidy — the value of the special conditions comes off your earnings before SGA is judged.

The honest summary: countable income is not your paycheck. It is your paycheck **after** SSA's own published math. The people who "keep countable income down" are not hiding anything — they are claiming, in writing, every exclusion Congress already gave them.

DIY steps — claiming deductions

1. List every cost you pay to be able to work (ride, meds, gear, help, care).
2. Save every receipt; write the date and what it was for on it.
3. Tell SSA about deductions with your first month's wage report — flag them as recurring if they repeat.
4. If a Work Activity Review form arrives, list every support and expense on it.
5. Review deductions with your BWIA counselor once a year.

Checklist — deductions

- ☐ I keep receipts for everything work costs me
- ☐ Blind and on SSI? I'm claiming BWE, not IRWE
- ☐ My employer/coach supports are written down (subsidy / special condition)

- ☐ Short jobs that ended because of my disability are on my list to mention (UWA)
- ☐ My earnings bounce? I'll ask about income averaging early

Your next step: Start a "work costs" envelope or phone folder today — every receipt goes in it from now on.

Cheat Sheet — Deductions

- **IRWE:** disability-related work costs you pay → subtracted. 3 questions: disability-related? needed to work? paid by me?
- **Subsidy:** employer help → subtracted at employer's stated value. **Special condition:** coach/agency help → subtracted too.
- **BWE (SSI, blind):** any normal cost of earning money — even taxes and work meals. Subtracted after the half-step → dollar for dollar. Use BWE, never IRWE, for SSI if you're blind.
- **Income averaging:** bumpy months can be averaged — can stop a cessation. Ask early.
- **UWA:** SGA-level work that ends within ~6 months because of the disability may not count. Ask early.
- **No receipts = no deduction.** Paper (or photos of it) is everything.

Go Deeper

- SSA: The Red Book — the employment-supports chapters

Chapter 5: Reporting Your Wages

> **Do it when…** you start the job (initial report), then every month by your deadline — SSI the 6th, SSDI the 10th (Easy Order, Stops 2–3).

Reporting is the habit that protects everything else in this book. Most overpayments (Chapter 6) start as unreported or late-reported wages. The good news: it's a simple routine once you set it up.

The deadlines

- **SSI:** report each month's earnings by the **6th of the following month**.
- **SSDI (Title 2):** report work activity and earnings changes by the **10th of the following month**.
- **Get both SSI and SSDI?** Report to **both** programs — they're separate systems.
- **Self-employed?** Your reporting works differently (net earnings, tax records). Tell SSA you're self-employed at your first report and ask what they need.

How to report (pick your method and stick with it)

- **Phone:** SSA's wage-reporting line, **1-866-772-0953**, is open during the **first 6 days of each month** for reporting the prior month's wages. SSA's main line is 1-800-772-1213.
- **Online:** a my Social Security account at ssa.gov lets you report wages — but first you must make an **initial employment report** (in person, by mail, by phone, or by fax) and ask SSA to **add your employer to your account**.
- **App:** SSA's wage-reporting app also requires that initial report and permission set-up.
- **In person / by mail / by fax:** always an option at your local office.

What to report

When you start a job: your name and Social Security number, the type of benefit you receive, your employer's name, address, and phone, your supervisor's name, your start date, your pay rate and average hours, your pay dates, and your job title. After that: each month's gross earnings, and any change — raise, hours, new job, job ended. Send IRWE/BWE receipts with your first month's report and mark them if they'll recur.

The receipt rule

Federal rules say you are entitled to a **receipt** for your work reports. Ask for one every time — a stamped copy, a confirmation number, a confirmation email — and **file it with that month's pay stub**. If a question ever comes up two years from now, that folder is your defense.

Paperwork: If you want SSA to release information from your record to a person or organization you choose — an advocate, a program, a family member helping you — the consent form is **SSA-3288 — Consent for Release of Information**. If someone will formally represent you to SSA, they are named on **SSA-1696 — Claimant's Appointment of a Representative** (Appendix E). Do not sign either one casually; know who is named and what it lets them do.

DIY steps — set up your routine

1. Make your initial employment report as soon as you start (don't wait for the first paycheck).
2. Choose your monthly method (phone in the first 6 days is the simplest).
3. Put a repeating reminder on your phone for the 1st of every month.
4. Report gross earnings for the month just ended; attach deduction receipts.
5. Get the receipt. File it with the pay stubs. Done until next month.

Checklist — reporting

- ☐ Initial employment report made; employer added to my account
- ☐ I know my deadline (SSI 6th · SSDI 10th · both if I get both)
- ☐ Monthly reminder set
- ☐ Receipts filed with pay stubs
- ☐ Changes (raise, hours, job ended) reported, not just wages

Your next step: If you're working and haven't made an initial employment report, do it this week — Chapter 21 shows you the safety net that reporting protects.

What to say — your first work report

> "Hello, I'm calling to report that I've started working. I receive [SSDI / SSI / both]. My employer is [name], I started on [date], I earn [rate] for about [hours] a week, and I'm paid on [pay dates]. Please add this employer to my account so I can report wages each month, and tell me how I'll get a receipt for this report."

Cheat Sheet — Reporting

- **Deadlines:** SSI by the **6th** · SSDI by the **10th** · both programs if you get both.
- **Phone:** 1-866-772-0953 (first 6 days of the month) · SSA main 1-800-772-1213.

- **Online/app need a first step:** initial report + employer added to your account.
- **Report:** start/stop dates, rate, hours, pay dates, gross monthly earnings, changes, work expenses.
- **Always get a receipt.** File it with the pay stub.

Go Deeper

- SSA: Choose Work — Ticket to Work
- SSA: Find Help

Chapter 6: Overpayments — Don't Panic, You Have Options

An overpayment letter means Social Security believes it paid you money you weren't due — usually because wages weren't reported, weren't processed in time, or a decision about your earnings took months. It is frightening. It is also **common, explainable, and answerable**. Scenario 1 walks through a letter step by step; this chapter gives you the full set of tools.

How repayment normally works (the defaults)

If you do nothing, Social Security can recover the debt by withholding part of your check — up to **10% of an SSI payment**, or **50% of an SSDI (Title 2) payment** — until it's repaid. Those are defaults, not destiny. You have three real remedy paths, and you can use more than one.

Path 1: Appeal (reconsideration) — "the amount or the decision is wrong"

- File **Form SSA-561** within **60 days** of the notice (late filing is possible with a good reason).
- You can file online, by mail, or at your office. **Filing stops collection from your current benefits until the decision is made.**

- **On SSI?** Appealing within **10 days** of the notice date can keep your payments going at the same level while the appeal is decided. Ten days goes fast — file first, perfect it later.
- Use this when: the earnings figures are wrong, the months are wrong, you did report (show your receipts!), or the work rules in this book (deductions, UWA, income averaging, grace months) weren't applied.

Path 2: Waiver — "it wasn't my fault and I can't afford to repay"

- Ask on **Form SSA-632-BK** (it can even be completed by phone). There is **no deadline** to request a waiver — but filing within 60 days pauses collection until the decision.
- A waiver can be granted when you were **not at fault** AND one of these is true: the amount is small (debts of **$2,000 or less can often be waived verbally — just ask**, no form needed); your income and resources leave nothing extra after basic living costs; you rely on needs-based help (SSI, SNAP, Extra Help, and similar); or repaying would be unfair ("against equity and good conscience").
- "Not at fault" includes: you reported on time and SSA processed it late, or you couldn't have known the rule. Your receipt folder (Chapter 5) is your evidence.

Path 3: A payment plan you can actually afford

- If you owe the money but the default withholding is too much, ask to **change the recovery rate**. Use **Form SSA-634** (Request for Change in Overpayment Recovery Rate). If you can't repay within about **60 months** at the rate you ask for, the form asks for a full financial statement — fill it in honestly, sign it, and send it in.
- Keep paying something while your request is pending; don't just stop.

Paperwork if the first answer is still no: If reconsideration is denied and you want a judge to decide, the next paper is **HA-501 — Request for Hearing by Administrative Law Judge** — ask within **60 days** of the reconsideration decision. If a representative will handle the case, **SSA-1696** appoints them. **SSA-3288** is different: it is only your consent for SSA to release information to someone you name — it does not make that person your representative.

Two more facts worth knowing

- Debts can eventually be **written off** by SSA under its own rules when they are long-delinquent and you're not currently receiving payments — a counselor can tell you if that could ever apply to you.

- SSA generally **cannot** take an SSDI overpayment out of your SSI check (cross-program rules limit this) — another reason to have a counselor read the whole picture before you agree to anything.

What NOT to do

- **Don't ignore the letter.** Deadlines pass; defaults kick in.
- **Don't agree to a repayment amount on the phone in a panic.** You can always say: "I want to review my options first."
- **Don't pay cash or send money anywhere except through official SSA channels.**

Get free help BEFORE you respond

Call the **Ticket to Work Help Line: 1-866-968-7842** (TTY 1-866-833-2967, Mon–Fri 8am–8pm ET) for a **WIPA** referral — free, in-depth benefits counseling. Or bring the letter to **your Employment Network** — benefits advisement (BWIA) is exactly what ENs and WIPA counselors do, and overpayment letters are exactly what it's for.

Checklist — overpayment letter

- ☐ Letter opened and read: amount? months? reason given?
- ☐ My receipts and pay stubs pulled for those months
- ☐ 60-day appeal deadline written on my calendar
- ☐ Free help called before responding (WIPA or my Employment Network)

- ☐ I know my path: appeal / waiver / payment plan — or a combination

Your next step: Put the letter and your pay-stub folder in one envelope marked "SSA — answer by [60-day date]" and make the help call this week.

Cheat Sheet — Overpayments

- **Defaults if you do nothing:** withholding up to **10% (SSI)** or **50% (SSDI)** of your check.
- **Appeal:** Form SSA-561, within **60 days**. Filing pauses collection. Use it when the facts are wrong.
- **Waiver:** Form SSA-632-BK, **no deadline**; $2,000 or less → ask for the verbal administrative waiver. Not your fault + can't afford / would be unfair.
- **Payment plan:** ask to lower the rate; Form SSA-634 if you can't finish in ~60 months.
- **Free help first:** Help Line 1-866-968-7842 (WIPA) · your Employment Network (find one at choosework.ssa.gov — this book's publisher, Prestige Path Consulting, is one you can choose).

Go Deeper

- Justice in Aging (webinar): Overpayments, In-Kind Support, and Operational Impacts
- Justice in Aging: Changes to SSI & Social Security Overpayment Policies Reduce Burden of Overpayments

- Justice in Aging (webinar): Updates on SSI Overpayment Policies

Chapter 7: Medical Reviews and Your Ticket's Protection

Two different reviews exist, and mixing them up causes needless fear:

- A **work review** looks at your earnings (Chapter 2). It can happen any time you work and report.
- A **medical review (CDR — Continuing Disability Review)** looks at whether your medical condition has improved. This is the review people dread.

The Ticket protection — know it cold

While your Ticket is **assigned** to an Employment Network **and you are making timely progress** toward your work plan, **Social Security will not start a medical CDR.** Choosing to try work through Ticket to Work pauses the medical-review risk that stops so many people from trying at all.

What "timely progress" means, in plain terms: at each review point (about every 12 months), Social Security looks for some mix of work and/or education moving you toward your plan's goal. Your IWP sets the goal; steady effort counts. If life interrupts — health, family, a lost job — tell your EN right away. You can ask for your Ticket to go **inactive** for a while instead of losing the relationship; know that inactive status does **not** carry the CDR protection, and you can also unassign and reassign your Ticket (a 90-day window keeps protections in place while you find a new EN).

If a medical review does happen: SSA has to show real medical improvement related to your ability to work before benefits can be stopped on medical grounds — the burden is on them, and most reviews do not end benefits. If you ever receive a medical cessation decision, **appeal deadlines are short, and appealing within about 10 days can keep payments going while the appeal is decided.** That letter is a "get help today" letter (see the Letter Decoder after the Contents).

Paperwork: A CDR packet usually turns on **SSA-454-BK — Continuing Disability Review Report** (edition 09-2026) — the long report about your condition, treatment, and recent work. If SSA decides your disability ceased for medical reasons, do not use the general appeal form: the cessation appeal is **SSA-789 — Request for Reconsideration - Disability Cessation Right to Appear** (edition 04-2026). Ask the same day about **SSA-792 — Statutory Benefit Continuation Election Statement** (edition 07-2026), the paper that elects to keep benefits going while a cessation is appealed — SSA must **receive** it within **15 calendar days** of the date on the cessation notice, so do not mail it on day 14 and hope. Your updated medical and work story goes on **SSA-3441-BK — Disability Report - Appeal** (edition 07-2026), and **SSA-827 — Authorization to Disclose Information to the Social Security Administration (SSA)** (edition 06-2024) lets your doctors send records to SSA. If reconsideration is denied, **HA-501** asks for an Administrative Law Judge hearing.

Checklist — reviews and protection

- ☐ My Ticket is assigned and my IWP is signed

- ☐ I know the difference: work review = earnings; medical CDR = health
- ☐ While assigned + making progress, SSA won't start a medical CDR
- ☐ If my situation changes, I'll tell my EN before a review does
- ☐ Any cessation letter = same-week call for help; appeals can keep payments going if filed fast

Your next step: If your Ticket isn't assigned yet, that's the first move to make — choose an Employment Network at choosework.ssa.gov or through the Help Line (1-866-968-7842) and assign it. Assignment is what turns this protection on.

Cheat Sheet — Reviews & Ticket Protection

- **Work review:** about earnings. Normal when you work. Answer forms on time (~20 days).
- **Medical CDR:** about health improvement. SSA must prove improvement.
- **Ticket assigned + timely progress = no new medical CDR.** That's the deal at the heart of Ticket to Work.
- **Cessation letter?** Appeal immediately — filed within ~10 days, payments can continue during the appeal.

Go Deeper

- SSA: Choose Work · Find Help

Chapter 8: Your Health Coverage While You Work

For many people, the real question isn't the paycheck — it's "what happens to my health coverage?" Here are the protections, by program.

Medicare (SSDI)

- Premium-free **Part A continues for at least 93 months after your Trial Work Period**, even if cash benefits stop for earnings (Chapter 2).
- **Part B and Part D** can continue as long as you stay enrolled and pay the premiums. Do not let Part B lapse casually — getting it back later can cost penalties.
- After the 93 months, some people can buy Part A and stay covered. Exact end dates for extended Medicare are personal — a counselor (or the Medicare Wizard tool a counselor can run with you) can pin down yours.

Help paying Medicare premiums — Medicare Savings Programs

> **Do it when…** your premiums get hard to afford — you can apply at your state Medicaid office any time, not just at a crisis (Easy Order, Stop 3).

State-run programs that pay some or all of your Medicare costs, based on income. In plain terms:

- **QMB** (income up to about 100% of the federal poverty level): pays Part A and Part B premiums, deductibles, and co-insurance — the biggest help.
- **SLMB** (up to about 120%): pays your Part B premium.
- **QI** (up to about 135%): pays your Part B premium (not available if you're on Medicaid).
- **QDWI** (up to about 200%, with modest savings): helps pay the Part A premium for people whose premium-free Part A ended because of work.

Getting one of these programs also automatically qualifies you for **Extra Help (Low-Income Subsidy)** with Part D drug costs. **Apply at your state Medicaid office** — many people who qualify never apply because nobody told them. Ask your counselor to screen you; your earnings level can move you between programs as it changes, and that's normal.

Paperwork: Extra Help itself is applied for with **SSA-1020 / i1020** — online, by phone, or at an office (there is no printable paper form to fax; Chapter 8's trap is in Appendix E). If SSA denies Extra Help, ends it, or sets it at an amount you dispute, the appeal is **SSA-1021 — Appeal of Determination for Extra Help with Medicare Prescription Drug Plan Costs** — and this one is the exception to the local-office rule: mail it to the address printed on the form. If your Part B or Part D premium includes a surcharge (IRMAA) based on an older, higher-income tax year, and your

income dropped because you **stopped work** or **reduced your hours**, **SSA-44 — Medicare Income-Related Monthly Adjustment Amount - Life-Changing Event** asks SSA to lower the surcharge.

Medicaid (SSI and workers)

- On SSI, Medicaid usually comes with the benefit — and **1619(b)** (Chapter 3) can keep it after cash payments reach $0.
- Lost SSI for a reason other than earnings — for example, an SSDI check starting or growing? Other Medicaid protections exist for former SSI recipients in exactly those situations. If a Medicaid termination letter arrives, **you can request a fair hearing**, and the state is supposed to check all Medicaid categories before ending your coverage. Ask for that check in writing.
- Many states run **Medicaid Buy-In** programs: workers with disabilities can buy Medicaid coverage even at earnings too high for other categories. If your earnings outgrow 1619(b), ask about your state's Buy-In before assuming coverage is gone.
- In states that expanded Medicaid, adults under 65 within the income limit can qualify on income alone (no resource test) — this can bridge gaps, including for a spouse in a couple where one partner's work ended the other's SSI.

Checklist — health coverage

- ☐ I know my Medicare Part A runs at least 93 months past my TWP
- ☐ I've been screened for a Medicare Savings Program (QMB/SLMB/QI/QDWI)
- ☐ On SSI, I know whether 1619(b) or a Buy-In protects my Medicaid
- ☐ A coverage-termination letter = fair-hearing rights; I'll ask for help fast

Your next step: At your next BWIA session, ask one question: "Have I been screened for help paying my Medicare premiums?"

Cheat Sheet — Health Coverage

- **Medicare Part A:** premium-free for **at least 93 months** after the TWP. Keep Part B/D enrolled and paid.
- **Medicare Savings Programs:** QMB (~100% of poverty) pays A+B costs · SLMB (~120%) and QI (~135%) pay the Part B premium · QDWI (~200%) helps with Part A. They also unlock Part D **Extra Help**.
- **Medicaid:** 1619(b) keeps it when earnings zero out SSI cash. Buy-In programs cover many workers above that. Termination letter → fair hearing + "check all categories."

Go Deeper

- Justice in Aging (fact sheet): Open Enrollment for 2027 Coverage through Medicare & the Marketplace
- Justice in Aging (issue brief): Health Care Bills and Dually Eligible Individuals
- Justice in Aging (webinar): Medicaid Community Engagement Requirements and Older Adults: FAQ

> **You can do this — Part 1 done.** You now know the map: your phase, your road, your deductions, your deadlines, and your protections. The rules were the scary part. From here, the book gets practical: money tools first, then the job itself.

Part 2 — Accounts and Plans That Protect Your Money



"How do I save anything if SSI only lets me keep $2,000?" This part is the answer: the accounts and plans the rules themselves built for you.

The Easy Order — When Everything Happens

Every account and incentive in this book has a right moment. Here is the whole path in five stops — nothing takes more than 3 steps. (This page is also a tear-out: Appendix A-8.)

STOP 1 — Before You Start Working

- **my Social Security account** — your online window into your record; how you'll report wages and see your status. 1. Go to ssa.gov and choose "my Social Security." 2. Create your sign-in. 3. Check that your benefit and address look right.
- **BPQY** — the SSA printout that proves your phase (Trial Work months, EPE dates). 1. Call SSA (1-800-772-1213) or visit your office. 2. Ask for a "Benefits Planning Query — BPQY." 3. File it; copy the numbers into My Numbers.
- **Ticket to Work assignment + BWIA session** — assign **before** you start, so medical-review protection and your plan line up from day one. 1. Choose an Employment Network (directory at choosework.ssa.gov, or call the Help Line — Prestige Path Consulting, this book's publisher, is one of the ENs listed there). 2. Assign your Ticket and sign your Individual Work Plan. 3. Book your free BWIA session.

- **ABLE account** — open as soon as you're eligible: **before** savings build toward the $2,000 SSI limit, and **before** any lump sum or inheritance arrives, if you can. 1. Confirm disability began before age 46. 2. Pick your state program. 3. Open online and make a first small deposit.
- **PASS** — if you already have a work goal, start the paperwork **now**: the plan must be **approved before** SSA will set money aside for you, and money saved before approval may still count. 1. Write the one-sentence goal. 2. Price it item by item. 3. Draft Form SSA-545-BK with your counselor.

Choosing an Employment Network — 5 facts before you sign

- **It's free, and it's your choice.** Assigning your Ticket costs nothing, ever. No EN can charge you for Ticket to Work services.
- **You pick — and you can change.** Compare two or three ENs: What services do they actually offer? Do they do benefits advisement, or only job placement? If it isn't working, you can unassign your Ticket and choose a different EN. Your benefits are never at risk for switching.
- **An EN works for you.** You sign an Individual Work Plan together — your goals, in your words, with the services you'll receive spelled out. If the plan doesn't say it, ask for it in writing.

- **Find them officially:** the Find Help directory at **choosework.ssa.gov/findhelp**, or call the **Help Line (1-866-968-7842)** and ask for ENs and WIPA projects near you.
- **WIPA is the other free door.** WIPA projects do in-depth benefits counseling without job placement — a good first stop if your only question is "what happens to my check if I work?"

STOP 2 — When You Get the Job

- **Tell SSA you started** — employer name, address, start date, pay rate, hours, pay dates. 1. Make the initial employment report (phone, office, mail, or fax). 2. Ask SSA to add the employer to your account. 3. Get a receipt.
- **Students under 22:** tell SSA you're in school — that's how the **Student Earned Income Exclusion** (up to $2,500/mo, $10,080/yr in 2027) gets applied to you. 1. Report your school and hours. 2. Mention "SEIE" by name. 3. Keep reporting wages monthly.
- **Start your work-expense folder** — IRWE and Blind Work Expense receipts count **from your first work expenses**. Save them from day one; a deduction you didn't save the receipt for doesn't exist. 1. One envelope or phone folder. 2. Every receipt, dated. 3. Hand them in with your first wage report.

- **Set up wage reporting** — pick ONE method (online, phone, or mail) and keep the proof every month. 1. Choose the method. 2. Put the deadline on your phone (SSI 6th · SSDI 10th). 3. File each receipt with its pay stub.

STOP 3 — First Paycheck, and Every Month After

- **Run the Monthly Routine** (Part 1): payday → report → save the stub → update the tracker → check your phase → one growth action.
- **Individual Development Account (IDA — matched savings)** — if a local program exists and you have a savings goal, open it now that earnings are real. 1. Ask 211 or your counselor what's open near you. 2. Enroll and name the goal. 3. Set the monthly deposit.
- **Medicare Savings Programs / Extra Help** — if your premiums get hard to afford, apply at your **state Medicaid office**. You can apply **any time** — don't wait for a crisis. 1. Ask for a Medicare Savings Program screening. 2. Apply for the level you fit (QMB/SLMB/QI/QDWI). 3. Tell your counselor the result.

STOP 4 — As You Grow (Raises, More Hours, Phase Edges)

- **Before a big raise:** re-check the SGA line (Scenario 4). Numbers first, accept second, report immediately.

- **1619(b)** is **NOT a signup** — if you were on SSI Medicaid, it's automatic protection when earnings zero out your cash. Just know your state's threshold exists and ask your counselor for the number.
- **ABLE-to-Work extra contributions** start when you're working and have the ABLE account — **the extra amount changes and sources differ; confirm yours with your state ABLE program.**

STOP 5 — If Things Change

- **Job ends because of your disability → EXR.** Not a pre-signup: you **ask within the 5-year window, when you need it**. Provisional payments can start while SSA decides (Scenario 6).
- **Benefits suspended inside the EPE → keep reporting, keep the trackers.** A month back under the line restarts payment — no new application. Reinstatement inside the EPE is simpler than people fear.
- **Overpayment letter → Scenario 1, deadlines first.** Appeal (60 days), waiver, or payment plan — with free help before you respond.

Timing traps, plainly: PASS approval comes before set-asides count · ABLE works best opened before the lump sum lands · Expense receipts count from day one — not from when you learned about them · Ticket assignment before starting work is what lines up your protections.

Chapter 9: ABLE Accounts

> **Do it when…** you're eligible — ideally before savings build toward the $2,000 SSI limit and before any lump sum arrives (Easy Order, Stop 1).

An **ABLE account** is a savings account for disability-related expenses, created by federal law (Section 529A) and run by state programs. Think of it as a protected savings jar: money in it is meant to be saved and spent on the costs of living with a disability — including work costs.

How it works

- **Who qualifies:** your disability began **before age 46** (that age rose from 26 — the expansion took effect **January 1, 2026**). You can qualify through your Social Security/SSI disability status, or with a signed statement from a doctor that your condition meets the disability standard.
- **Who can put money in:** anyone — you, family, friends, even a trust. Money other people deposit is **not counted as your income** for SSI. Money you deposit from your own income still counts as income in the month you earned it (the protection is on the savings side).
- **Yearly limit:** total contributions from all sources are capped each year (the cap was **$20,000 in 2026** — confirm the current year's cap with your state ABLE program).

- **The SSI resource protection:** the first **$100,000** in an ABLE account does **not** count toward SSI's $2,000 resource limit. If a balance over $100,000 pushes you over the resource limit, SSI payments are **suspended — not terminated** — your Medicaid continues, and payments can resume when the balance comes back down, even years later, with no new application.
- **What you can spend it on (Qualified Disability Expenses):** education, housing (rent, mortgage, utilities), transportation, employment training and supports, assistive technology, health and wellness, financial and legal services, funeral and burial, and basic living expenses. A rent payment made through an ABLE account doesn't reduce your SSI the way a relative paying your rent directly can — a real, legal advantage.
- **Working? Extra room:** if you work and don't have an employer retirement plan contribution, you may be able to contribute extra from your own wages above the yearly cap (the "ABLE-to-Work" rule). **The extra amount changes, and sources differ — confirm yours with your state ABLE program before counting on it.**
- **One caution:** housing money should be spent in the **same month** you take it out of the ABLE account, or it can count as a resource the next month. And after the account owner's death, a state may claim back Medicaid costs paid — something to weigh with a counselor if you're saving large amounts.

The Big ABLE List — What ABLE Money Can Pay For

ABLE is broad ON PURPOSE. Congress wrote the rule as: any expense related to living with your disability that maintains or improves your health, independence, or quality of life. The categories below are the statute's own list (Internal Revenue Code §529A) — and the statute itself says the list is **not** the whole story ("including, but not limited to"). If an expense is genuinely tied to your life with a disability, it very likely qualifies. Keep your receipts anyway — you are the record-keeper if the IRS ever asks.

Two money facts to hold while you read: money in an ABLE account does not count as an SSI resource up to **$100,000**, and withdrawals spent on the expenses below in the same month do not count as SSI income. The one warning: money taken out for **housing** must be spent in the same month it comes out, or the leftover counts as a resource the next month.

Education

- Tuition (K-12, college, trade school)
- Books and course materials
- Fees
- Tutoring
- Special education services
- Educational software and a computer for school

Housing

- Rent
- Mortgage payments
- Property taxes
- Homeowner's or renter's insurance
- Utilities — electric, gas, water, sewer, trash
- Home repairs
- Accessibility modifications to your home
- Moving costs

Transportation

- Buying a vehicle
- Vehicle loan or lease payments
- Vehicle modifications for accessibility
- Fuel
- Maintenance and insurance
- Public transit passes and fares
- Rideshare and taxi rides
- Accessible transportation services

Work: employment training and support

- Job coaching
- Vocational training

- Career counseling
- Tools and equipment for your job
- Uniforms and required work clothing
- Work-related transportation
- Costs of starting your own business

Assistive technology and personal support services

- Wheelchairs and mobility equipment
- Hearing aids
- Communication devices (including a tablet running a communication app)
- Screen readers and adaptive computer equipment
- Smart-home and environmental control technology
- Personal care attendants and in-home aides
- A paid family caregiver

Health, prevention, and wellness

- Health insurance premiums
- Copays and deductibles
- Dental care
- Vision care
- Hearing care
- Mental health services and counseling
- Prescription medications

- Therapy — physical, occupational, speech, behavioral
- Wellness and prevention programs, including a gym membership
- Long-term care services
- Medical costs insurance does not cover

Financial management and administrative services

- ABLE account fees
- Financial planning and advisor fees
- Tax preparation
- Benefits-planning help
- Trust administration costs

Legal fees

- Legal help with benefits questions
- Estate and special-needs planning
- Guardianship costs

Oversight and monitoring

- Expenses for a guardian or conservator
- Monitoring services that keep you safe and independent

Funeral and burial

- Funeral expenses

- Burial expenses

Basic living expenses — yes, really

- Food and groceries
- Clothing (including adaptive clothing)
- Personal care items
- Household goods
- Phone service

> **The sentence to remember:** ABLE is not just for "disability-looking" purchases. Congress designed it for the whole cost of a life with a disability — and daily life is most of that cost.

Steps to start

1. Confirm your disability began before age 46 (most current beneficiaries qualify).
2. Pick a program at the ABLE National Resource Center's state listing — you may enroll in another state's program if yours is inactive.
3. Open online; link your bank account.
4. Set one small automatic deposit — even $10 a month builds the habit and the protection.
5. Tell your counselor you opened it, so it goes in your plan.

Checklist — ABLE

- ☐ Disability began before age 46 (rule in effect Jan 1, 2026)
- ☐ I know the yearly contribution cap (was $20,000 in 2026 — confirm the current cap with my state program)
- ☐ First $100,000 doesn't count against SSI resources; over that = suspension, not termination; Medicaid continues
- ☐ Housing withdrawals spent the same month
- ☐ ABLE-to-Work extra amount = confirm with my state program (sources differ)

Your next step: Look up your state's ABLE program today and read its one-page summary — opening can wait until your next counseling session, knowing your program can't.

Cheat Sheet — ABLE

- Savings for disability costs; disability must have begun **before age 46**.
- Yearly contributions are capped (was $20,000 in 2026 — confirm the current cap). First **$100,000** invisible to SSI's resource limit.
- Family deposits aren't your income. ABLE growth isn't taxed when spent on disability expenses.
- Rent through ABLE doesn't cut SSI like direct family help can. Spend housing withdrawals the same month.

Go Deeper

- Justice in Aging (webinar): How ABLE Accounts Work with Supplemental Security Income (SSI)
- Justice in Aging (webinar): Topics in SSI — ABLE Accounts and Supplemental Security Income

Chapter 10: PASS — Plan to Achieve Self-Support

> **Do it when…** you have a work goal — start the paperwork before you save, because the plan must be approved before set-asides count (Easy Order, Stop 1).

A **PASS** is not a bank account. It's a **written plan, approved by Social Security**, that lets you set aside income or resources for a specific work goal — and while the plan is active, **the money you set aside does not count** against your SSI eligibility or payment.

How it works

- **The goal must lead somewhere real:** the plan has to show the goal will significantly reduce your need for SSI — or, for SSDI, get you to SGA-level earnings. Examples: tuition and fees for a certificate, tools or equipment, a reliable vehicle for work, business start-up costs, job coaching, licenses, uniforms (not everyday clothes), attendant or child care so you can train, even fees for help preparing the plan.
- **What it does to your SSI math:** money set aside under an approved PASS is excluded — many people get dollar-for-dollar recovery, meaning their SSI payment rises by the amount they set aside, funding the goal. Your earnings still

count in the first steps of the formula — the exclusion happens through the PASS itself, which is why the order matters and a counselor's help pays off.

- **The form:** plans are written on **Form SSA-545-BK** and approved by a PASS specialist. A helper site, passonline.org, walks through building one.
- **Doing it right:** keep the set-aside money in a **separate bank account**, spend it only on the plan, keep receipts, and follow the plan's timeline. If the plan changes, tell SSA and amend it — don't quietly spend PASS money on something else.
- **One expense, one tool:** the same expense can't be claimed under both PASS and IRWE (Chapter 4). PASS is usually the better deal — your counselor will run both ways.

The Big PASS List — What PASS Money Can Pay For

This list comes from SSA's own PASS rules (POMS SI 00870.025) — and SSA describes its own list as not all-inclusive. One rule controls everything:

> **Every dollar must be needed to reach the specific work goal written in your approved PASS.** If it does not move you toward that goal, PASS cannot pay for it.

Read the list with your goal in mind — and remember the payoff: income and savings you set aside under an approved PASS are **not counted**, not as SSI income and not toward the $2,000 SSI resource limit. For many people, PASS is how you save real money while on SSI.

School and training

- Tuition
- School and training fees of every kind
- Books
- School supplies
- Tutoring fees
- Testing and exam fees
- Counseling tied to your program
- Room and board away from home when you must live elsewhere to attend school or training — while you still keep your permanent home

Starting or running a business

- Equipment to establish the business
- Supplies to establish and carry on the business
- Operating capital
- Inventory
- Finance and service charges connected to any approved PASS purchase

- Bank charges on the separate account that holds only PASS money

Tools and gear for the job

- Equipment and tools made for your condition
- Equipment and tools any worker would use (general-use tools count too)
- Safety equipment
- Uniforms
- Specialized clothing — including dress business clothing

Getting there

- Public transportation and common carriers (bus, train, transit passes)
- Hiring a private or commercial carrier
- Hiring a person to drive your vehicle
- Leasing a vehicle for the goal
- Renting a vehicle for the goal
- **Buying a vehicle for the goal** (SSA steers you to the least costly option that works)
- Fuel for that vehicle
- Insurance for that vehicle
- Maintenance and registration for that vehicle
- Vehicle taxes tied to that vehicle

People who help you reach the goal

- Attendant care
- Child care (so you can attend school, training, or work)
- Job coaching
- Job counseling services
- Supported employment services, including job development

Credentials and professional costs

- Licenses required for the job or business
- Certifications and exam costs
- Permits
- Dues for academic or professional organizations
- Subscriptions to academic or professional publications
- Taxes and government user fees connected to an approved PASS item (income taxes, fines, and penalties are **not** allowed)

Access changes

- Modifications to a building so you can get in and work
- Modifications to a vehicle so you can operate or ride in it

The small-print items people forget

- Meals eaten during work hours (including during job training and school)

- Food and shelter while temporarily away from home for school, training, or business activity
- Job search expenses
- Relocation expenses for the goal
- PASS preparation fees (paying someone qualified to help you write the plan)

What PASS will NOT pay for

- Ordinary living expenses with no link to the goal (regular rent, regular groceries, utilities)
- Recreation
- Old debts unrelated to the goal
- Anything another program already pays for (Vocational Rehabilitation, a Medicaid waiver) — PASS fills gaps; it does not double-pay
- Anything you would buy anyway, work goal or not

Steps to start

1. Name the work goal in one sentence ("I will earn my commercial driver's license by…").
2. List what it costs, item by item, with prices.
3. Sit with your Employment Network or a WIPA counselor and draft Form SSA-545-BK.
4. Open the separate account when the plan is approved.
5. Set aside the plan amount each month; keep every receipt.

Checklist — PASS

- ☐ My goal is specific and leads to more earnings / less SSI
- ☐ Costs are itemized with real prices
- ☐ Form SSA-545-BK drafted with help (passonline.org)
- ☐ Separate account for set-aside funds
- ☐ No double-claiming the same expense as IRWE

Your next step: Write your one-sentence work goal at the top of a page — that sentence is the seed of the whole plan.

Cheat Sheet — PASS

- Approved written plan (SSA-545-BK) → income/resources set aside for a work goal **don't count** for SSI.
- Can restore your payment **dollar for dollar** while you save.
- Separate account. Approved spending only. Receipts always.
- PASS **or** IRWE for an expense — never both.

Go Deeper

- Justice in Aging (fact sheet): The Supplemental Security Income (SSI) Resource Limit and Common Solutions

Chapter 11: Other Accounts and Safe Places for Money

Individual Development Accounts (IDAs)

Matched-savings programs: you save toward a goal (often education, a home, or a small business) and the program **matches** your deposits. Savings in **federally funded IDAs (through TANF or the Assets for Independence program) are excluded from SSI counting.** Availability is local and varies — ask 211 or your counselor what's open near you.

Special needs trusts and pooled trusts

Sometimes money arrives all at once — an inheritance, a settlement, a back-payment. Received directly, it can break SSI and Medicaid. Families often place such money in a **special needs trust** (set up for the person, managed by a trustee) or a **pooled trust** (run by a nonprofit, with a sub-account for the person), so the money can pay for extras without counting against benefits. **This is lawyer territory.** This book explains the idea so you can ask the right question — "Would a special needs trust protect this?" — before the money lands, not after. Never sign trust paperwork you don't understand; get independent legal advice.

Burial funds

SSI ignores **burial funds up to $1,500** set aside for your burial (and burial spaces themselves don't count). A small, legal, often-overlooked exclusion — worth using if you're near the resource line.

Dedicated accounts (for children's back payments)

When a child on SSI receives a **large back payment**, the parent or representative payee must keep it in a **separate "dedicated account"** and spend it only on approved things for the child (medical care, education and training, and similar needs). If you're a parent or payee, this separation is not optional — SSA can ask for an accounting.

my Social Security — the account you actually use every month

Your free account at **ssa.gov** shows your benefit status, lets you report wages (after the Chapter 5 setup), update your address and direct deposit, and get letters online. Set it up with strong sign-in security and never share your password — SSA will never ask for it by phone or text.

Direct Express and direct deposit — how your money arrives

SSA pays electronically: **direct deposit** to your bank account, or the **Direct Express** prepaid card if you don't have one. Keep your payment method and address current with SSA — a stale address is how people miss the letters this book teaches you to answer.

Building Wealth While on SSI or SSDI

Saving is not the same game on both benefits — and knowing which game you are playing is the whole strategy.

First, the line that decides everything:

- **SSDI has NO resource limit.** None. SSA does not care what an SSDI-only recipient saves, invests, or owns — SSDI watches your work and earnings, never your bank balance. If you are SSDI-only, you can build wealth the ordinary way: savings, retirement accounts, a business, property.
- **SSI is the opposite.** SSI caps **countable resources at $2,000** for an individual ($3,000 for a couple) — cash, bank accounts, stocks, extra vehicles, most of what can be turned into money for food or shelter. On SSI, wealth-building is a rulebook game: every legal path below works by moving value into things SSI **excludes**.
- **On both?** The SSI rules govern your savings. Use the SSI paths.

- One timing rule runs the whole SSI game: resources are counted as of the **first moment of the month**. Money must be inside an exclusion before the 1st.

The SSI wealth paths (all legal, all published by SSA)

- **ABLE account — the big one.** Save and invest in a tax-advantaged account that SSI ignores up to **$100,000** (Chapter 9). Anyone can contribute — you, family, friends. This is the single most powerful wealth tool on SSI.
- **ABLE to Work.** If you work and your employer does not offer you a retirement plan (or you don't participate in one), you may contribute **extra** ABLE money on top of the normal yearly limit — up to your earnings. The cap is set from the federal poverty line and changes yearly; check the current figure with your state program before you rely on it. Work literally raises your legal savings ceiling.
- **PASS.** Money set aside under an approved PASS is excluded from the $2,000 count while you build toward a work goal (Chapter 10) — education funds, business start-up funds, a vehicle fund.
- **Individual Development Account (IDA).** Through a TANF or federal Assets for Independence program: you deposit earnings toward school, a home, or a business; a nonprofit **matches** your deposit (typically $1 for $1). Your deposits, the match, and the interest are all excluded from SSI income **and** resources. Warning: an IDA that is not federally funded is **not** excluded — check the program before you deposit.

- **Property Essential to Self-Support (PESS) — own the business, not the cash.** Property you use in a trade or business, and tools and equipment you use as an employee, are **fully excluded**, with no value limit. Non-business property can also be excluded up to $6,000 of equity value (property that produces goods for your own household, or property returning at least 6% a year, for example rental property). On SSI, turning savings into business assets is a legal way to hold real wealth.
- **Your home.** The home you live in (and the land it sits on) is excluded, whatever it is worth. Building equity in your own home is building wealth SSI never counts.
- **One automobile.** One vehicle used for transportation by you or a household member is excluded **regardless of value**. A paid-off, reliable car is real net worth that does not touch the $2,000 limit.
- **Household goods and personal effects.** Your furniture, electronics, and belongings are excluded. (Excluded does not mean unlimited investing — it means ordinary living property is safe.)
- **Burial funds and burial spaces.** Up to **$1,500** set aside for your burial (and $1,500 for a spouse), kept in a separate, clearly marked account, is excluded; burial spaces and plots for you and your immediate family are excluded with no dollar cap. One detail: the $1,500 is reduced by the face value of life

insurance policies that SSI already excludes — ask your counselor to run your exact numbers. Small, but it is protected money your family will actually need.

- **Back payments have a clock, not a curse.** Retroactive SSI/SSDI payments are excluded from resources for **9 months** after the month you receive them. **The move:** spend or move a lump sum into an excluded place (ABLE, PASS, home, vehicle) inside that window — after month 9, whatever is left in the bank counts.
- **Tax refunds, including the Earned Income Tax Credit (EITC).** Federal tax refunds are excluded from SSI resources for **12 months** after the month you get them. If you work, file your taxes and claim the EITC — it is real money, and the 12-month window gives you time to place it. (On SSDI, the EITC never affects your benefit at all.)
- **1619(b) — keep Medicaid while you climb.** If earnings end your SSI cash payment, Section 1619(b) can keep your **Medicaid** running up to a state earnings threshold (often far above the SSI cash cutoff, and higher with an individualized calculation — Chapter 3 has the conditions, and your counselor can give you your state's current threshold). Health coverage is wealth protection: one uninsured hospital stay can erase a decade of saving.
- **Special needs trust / pooled trust — lawyer territory.** A properly drafted (d)(4)(A) special needs trust, or a pooled trust run by a nonprofit, can hold larger sums (an inheritance, a settlement) outside the $2,000 count. Say it plainly: **do not**

DIY this. A badly drafted trust counts in full. This one needs a special-needs attorney — the legal fee is part of the play, and ABLE money can pay it (Chapter 9).

The SSDI-only fast lane (no resource limit — just don't cross the work rules)

- Save and invest normally — bank accounts, IRAs, employer retirement plans, brokerage accounts: none of it is reported to or limited by SSDI.
- Build a business — SSDI has no asset test; only your earnings from work interact with TWP and SGA.
- Your safety nets while you build: Trial Work Period, Extended Period of Eligibility, Expedited Reinstatement (5-year window), and Medicare continuing at least 93 months after your TWP ends.

Traps — what does NOT work

Each of these is a documented way people lose SSI. Learn them as a list of doors not to open.

- **A regular savings account is not a shelter.** Every countable dollar over $2,000 on the 1st of the month can suspend your SSI. "Saving for a rainy day" in a normal bank account is the trap itself.

- **Retirement accounts count on SSI.** Your own IRA/401(k) is a countable resource for SSI (an ineligible spouse's pension is treated differently — get advice before assuming). On SSDI-only, retirement saving is fine; on SSI, ABLE is the substitute vehicle.
- **Giving it away backfires — badly.** Giving money or property away, or selling it for less than it is worth, inside the 36-month look-back creates a **penalty period of SSI ineligibility** — the amount you gave away divided by your monthly benefit amount, up to **36 months** with no SSI at all. You end up with neither the money nor the check.
- **The "hide it" accounts are not hidden.** Cash App, Venmo, PayPal, prepaid cards, cash in a drawer, a relative "holding" your money, a joint account you control — if you can spend it, SSI counts it. (Joint accounts are presumed to be **entirely yours** unless you prove otherwise.)
- **Sitting on an inheritance is the classic ambush.** An inheritance counts as income the month it arrives and a resource every month after. The legal versions exist — ABLE deposit, a properly drafted special needs or pooled trust, timely spend-down into excluded things (home, vehicle, burial fund) — but they must happen **fast**, and the trust version needs a lawyer.
- **Ignoring an overpayment letter makes it grow teeth.** Silence converts a negotiable debt into automatic withholding of part of your check. The legal plays are the forms: dispute it

(SSA-561), ask for a waiver (SSA-632-BK), or negotiate the repayment rate down (SSA-634). Filing is the move; ignoring is the trap. (Chapter 6 walks through all three.)

- **A second car, a boat, or land you don't use counts at full equity value** (minus what you owe on it). On SSI, only ONE vehicle is excluded — the second one is a resource with wheels.

Cheat Sheet — Accounts at a Glance

- **ABLE:** disability-cost savings; $100,000 protected from SSI resources.
- **PASS:** approved plan; set-asides don't count while you fund a work goal.
- **IDA:** matched savings; federally funded IDA money excluded from SSI counting.
- **Special needs / pooled trust:** parks inheritances and settlements safely — lawyer required.
- **Burial funds:** up to $1,500 ignored by SSI.
- **Building wealth:** SSDI has **no** resource limit; on SSI, build inside the exclusions (ABLE, PASS, IDA, PESS, home, one car) — full paths and traps in the section above.
- **Dedicated account:** mandatory separate account for a child's large SSI back payment.
- **my Social Security + direct deposit/Direct Express:** your everyday tools — keep them current and secure.

Your next step: Log in to (or create) your my Social Security account and check that your address and payment method are right.

> **You can do this — Part 2 done.** Saving on SSI or SSDI isn't breaking the rules — the rules built these doors. Knowing they exist is the hard part, and now you know.

Part 3 — Finding Work That Fits



Chapter 12: Job Titles, Explained

Job postings hide behind titles. Here's what the titles that fit our participants most often actually mean — what you'd do all day, and who tends to thrive in them.

- **Customer Service Representative** — Helping customers by phone, chat, or in person: orders, questions, problems. Many roles are remote. Fits: patient talkers, people who like solving a problem and being done with it. Seated work; steady schedules exist.
- **Data Entry / Medical Data Entry** — Typing information into systems accurately: forms, claims, records. Medical data entry adds health-care terms. Fits: careful, keyboard-comfortable people who like quiet, focused work.
- **Medical Office Administrator / Patient Registrar** — Front desk of a clinic or hospital: scheduling, check-in, insurance forms. Fits: organized people-persons; grows from data-entry experience.
- **Night Auditor (hotels)** — The overnight front-desk role: checking in late guests, balancing the day's books, light reports. Fits: night owls; often quieter than day shifts, and hotels hire steadily. Experienced participants have landed these roles through name-brand hotel chains.

- **Home Health Aide** — Helping clients at home with daily living: meals, mobility, companionship, light tasks. Fits: caring people who want active, human work; training is often provided, and it can be a step toward medical assisting and other licensed care roles.
- **Warehouse roles (seated/light where posted)** — Some warehouse jobs are heavy; others are scanning, packing, labeling, or returns processing at a bench. Read the posting's physical requirements closely (Chapter 15) and match them honestly to what your body can do.
- **Bank Fraud / Disputes Operations** — Back-office bank jobs reviewing transactions and customer dispute claims, mostly by computer and phone. Fits: detail-focused people; banks hire these in waves and train.

One honest warning from experience: be cautious with life-insurance sales offers. They are often commission-only, charge you for leads or licensing, and are a poor fit for someone who needs a steady paycheck. No honest counselor steers people there, and neither should a listing that found you.

Cheat Sheet — Titles

- Talker → customer service. Typer → data entry. Organizer → medical office. Night owl → night auditor. Caregiver heart → home health aide. Detail detective → bank fraud/disputes.
- Always read the duties and physical requirements, not just the title.

Your next step: Circle two titles above that sound like you — those are your search words in Chapter 14.

Go Deeper

- CareerOneStop's interest assessment and occupation profiles (Appendix B) — 30 questions, real job matches.

Chapter 13: Trainee Pipelines — Jobs That Train You

Some of the best doors have the word **"Trainee"** in the title. Employers — especially government agencies and big institutions — hire people without the exact experience, train them in a class, and promote from within. Search these exact titles:

- **Claims Examiner Trainee** — State and insurance employers hire trainees to learn to review and decide claims (unemployment, insurance, benefits). Steady, seated, career-ladder work.
- **Veterans Service Representative (VA)** — Federal job helping veterans with their claims. Posted on USAJOBS; veterans and people with disabilities have specific federal hiring paths (ask about Schedule A).
- **Claims Specialist (SSA)** — Social Security's own front-line claims job, in local offices nationwide. Posted on USAJOBS.
- **Bank fraud/disputes trainee classes** — Large banks periodically hire whole training classes for operations centers.

Why trainee roles fit: no experience trap ("entry-level" that secretly wants 3 years), paid training, predictable hours, and benefits. **How to find them:** search the exact title + your city on USAJOBS (federal) and each state job bank (Appendix B), and set alerts.

Checklist — trainee pipelines

- ☐ I searched the four exact titles for my area this week
- ☐ Federal postings: I checked USAJOBS and noted closing dates
- ☐ I asked my Employment Network (or a WIPA counselor) about Schedule A (federal disability hiring path)
- ☐ Closing dates are on my calendar — trainee postings close fast

Your next step: Run one exact-title search today — "Claims Examiner Trainee" plus your city.

Cheat Sheet — Trainee Pipelines

Search the exact words: **Claims Examiner Trainee · Veterans Service Representative · Claims Specialist · fraud/disputes operations**. Government and bank training classes = paid training, real ladders, no experience trap.

Chapter 14: Where to Look

Start close to home. If you have an Employment Network, it sends matched leads with direct links and points out job fairs. Your state job bank and your local American Job Center do the same. Then widen the net yourself:

- **Official job banks for our regions:** WorkSource Georgia · AlabamaWorks · Employ Florida · Illinois workNet · Louisiana Works (links in Appendix B).
- **National:** CareerOneStop (the Labor Department's hub — job search, training finder, local help by ZIP) and USAJOBS (federal).
- **Career centers:** your state career center and Goodwill career centers offer free computers, resume help, and workshops — walk in.
- **Job fairs:** Employment Networks and career centers round up confirmed fairs weekly; virtual fairs run through platforms like JobFairX. A fair is a room (or screen) full of employers who came to hire — prepare like it's five mini-interviews (Chapter 18).
- **Training that leads to jobs:** Georgia's technical colleges and the **HOPE Career Grant** (tuition-free programs in in-demand fields); free online starters like Professor Messer (IT certifications) and Cisco Networking Academy.

DIY steps — a weekly search rhythm

1. Monday: check your Employment Network's leads and the fair roundup.
2. Search your two titles (Chapter 12) on your state job bank; save new matches.
3. Apply the same day to anything that fits (Chapter 15's checks first).
4. One trainee-pipeline search (Chapter 13).
5. Log every application: date, employer, title, link, status. (Your log is also great evidence of effort for your plan.)

Your next step: Save your state job bank's site and run your first two-title search.

Cheat Sheet — Where to Look

Your Employment Network's leads first → state job bank → CareerOneStop/USAJOBS → career centers & Goodwill → weekly fairs. Log every application.

Go Deeper

- All links are collected in Appendix B, Resource Directory.

Chapter 15: Reading a Job Posting Like a Pro

Five checks, two minutes, before you apply:

1. **Is it fresh?** Look for the posted date. Within about the last **14 days** is prime. No date? Be cautious — and check the employer's own site.
2. **Is it still open?** Words like "closed," "filled," or "no longer accepting" end the story. If the apply button errors or loops, the posting may be dead even if the page loads.
3. **Is this the employer's own page?** Aggregator sites copy each other's postings — including expired ones. Whenever you can, apply from the **company's own careers page**.
4. **Do the duties fit — really?** Read tasks and physical requirements, not the title. Lifting weight, standing hours, schedule (nights? weekends?), location or remote — match them to your real life before investing hope.
5. **What exactly do they want?** Note required documents (resume format, license, typing speed), the closing date, and the name of the role — you'll mirror their words in your application (Chapter 17).

Red flags: fees to apply or train, requests for bank info before a job offer, interviews only by gift-card apps, a company email that doesn't match the company's domain. Real employers don't charge you to get hired.

Checklist — posting check

- ☐ Posted within ~14 days (or verified live on the employer's site)
- ☐ Apply path works; employer's own careers page preferred
- ☐ Duties, schedule, location, physical demands fit me
- ☐ Requirements and closing date noted in my log

Your next step: Find one live posting and run all five checks on it — practice counts.

Cheat Sheet — Posting Check

Fresh? Open? Employer's own page? Fits my body and schedule? Requirements noted? Five yeses = apply today.

> **You can do this — Part 3 done.** You know what the titles mean, where the training doors are, and how to spot a live posting. Next: turning "I found it" into "I applied — well."

Part 4 — Applying and Landing It



Counselors and Employment Networks open doors. Walking through them — applying, showing up, following through — is your part of the deal. It's the part that gets people hired.

Chapter 16: Your Resume — Gaps and All

A resume is not your life story. It's a one-page argument: I can do this job. Employment gaps are normal after time away for health reasons, and they can be handled professionally — every employer in this book's world has seen them.

The build (DIY steps)

1. **Contact line:** name, city/state, phone, a simple professional email. (No full street address needed.)
2. **Summary (2–3 lines):** who you are for this job. "Dependable customer service professional returning to the workforce with strong phone, computer, and problem-solving skills. Experience in high-volume call handling and accurate data entry."
3. **Skills list:** mirror the posting's words — systems, typing, licenses, languages, cash handling, scheduling.
4. **Experience:** most recent first. For each role: title, employer, city, dates, and 2–4 bullets that start with action words and show results ("Processed 60+ applications daily with 99% accuracy").
5. **The gap, handled honestly:** if recent years weren't paid work, use them truthfully: "Family caregiver," "Health recovery and retraining," volunteer work, coursework, certifications earned. A line that accounts for the time beats a hole the reader fills in for you.

6. **Education & training:** school, certificates, and any trainee programs in progress.

Rules that protect you

- **One page** for most roles; two only with a long, relevant history.
- **No personal details** the employer doesn't need: no Social Security number, no birth date, no benefit information. You never have to disclose your disability or your benefits on a resume — accommodations talk comes later, on your terms (Chapter 18).
- **Save as PDF** with your name in the file name: `Firstname-Lastname-Resume.pdf`.
- **Plain text version** too — many application systems mangle fancy formatting. Simple fonts, no tables or text boxes.

Checklist — resume

- ☐ Summary aimed at this job; skills mirror the posting
- ☐ Gaps accounted for honestly, briefly, without apology essays
- ☐ Action-word bullets with numbers where I can
- ☐ PDF + plain-text versions saved, name in the file name
- ☐ My Employment Network or a career center reviewed it (free) before my first send

Your next step: Draft the summary — three lines — today. The rest builds from it.

Cheat Sheet — Resume

Argument, not autobiography. Mirror the posting. Explain time briefly and truthfully. PDF + plain text. No SSN, no benefit details, ever.

Chapter 17: Applications, Step by Step

1. **Apply the same day the lead lands.** Postings close; trainee classes fill; the person who applied Tuesday interviews Friday.
2. **Use the employer's own application** when you can (Chapter 15). Create the account, save your password somewhere safe.
3. **Answer every required field.** "See resume" is a weak answer in a form field — paste the real answer.
4. **The work-history questions:** be consistent with your resume. Dates don't have to be perfect to the day, but they must agree with each other.
5. **"Can you perform the essential functions?"** — if you can do the core tasks (with or without a reasonable accommodation), the answer is yes. You are not required to narrate your medical history in an application.
6. **Before you submit:** screenshot or save the confirmation page and the job description. Add the role to your application log.
7. **Follow up** (script below) if you hear nothing in about a week and the posting is still open.

What to say — the follow-up message

> "Hello, my name is [Name]. I applied for the [Job Title] position on [date] (confirmation #[number]). I'm very interested in the role — my background in [one matching skill] fits what you're looking for. Is there anything else I can provide? Thank you for your time."

Checklist — application day

- ☐ Same-day application sent from the employer's own site where possible
- ☐ Every field answered; resume version matches the role
- ☐ Confirmation saved; log updated
- ☐ Follow-up date (about 1 week) on my calendar

Your next step: Pick your best current lead and apply — today, not tomorrow.

Cheat Sheet — Applications

Same day. Employer's own site. Every field. Save the confirmation. Log it. Follow up in a week.

Chapter 18: Interviews — What to Say

An interview is a conversation with a purpose: can this person do the job, and will they show up? You are answering those two questions, warmly and with proof.

Prepare (DIY steps)

1. Re-read the posting; list the five duties. For each, one sentence of your proof ("I did that when…").
2. Prepare your gap answer (below) until it sounds boring — that's when it's right.
3. Plan the route/connection test a day early; lay out clothes; know the name of who you're meeting.
4. Prepare two questions of your own ("What does training look like?" "What does a good first month look like?").
5. If you need an **accommodation** for the interview itself (an interpreter, a wheelchair-accessible room, extra time on a test), ask for it plainly and early — that's what the Job Accommodation Network helps employers do every day, and asking is a normal, protected step. **Chapter 20 is your full guide to asking — the plain-English rule, the steps, and the letters.**

What to say — the gap question

> "I was out of the workforce for a health reason, which is resolved to the point that I'm cleared and eager to work. During that time I [kept skills current / completed training / volunteered]. I'm looking for steady work I can grow in, and this role fits."

Short. Factual. Forward-looking. You do not owe medical details.

What to say — asking about schedule needs

> "I'm available for the posted schedule. If occasional medical appointments come up, I schedule them outside work hours whenever I can, and I'd communicate early about anything unavoidable. Reliability matters to me — it's why I'm asking about the schedule now rather than later."

After

Send a thank-you email the same day (script in your log): thank them, name one thing you learned, restate your fit in one line. Then log it and move to the next application — interviews are a numbers game you play with quality.

Checklist — interview day

- ☐ Five duties, five proofs, out loud once

- ☐ Gap answer practiced; two questions ready
- ☐ Route tested, clothes ready, arrival 10–15 minutes early
- ☐ Thank-you sent the same day

Your next step: Practice your gap answer out loud three times — boring is the goal.

Cheat Sheet — Interviews

Prove you can do it and that you'll show up. Gap = short, factual, forward. Accommodations: ask plainly, early. Thank-you same day.

Chapter 19: Your First Week

You got the job. Now protect it — including the benefits side.

1. **Day 1–2:** Make your **initial employment report** to SSA (Chapter 5) if you haven't. Write down your supervisor's name, your schedule, your pay rate, and your pay dates.
2. **Paperwork:** keep copies of your offer letter, W-4, and any handbook pages about schedules and calling out.
3. **Pay stub system:** start the folder (physical or phone photos): every stub, in order. This folder feeds your monthly wage reports and defends you in any overpayment question.
4. **Learn the absence rules** before you need them: who to call, by when, what counts as excused.
5. **Week 1 check-in with your Employment Network:** tell them you started. Your plan, your reporting routine, and your phase tracking all update from this one call.
6. **First paycheck coming?** Read Scenario 2 (SSDI) or Scenario 3 (SSI) before it lands.
7. **A barrier already?** If something about the job itself is in your way — noise, standing, print size, schedule — that is an accommodation question, and week one is a perfectly good time to ask. Chapter 20 walks you through it.

Checklist — first week

- ☐ Employment reported to SSA; employer info written down

- ☐ Pay-stub folder started
- ☐ Absence/call-out rules learned
- ☐ Employment Network told I started
- ☐ If I hit a barrier, I know asking for an accommodation is normal (Chapter 20)

Your next step: Make the "started work" call — to SSA and to your Employment Network — within your first two days.

Cheat Sheet — First Week

Report the job. Keep every stub. Learn the call-out rules before you need them. Tell your Employment Network you started.

> **You can do this — Part 4 done.** Doors opened, and you walked through. Part 5 is about staying through the door: keeping the job and the safety net, month after month.

Part 5 — Keeping the Job, Keeping Your Net



Chapter 20: Your Rights at Work — Accommodations and the ADA

Most people on benefits who want to work are not stopped by the work itself. They're stopped by one barrier: the noise that makes concentration impossible, the shift that collides with dialysis, the print that's too small to read, the standing that a body can't do for eight hours. Here is the part nobody told you: **for most jobs, the law gives you the right to ask for that barrier to be changed — and asking is normal, common, and usually cheap for the employer.**

The expert guide for this chapter is the **Job Accommodation Network (JAN)** — a free service of the U.S. Department of Labor that has helped workers and employers figure out accommodations since 1983. JAN doesn't place you in a job and doesn't give legal advice. What JAN does — free, confidentially, one person at a time — is help you answer one question: "What change would let me do this job?" Everything in this chapter follows JAN's guidance for workers, and JAN is credited in Appendix D.

The Plain-English Rule

> **You do not need magic words.** You do **not** have to say "ADA." You do **not** have to say "reasonable accommodation." A valid request is simply this: **telling your employer you need a change at work because of a medical condition.** Plain English counts. A letter counts. A conversation counts.

Here is what that rule looks like in real life — these examples come from the EEOC's guidance, as JAN teaches it:

- "I'm having trouble getting to work at my scheduled start time because of the medical treatments I'm undergoing." — **That IS an accommodation request**, even though no legal words were used.
- "I need six weeks off to get treatment for a back problem." — **That IS a request.** Leave can be an accommodation.
- A new employee who uses a wheelchair tells her employer the wheelchair can't fit under her desk. — **That IS a request.** She named the barrier and the reason in one sentence.
- "I'd like a new chair because mine is uncomfortable." — **That is NOT a request the law recognizes** — not because a chair is unreasonable, but because nothing linked the need to a medical condition. Add the link — "because of my back condition" — and it becomes one.

Memorize the shape of it: **the barrier + "because of my medical condition" + what might help.** That's the whole formula.

Who is covered — and when you can ask

- The ADA's job rules (Title I) cover **private employers with 15 or more employees**, plus state and local government employers. Federal workers are covered by a nearly identical law (the Rehabilitation Act).
- You qualify if you have a disability as the law defines it, you can do the **essential functions** of the job (with or without an accommodation), and the change you need is because of your disability. **There is no official list of conditions that count** — it's about your limitations, not your diagnosis label.
- **Applicants are covered too.** You can ask for an accommodation just to apply or interview: an accessible application, a reader or interpreter, materials in large print, extra time on a test. Chapter 18's interview advice and this chapter work together — ask plainly, and ask early.
- **You can ask at any time** — before you start, in your first week, or years in. You can ask more than once, and ask again if your condition or your job changes.
- **Medication side effects count.** If your medicine makes you drowsy, foggy, or in need of breaks, those are limitations the law treats the same as limitations from the condition itself.

- **Ask before performance suffers.** An employer does not have to undo discipline that happened before they knew about the disability. The safest moment to ask is the moment you first see the barrier — which is often your first week (Chapter 19).

What an accommodation can be

An accommodation is **any change or adjustment to a job, the work environment, or the way things are usually done** that lets you apply, do the essential work, or enjoy the same benefits as other employees. Real categories, from JAN:

- **Equipment and devices** — provided or modified: a different chair, a screen magnifier, a headset, a cart.
- **Schedule changes** — modified or part-time schedules, shifted start times, extra or rearranged breaks.
- **Job restructuring** — swapping marginal tasks (the small extras), not removing essential ones.
- **Communication changes** — instructions in writing, readers, interpreters, captioned meetings.
- **Workplace changes** — a moved workstation, better lighting, an accessible route.
- **Policy changes** — telework days, leave for treatment, a fluids-at-your-station exception.
- **Reassignment** to a vacant position, when nothing else works in the current one.

What an employer does NOT have to do: remove an essential job function, lower production standards, provide personal items you use off the job too (glasses, a wheelchair, hearing aids), or provide a change that causes **undue hardship** — significant difficulty or expense, judged against that employer's size and resources. And one more honest rule: the employer may choose **any effective** accommodation, not necessarily your favorite. If what they offer doesn't actually work, say so — that conversation is part of the process (see "If It Goes Wrong," below).

The cost myth — read this before you decide not to ask

The #1 reason workers stay silent is "my employer can't afford it / I don't want to be a burden." JAN asks employers about this every year. The newest study (September 17, 2025 — employers who contacted JAN, 2019–2024) found:

- **61% of accommodations cost NOTHING** — a schedule change, a moved desk, a policy tweak.
- **33% had a one-time cost — the median was $300.**
- **6% had ongoing costs — the median was $2,400 a year** (things like an interpreter for meetings).
- **66% of employers rated the accommodation very or extremely effective** — and the benefit they named most was keeping a valuable employee.

Asking is not a favor you're begging for. Most of the time it's a free or cheap fix that the employer is glad to make. (One warning about older numbers: you may see different, older figures quoted in older material — even on one of JAN's own pages. Those come from an older study. The figures above are the current ones.)

Telling your employer — disclosure, in plain terms

To get an accommodation, your employer has to know a disability is involved — that's called **disclosure**, and how much you say is largely your choice.

- **You can start general.** You usually do not have to name your diagnosis to start. Begin with your limitation and what you need: "I need to talk about the difficulty I have handwriting notes, because of a medical condition." That's a complete, valid opening.
- **Three normal reasons people disclose:** to ask for an accommodation; to get equal access to benefits and privileges (training, transportation, workplace events); or to explain an unusual situation (like needing to work from home while the office air conditioning is repaired).
- **Documentation has limits.** If your disability or need isn't obvious, the employer can ask for limited medical documentation showing you have a covered disability and why you need the change. They are entitled to information that helps them understand the disability and the need — **not your complete medical records, and not information about unrelated conditions.** If a request for paperwork

feels like a fishing expedition, that's a known problem with known guidance — JAN has a whole article on improper documentation requests, and free help (below) can walk you through it.

- **You can bring support.** If meetings are hard because of your condition — stress, anxiety, emotions — you can ask to have a support person with you at accommodation meetings. That can itself be an accommodation.
- **Timing is yours.** There is no deadline by which you "should have" disclosed. Applicants often wait until after a job offer; employees often disclose when a barrier appears. The one timing rule that matters: earlier beats after-a-discipline-problem.

How to ask — JAN's 5 steps

1. **Decide how you'll ask.** Face-to-face, email, or a letter (templates below). Oral requests count — but a written one creates a record. Many people do both: talk first, follow up in writing.
2. **Decide who to ask.** Anyone in management can receive a request. For schedule changes, HR plus your supervisor is a strong pair. You don't have to find the "right" person — the employer is responsible for routing it.
3. **Explain the why and offer your ideas.** Name the barrier, link it to your medical condition (plain English!), and suggest what would help. You don't need a perfect solution — having an idea starts the conversation.

4. **Follow up.** If nothing happens in a reasonable time, check on it. If you're denied, ask why — the reason tells you the next move (more information, a different idea, or the ladder in "If It Goes Wrong").
5. **Monitor it.** Once an accommodation is in place, you are the monitor. If it stops working — or your condition or job changes — say so. The process reopens.

What happens between your request and the fix has a name: the **interactive process**. JAN's plain definition is the only one you need: **it simply means you and your employer work together to come up with the accommodation.** A typical path: your request is recognized → information is gathered → options are explored → one is chosen → it's put in place → it's checked to make sure it works. It's a conversation, not a courtroom.

Ideas by limitation — a menu, not a prescription

JAN organizes accommodation ideas **by limitation** — what you can't do easily — rather than by diagnosis. That's the right way to browse: find your barrier, circle two or three ideas, bring them to your request. (These are starting points; JAN's website and consultants go deeper, and new products appear constantly.)

Fatigue / low stamina: flexible schedule · periodic rest breaks · anti-fatigue matting · a stand-lean stool or low task chair · carts instead of carrying · job restructuring · telework days · an ergonomic assessment.

Concentration / attention: noise-cancelling headset · workspace moved away from noise · white-noise machine or sound panels · cubicle walls or reduced clutter · planned uninterrupted work time · large assignments divided into smaller steps · written or recorded instructions · memory aids and organizers.

Memory: checklists and flowcharts · instructions in writing (always) · picture cue cards · a voice recorder for spoken instructions · wall calendar and deadline reminders · templates that prompt for the information you need · extra training time and refreshers when things change · a mentor or go-to person for daily questions.

Managing time and schedules: to-do lists and templates · reminders (verbal, written, app) · regular priority check-ins with your supervisor · assignments broken into steps. Note: JAN has no single "attendance" page — schedule help is spread across its whole site in the form of flexible schedules, modified breaks, part-time schedules, and leave. If getting there or staying the whole shift is the barrier, those are the asks to make.

Stress: identify the trigger and remove it, move away from it, or reduce it · telework (control of your environment) · schedule shifts to avoid the worst commute · modified breaks (shorter and more frequent, or one longer rest) · consistent check-ins and clear feedback from your supervisor · a service animal (see below).

Sitting a long time: adjustable or sit-stand workstation · an ergonomic chair fitted to you · lumbar and foot supports · scheduled breaks to stand and walk · an ergonomic assessment.

Standing a long time: anti-fatigue matting · a stand-lean stool · sit-down breaks · an adjustable workstation · if standing simply can't work, reassignment to a vacant position with less standing.

Lifting: carts, lift tables, and transfer devices · team lifting instead of solo lifting · proper lifting technique training · restructuring so lifting isn't the whole job · rest breaks during heavy work.

Low vision: large print — JAN points to the American Foundation for the Blind standard of **at least 16-point type, 18 preferred** (you can ask for work documents the same way) · screen magnification software and larger monitors · video magnifiers (CCTV) and hand magnifiers · large-print keyboard labels · bold pens and bold-line paper · better task lighting · glare control · training materials in alternate formats (audio, Braille) · extra breaks to rest your eyes.

> **Real situations, real solutions** (from JAN's Situations and Solutions Finder — 700+ real accommodations that actually worked, searchable by condition, limitation, or job): - A cubicle worker whose **migraines** were triggered by noise near the copier was **moved to a low-traffic spot** and given an environmental sound machine. Cost: nearly nothing. - A social worker with **diabetes-related vision loss** asked for a reduced workload. Instead, the employer provided **stand magnification equipment and screen-magnification software** — full duties, full standard, barrier removed. - A retail worker needing **dialysis three times a week** was **transferred to a store closer to the dialysis center**, with leave as needed. - A therapist with **brain-injury memory deficits** was allowed to **record sessions and replay them before writing notes**, with 15 minutes scheduled after each session for note-taking.
>
> Ordinary people, ordinary fixes. Search the Finder yourself at askjan.org — chances are someone with your exact barrier has already solved it.

Two special cases worth their own space

Telework. Working from home **can** be a reasonable accommodation when your disability makes on-site work hard and the essential parts of the job can be done at home. Barriers telework commonly solves: a brutal commute (pain, fatigue, medical needs), inaccessible parking or buildings, environmental

triggers (chemicals, temperature, lighting), privacy for medication or treatment, and concentration problems. It only has to cover what the disability requires — one day a week, half-days, a set period. Your employer may offer a different, effective on-site fix instead; preference matters, but effectiveness is the legal test. A simple written plan (hours, check-ins, how you'll communicate) makes telework requests succeed more often.

Service animals. Asking to bring a service animal is handled like any other accommodation request: **ask first — don't just bring the animal.** Say what the animal does for you and be ready to talk through the practical side (where the animal stays during your tasks, for example). JAN fields these questions constantly, including from employers worried about clients or coworkers — there are workable answers, and JAN will help find them.

Coming back after time away? You do **not** have to be "100% healed" to return to work. Employers must consider accommodations for people returning with restrictions — modified duties, a modified schedule, or transitional work that builds hours and tasks up gradually. A "100% healed before you return" policy, applied without looking at your individual situation, is exactly the kind of blanket rule the ADA pushes back on. If you're returning from a stretch on benefits, Chapter 20's neighbor chapters (your phase, your reporting) handle the benefits side — this chapter handles the workplace side: ask early, while "early intervention" can still do its work.

If it goes wrong — the ladder

- **Silence.** There's no legal deadline for a response, but employers are expected to act **as quickly as possible**, and long unexplained delays can themselves become a denial. Move one rung: a polite written follow-up (the Inquiry Letter below) that documents your good-faith effort.
- **Offered something that won't work.** You can try it and report back honestly — or explain why it won't work and ask them to consider other options. "That won't work because..." plus an alternative is the strongest sentence in this whole process.
- **Denied.** First: **ask why.** If the reason is thin medical information, provide more. If it's cost or hardship, suggest other options — you now know most accommodations cost little or nothing. If you believe there's no valid reason: go up the chain of command, file a union grievance if you have a union, or contact the **EEOC** or your **state enforcement agency**.
- **Documentation is slow.** Tell your employer you're working on it and why. Provide records you already have. Ask for a **temporary** accommodation in the meantime — temporary and changing limitations can be accommodated too.
- **Know the boundary.** JAN gives accommodation ideas and process help — **not legal advice**, and neither does this book. For legal questions, your state's **protection & advocacy system** and the EEOC are the routes. For the benefits side of

any workplace problem — hours, earnings, reporting — your Employment Network or WIPA counselor is the call (that's the red-flag list in Part 1).

The letters — copy, adapt, send

A written request creates a record; that's its whole job. JAN publishes sample letters and a guide to what a request letter should contain. The templates below are **written for this book, modeled on JAN's samples** — the structure is JAN's teaching; the words are yours to make your own. JAN's originals live at askjan.org (see Go Deeper).

What a request letter includes (JAN's 7 elements): ① who you are (name, job title) · ② that you are requesting an accommodation under the ADA (naming it is optional in speech — in a letter, it helps) · ③ your limitation, in plain words (a diagnosis name is optional) · ④ the job task or barrier you're having trouble with · ⑤ your accommodation idea(s) · ⑥ a note that your health-care provider can supply documentation if needed · ⑦ a request for a response, and your contact information.

Template 1 — Accommodation Request Letter (book template — modeled on JAN's sample; make it yours)

[Date]
Dear [supervisor's or HR name],
I am writing to request an accommodation for my job as [your job title]. I have a medical condition that affects [your limitation, in plain words — for example: "how long I can stand," "my ability to concentrate in noise," "my energy in the afternoon"].
Because of this, I am having difficulty with [the specific task or barrier]. I would like to request [your idea — for example: "a stool at my workstation," "my schedule shifted 30 minutes later," "instructions in writing"]. I believe this would allow me to perform my job duties fully.
My health-care provider can supply documentation about my condition and this need if you require it. Please let me know what information you need from me, and when we can discuss this.
Thank you for your time and consideration.
[Your name] · [your phone or email]

Template 2 — Sample language: asking without naming a diagnosis (modeled on JAN's mental-health sample letter — notice: no diagnosis appears anywhere in it)

Dear [name],
I am requesting an accommodation related to a medical condition. I experience difficulty with concentration and staying organized when there is a lot of background noise and

when tasks are given only verbally.
To help me do my job effectively, I would like to request permission to use noise-cancelling headphones while I work, and to receive my task assignments in writing (a short written list or email is fine).
I am happy to discuss other ideas if these are not workable. My provider can supply documentation if needed. Thank you for considering this request.
[Your name]

Template 3 — Sample language: a physical limitation (short form — many requests need no more than this)

Dear [name],
Because of a medical condition affecting my back, I am requesting the following accommodations: an adjustable sit-stand workstation, an ergonomic chair, and a modified break schedule so I can change positions during my shift. My provider can document this need. I would welcome a meeting to discuss these or other options.
[Your name]

Template 4 — Inquiry Letter: when an employer goes silent (modeled on JAN's Employee Accommodation Inquiry Letter)

[Date]
Dear [name],
I am writing to follow up on my accommodation request dated [date of your original request], regarding [brief description — the barrier and what you asked for]. I have not yet received a

response, and I want to make sure my request reached the right person.
I remain ready to discuss options, provide documentation from my provider, or consider alternatives that would work.
Please let me know the status of my request and what the next step is.
Thank you for your attention to this.
[Your name] · [your phone or email]

Keep a copy. A dated paper trail of good-faith effort is worth a great deal if a request is ever disputed.

Free expert help — JAN's contact box

Job Accommodation Network (JAN) — free, confidential, one-on-one help with accommodation ideas and ADA questions. - **Voice: 1-800-526-7234** · **Email: JAN@AskJAN.org** · **Web: askjan.org** (voice number and email confirmed on JAN's own Contact page) - **TTY: 1-877-781-9403** · **Hours: Monday–Friday, 9 a.m.–6 p.m. Eastern** (per JAN's published materials and the SSA Red Book's JAN listing) - Online question form and live chat at askjan.org. When you write, JAN asks what helps them help you: your limitation, your job and its duties, whether you're employed or job-seeking, and your question. - **Self-employed or starting a business?** JAN has an **Entrepreneurship team** (business planning, financing, benefits planning for the self-employed) — reach it through

> the "Self-Employment JAN on Demand" form on JAN's Contact page. It pairs with Chapter 24 of this book. - JAN is **not** a job-placement service and does not provide legal advice — it's the accommodation-ideas desk. For job placement and benefits planning, that's your Employment Network and WIPA (Appendix B).

Checklist — asking for an accommodation

- ☐ I can name my barrier and my limitation in one plain sentence
- ☐ I have two or three ideas to suggest (the menu above, or JAN's site)
- ☐ I know who I'm asking, and how (talk + written follow-up)
- ☐ I asked before the barrier became a performance problem
- ☐ I kept a dated copy of everything I sent
- ☐ If it isn't working, I said so — and suggested the next idea

Your next step: Write your one sentence — barrier + "because of my medical condition" + what might help — on your My Numbers page. Having the sentence ready is most of the battle.

Cheat Sheet — Your Rights at Work

- **Plain-English rule:** barrier + medical condition + idea. No magic words — you don't have to say "ADA."

- **Covered:** employers with 15+ employees (and government employers). Applicants count. Ask any time — even your first week.
- **Side effects count.** Medication limitations are limitations.
- **Mostly free:** 61% of accommodations cost $0; typical one-time cost is a $300 median (JAN, Sept 2025).
- **Disclosure:** start with your limitation, not your diagnosis. Documentation is limited — never your whole medical record.
- **Process:** ask → talk it through together (the interactive process) → try → monitor → speak up if it fails.
- **If it goes wrong:** ask why → add information → suggest alternatives → written follow-up → chain of command / union → EEOC or state agency.
- **JAN:** free experts — 1-800-526-7234 · JAN@AskJAN.org · askjan.org.

Go Deeper

- JAN: Insights on the ADA — Q&A for Workers — the skeleton of this chapter, in JAN's own words
- JAN: Employees' Practical Guide to Requesting and Negotiating Reasonable Accommodation
- JAN: The Cost and Benefits of Accommodations — the September 2025 study behind the cost box
- JAN: Situations and Solutions Finder — 700+ real accommodations, searchable

- JAN: Sample Accommodation Request Letter and Sample Language for Accommodation Request Letters — the originals our templates are modeled on

Chapter 21: Already Working? Your Ticket Still Works for You

Starting a job does **not** end your Ticket — and it does not have to end your benefits. If you're already earning — a part-time job, a few shifts, gig work — you are not behind. You're ahead: you have momentum. What most working beneficiaries don't have is a map. This chapter is the map.

Your safety net, in plain language

- **The Trial Work Period** lets you test working for 9 months while keeping full SSDI checks. In 2027, a month counts toward it when you earn over **$1,270**.
- After those 9 months, the first month you earn at the substantial level is your **cessation month** — and your **Extended Period of Eligibility** begins.
- **36 months of protection:** during the EPE, you are still paid for every month your gross countable earnings stay under **$1,770** (the 2027 SGA limit).
- **3 grace months:** your cessation month and the two months after it are paid even if you earned over the limit.
- **A way back:** if your benefits stop because of work, **Expedited Reinstatement** can restart them without a new application — if you ask within **5 years**. You can receive up to **6 months of provisional payments** while Social Security decides.

- **Medicare continues** for at least **93 months** after the Trial Work Period ends.

You can assign your Ticket while you work

You don't have to quit, pause, or start over. Services run alongside your job: knowing your exact Trial Work month count, planning raises and hours before you accept them, and support as your earnings grow. Your exact months, cessation date, and limits depend on your record — they're confirmed with a free benefits review (ask about your **BPQY**, the SSA printout that shows your status).

Your 3 habits from here

1. **Report your earnings** to Social Security every month (Chapter 5).
2. **Keep every pay stub.** They are your proof.
3. **Check before you change.** More hours or a raise can affect your check — a quick review first prevents overpayments later (Chapter 22).

Checklist — already working

- ☐ I know my Trial Work months used (or I've requested my BPQY)
- ☐ My wage reporting is a monthly routine with receipts
- ☐ I check with my Employment Network (or a WIPA counselor) before accepting raises or big hour changes

- ☐ I know my EXR window: 5 years from any work-related stop

Your next step: Book the free benefits review and get your real Trial Work count — guessing is the only risky move left.

Cheat Sheet — Already Working

Ticket works while you work. TWP → cessation + 3 grace months → 36-month EPE ($1,770 line, 2027) → EXR way back within 5 years. Medicare ≥ 93 months. Report monthly. Keep stubs. Check before you change.

Go Deeper

- SSA: Choose Work — stories and webinars for working beneficiaries

Chapter 22: Raises, More Hours, and Other Changes

Good news can change your math. None of it is a trap — if you check first.

- **On SSDI in the EPE:** a raise that pushes countable earnings over **$1,770** (2027) pauses checks for those months — after your grace months are used. Under the line = paid. Deductions (Chapter 4) may pull you back under; a few dollars of IRWE can be the whole difference.
- **On SSI:** a raise simply shrinks the payment by the formula (half of what's left after $20 + $65). Your total still rises. Watch the resource line instead — bigger balances need ABLE/PASS protection (Part 2).
- **Before you accept:** run the new monthly gross through your phase math, check the effect on health coverage (Chapter 8 — Medicare Savings Programs and 1619(b) thresholds move with income), and tell SSA about the change when it happens.
- **A promotion with a start date mid-month?** Earnings are counted by the month's work — ask your counselor how your program will treat the switch month rather than guessing.

What to say — buying 48 hours to check

> "Thank you — I'm glad to accept. My start date for the new schedule — could we confirm it in writing? I manage my schedule carefully and want to give you a definite yes with the details set."

(Then run your numbers with your Employment Network or a WIPA counselor the same day — and say yes with your eyes open.)

Checklist — before the change

- ☐ New gross monthly pay estimated honestly (best and worst month)
- ☐ Phase check: TWP month? EPE month over/under SGA? SSI formula run?
- ☐ Health coverage check (1619(b) threshold / Savings Program level)
- ☐ SSA will be told when the change starts; my log updated

Your next step: The next time any change is offered, use the script, then call your Employment Network before your first bigger paycheck arrives.

Cheat Sheet — Changes

Raise on SSI = smaller payment, bigger total. Raise on SSDI in the EPE = watch the $1,770 line and your deductions. Always: numbers first, accept second, report immediately.

Chapter 23: Other Money — Unemployment, Workers' Comp, VA Benefits

Other payments interact with your benefits in specific ways. The big split: **SSDI cares about earnings; SSI counts almost all income.**

Unemployment Insurance (UI)

- **On SSDI:** UI does **not** reduce your SSDI payment — Title 2 is about work, and UI isn't work. (Still tell SSA if your work status changes, especially during the EPE or if you're considering EXR.)
- **On SSI:** UI is **unearned income** — your SSI drops by roughly the UI amount (after the $20 exclusion). And remember the Chapter 3 watch-out: if **unearned income like UI** is what pushes you past the break-even point, **1619(b) Medicaid protection does not apply**. Scenario 9 works the case.
- UI denials (for example, being fired) can be appealed — legal aid in Appendix B handles these.

Workers' Compensation (WC)

- **On SSDI:** WC (or similar public disability payments) can reduce your SSDI — but the combined total is never supposed to drop below what you had before the reduction. A lump-sum

settlement is usually spread out over the months it replaces. Tell your WC attorney you receive SSDI — it changes the settlement math.

- **On SSI:** WC counts as unearned income (after the $20 exclusion), and can affect Medicaid the same unearned-income way UI can.

Veterans' benefits

- **VA Disability Compensation** is **not** reduced by SSDI, and does **not** reduce SSDI. For SSI it counts as unearned income (dollar-for-dollar after the $20 exclusion).
- **VA Pension** (needs-based) works the other way: SSDI and earnings reduce it dollar-for-dollar — and starting work mid-year can create a VA Pension overpayment reaching back to January 1. If you receive VA Pension, tell the VA before your earnings change, and note the $20 exclusion does **not** apply there.
- VA health care is valuable but is **not** health insurance for Medicare purposes — it protects you against Part D penalties, not Part B penalties. Veterans: ask a counselor before declining Part B.
- Apply or ask: va.gov or 1-800-827-1000.

Checklist — other money

- ☐ UI: SSI drops (unearned); SSDI payment unaffected; 1619(b) warning understood

- ☐ WC: SSDI offset possible; settlements are prorated; attorney told about my SSDI
- ☐ VA: Compensation ≠ Pension — different rules, both reported

Your next step: If you receive any payment besides your benefit and wages, list it in your My Numbers page and ask about it at your next session.

Cheat Sheet — Other Money

UI: unearned for SSI (and kills 1619(b) if it's the cause); no effect on SSDI pay. **WC:** can offset SSDI; unearned for SSI. **VA Compensation:** safe with SSDI, unearned for SSI. **VA Pension:** reduced dollar-for-dollar by SSDI and earnings — report before changes.

> **You can do this — Part 5 done.** Keeping the job is a skill, and keeping the net is a habit: report, save stubs, check before changes. One part left — the moments themselves, walked through step by step.

Chapter 24: Self-Employment and Gig Work — Working for Yourself

You are here if… you earn money without an employer: gig apps (DoorDash, Uber, Instacart), freelancing, cleaning, childcare, crafts, reselling, lawn care — any work where nobody withholds taxes and you might get a **1099** instead of a W-2. In Social Security's eyes, **independent contractors are self-employed** — and self-employment has its own rules. Cash-paid work counts too.

What changes when you're self-employed

- **Net, not gross.** What counts is your **Net Earnings from Self-Employment (NESE)**: what you took in minus your ordinary business expenses. Not the app's payout total, not the 1099 by itself — the net.
- **Hours matter as much as money.** For SSDI, a month counts as a **Trial Work month** when your net earnings pass **$1,270** (2027) **OR** you work **more than 80 hours** in the month — either one.
- **SGA works differently.** There is no single paycheck number. Social Security judges the whole picture with its self-employment tests — whether your services are significant to the business, whether the income is substantial, how your work and pay compare to others doing the same work, and

what your work is worth. Translation: **keep hours and net records; SSA judges the whole picture, and good records are how you tell your side of it.**

- **For SSI:** net earnings get the usual treatment — the $20 and $65 exclusions, then half counts. NESE is figured across the **tax year** and spread over the months of that year — which is one more reason the monthly reports below matter.
- **Taxes are on you.** Nobody withholds. Set money aside as you earn, expect **quarterly estimated taxes**, and plan on **Schedule C** and **Schedule SE** with your tax return. This matters double because **SSA works from your filed tax return** to judge self-employment earnings — so **file every year, even when income is small.**

Your steps — in order

1. **Report starting self-employment to SSA right away.** It's a reportable event — don't wait for a 1099, a tax form, or the end of the year. Say what the work is, when you started, and your best estimate of net earnings.
2. **Keep records from day one:** every payment in, every business expense (with receipts), and your **hours** each month. The NESE Monthly Log in Appendix E-11 is built for exactly this.
3. **Report monthly, like everyone** (Chapter 5 deadlines) — your estimate now, reconciled by your tax return later.

4. **Set aside tax money** in a separate account as money comes in — a painful April is usually a planning problem, not a surprise.
5. **File your taxes every year** (Schedule C + Schedule SE), even for small amounts. No return = SSA has no clean record of your net — and "no record" gets decided for you, not by you.
6. **Keep claiming your deductions: IRWE and BWE still apply** when you're self-employed (Chapter 4) — disability-related work costs, with receipts. Don't confuse them with ordinary business expenses: business expenses lower your net earnings; IRWE/BWE are subtracted on top of that, by the rules in Chapter 4. The same receipt-folder habit from the Easy Order (Stop 2) carries both.

Tracker — what you keep

Your **NESE Monthly Log** (Appendix E-11): month · income in · business expenses · **net** · hours worked · Trial Work month? (net over $1,270 or 80+ hours). At tax time, this log is your Schedule C worksheet — and if an **SSA-820-BK** (Work Activity Report - Self-Employment) ever arrives, this log is how you answer it calmly, inside its **15-day** return window.

Letters SSA may send

Work review letters and the SSA-820-BK (15 days — Letter Decoder). SSA may also ask for **SSA-766 — Statement of Self-Employment Income** (2 pages, edition 06-2025): a short signed

statement of what you earned from self-employment for a period SSA asks about. Your NESE log is how you fill it in without guessing. If SSA's earnings record and yours disagree, your log plus your filed return is your evidence.

If this happens…

- A platform sends a 1099 for more than you "made" → normal: the 1099 shows gross; your Schedule C net is what counts. Keep expense proof for the difference.
- Work is cash-only → it still counts, for benefits and for taxes. Log it the day it's paid.
- A great month spikes your net → SSDI: an 80-hour or over-$1,270 month uses a Trial Work month; in the EPE, SSA applies its whole-picture tests — bring your log to your counselor before worrying.
- You also have a regular job → wages and NESE are two streams; report both, track both.

What to say — reporting self-employment to SSA

> "I'm calling to report that I've started self-employment. I [drive for a delivery app / do freelance work / run a small cleaning business], starting [date]. I expect my net earnings — after business expenses — to be about [amount] a month, working about [hours] hours a month. I'll report monthly, I'm keeping records of income, expenses, and hours, and I'll file my taxes each year. What else do you need from me?"

Watch-outs

- ☐ **Never wait for a 1099 to report.** Reporting starts when the work starts.
- ☐ Cash work counts. Unreported cash income is the fastest route to an overpayment.
- ☐ Gig apps **are** self-employment in SSA's eyes — "it's just an app" changes nothing.
- ☐ Hours count even in a low-money month (80+ hours = a Trial Work month).
- ☐ **Red flags — get one-on-one help first:** unfiled back taxes, or self-employment while receiving both SSDI and SSI. Those two tangles are exactly what one-on-one BWIA is for (your Employment Network, a WIPA project, or the Help Line: 1-866-968-7842).

Your next step: Start your NESE log today with this month's income, expenses, and hours — even if the numbers are small.

Cheat Sheet — Self-Employment

- Contractor = self-employed. **Net** (NESE) counts, not gross.
- **Trial Work month:** net over **$1,270** (2027) **or 80+ hours**.
- **SGA:** no single number — SSA judges the whole picture. Records are your voice.
- **SSI:** net gets $20/$65 exclusions, then half counts; NESE spreads across the tax year.

- **Taxes:** set money aside, quarterly estimates, Schedule C + SE — and **file every year**.
- **IRWE/BWE still apply** — separate from ordinary business expenses. Receipts from day one.

Go Deeper

- SSA: The Red Book — the self-employment chapters
- JAN: Entrepreneurship resources — JAN's self-employment team helps people with disabilities plan businesses, including how benefits fit
- Appendix E-11: your NESE Monthly Log · Form SSA-820-BK (E-1) is the review form this prepares you for

Part 6 — What If…? Real Situations, Step by Step



Fictional situations, built from the real rules. Find the one that matches your letter, your paycheck, or your week — each scenario stands alone.

Scenario 1: "Social Security Says I Was Overpaid"

The moment arrives. A letter from SSA says you were overpaid and owe money back. Your stomach drops.

What it means, in plain words. Social Security believes that for certain months, it paid you more than the rules allowed — most often because wages were reported late, processed late, or a decision about your earnings took a long time. The letter should say how much, which months, and why. An overpayment notice is a claim, not a verdict — it can be wrong, and there are three official ways to answer it.

What happens next. If you do nothing, Social Security can start taking back the money — up to 10% of an SSI check or 50% of an SSDI check each month. Your move is to respond within the deadlines below, which pauses collection while your case is reviewed.

Your exact steps

1. **Open the letter today** and read three things: the amount, the months, the reason. Write the date you received it on the envelope.
2. **Pull your proof:** pay stubs and reporting receipts for those months (your Chapter 5 folder).

3. **Call for free help before you respond:** WIPA through the Help Line (**1-866-968-7842**) or your Employment Network. Bring the letter and the folder.
4. **Choose your path (Chapter 6):** - The facts are wrong → **Appeal** on Form SSA-561 within **60 days** of the notice. Filing pauses collection. (On SSI, appealing within **10 days** can also keep your payments going while it's decided.) - The facts are right but it wasn't your fault and you can't afford it → **Waiver** on Form SSA-632-BK (no deadline; file fast anyway). Owe $2,000 or less? Ask for the verbal administrative waiver. - You owe it but the withholding is too much → ask for a **lower recovery rate**; Form SSA-634 if you can't repay in about 60 months.
5. **Keep paying your other bills and keep reporting wages** — life continues while the case is reviewed.
6. **Write everything down:** who you talked to, when, what they said. Keep copies of anything you file.

What NOT to do. Don't ignore it. Don't agree to any payment amount in a panic phone call. Don't send money anywhere but official SSA channels. Don't stop reporting current wages because you're angry — that creates the next overpayment.

What to say (calling SSA)

> "I received an overpayment notice dated [date] for [amount], covering [months]. Before I agree to anything, I want to understand my options. Please note in my file that I am reviewing the notice and will respond within the deadline. Can you confirm whether collection will pause if I file for reconsideration or a waiver?"

Worked numbers. Suppose the notice claims 4 months were overpaid because a raise was processed late. Your receipts show you reported the raise the month it started. That's an appeal (SSA-561) with receipts attached — the strongest kind: the facts, documented by SSA's own receipt.

Go Deeper

- Justice in Aging (webinar): "I Can't Pay That!" — Social Security Overpayments and Low-Income Clients

Scenario 2: First Paycheck While on SSDI

The moment arrives. Your first real paycheck — more than you expected, and suddenly you're worried you "earned too much."

What it means. During your Trial Work Period, there is no "too much." If this month's gross pay tops **$1,270** (2027), the month simply counts as **one of your nine Trial Work months** — and your full SSDI check still arrives. Under $1,270, the month doesn't even use one.

What happens next. Nothing changes about your check during the TWP. What matters is your count and your reporting.

Your exact steps

1. Check the gross (before taxes) on the stub against $1,270. Mark your Trial Work tally: used ___ of 9.
2. Report the month's earnings by the **10th** of next month (Chapter 5). Get the receipt; file it with the stub.
3. Tell your Employment Network you used a Trial Work month — your plan timeline updates.
4. Around Trial Work month 6 or 7, book a BWIA session to plan the EPE before it arrives.

What NOT to do. Don't "save up" unreported months to report all at once — late reporting is how overpayments are born. Don't quit a good job out of TWP fear: the EPE and grace months (Chapters 2) are designed for exactly what comes next.

What to say (to yourself, then your counselor)

> "This paycheck used one of my nine Trial Work months. My full check continues. My job now is: report it, file the stub, keep counting."

Worked numbers. First check: $1,480 gross. Over $1,270 → **1 Trial Work month used, 8 remain.** SSDI check: **unchanged, in full.**

Scenario 3: First Paycheck While on SSI

The moment arrives. You earned your first wages — say **$400** this month — and you're bracing for your SSI to vanish.

What it means. SSI doesn't vanish; it adjusts, about two months later, by the formula: ignore $20, ignore $65 of earnings, count half the rest.

What happens next. $400 − $20 − $65 = $315. Half = **$157.50** counted. At the maximum SSI payment of **$1,029**, your payment becomes **$871.50**. Your total: $400 + $871.50 = **$1,271.50**. You are **$242.50 ahead** by working.

Your exact steps

1. Report the earnings by the **6th** of next month (phone 1-866-772-0953 in the first 6 days is easiest). Get your receipt.
2. File the pay stub.
3. Don't be alarmed when the adjustment shows up in a check about two months out — that's the normal lag.
4. Watch your bank balance on the 1st of each month against the **$2,000** resource line (Chapter 3).

What NOT to do. Don't spend as if both full checks continue forever — the adjusted amount is the steady state. Don't stop reporting because "they already know" — reporting is what keeps you eligible and protected.

What to say (asking a counselor to check your math)

> "I earned $400 last month and I'm on SSI. My math says $157.50 counts and my payment should be about $871.50 at the maximum rate. Can you check that against my actual payment amount?"

Scenario 4: Offered a Raise or More Hours

The moment arrives. Your supervisor offers more hours and a raise. It feels great — and risky.

What it means. The offer changes your monthly gross. What it does to your benefits depends on your phase (Find Your Phase) and the 2027 lines: **$1,770** SGA for SSDI-in-EPE; the gentle half-formula for SSI.

What happens next. On SSI: your payment shrinks by the formula; your total grows. On SSDI in the EPE: months over the SGA line pause checks (after grace months), months under are paid — and deductions (Chapter 4) can pull countable earnings back under the line.

Your exact steps

1. Use the Chapter 22 script: thank them, get the new schedule in writing, take a day to check.
2. Estimate the new monthly gross — honest average, not best week.
3. Run your phase math (or call your Employment Network and run it together — free, fast).
4. Check health coverage effects (Chapter 8).
5. Accept with your eyes open; report the change to SSA when it starts.

What NOT to do. Don't refuse good offers out of fear of numbers you haven't run. Don't accept a big jump blind if you're mid-EPE with grace months already used — one phone call first.

What to say

> "Thank you — I'd love to. Can I confirm the new schedule in writing and give you my final yes tomorrow? I plan my hours carefully, and I want to be certain I can commit to them fully."

Worked numbers. EPE, non-blind: current gross $1,550/mo (paid months). Offer raises gross to $1,780. You pay $110/mo for disability-related transport (IRWE, receipts kept): countable = $1,780 − $110 = **$1,670 — still under the $1,770 line.** Your check stays payable. The receipts were worth a paycheck.

Scenario 5: A Month Over the SGA Line During the EPE

The moment arrives. A big overtime month pushed you over $1,770. You wait for the sky to fall.

What it means. If this is your **first** over-SGA month in the EPE, it's your **cessation month** — and Social Security still pays you for it **and the next two months** (the grace period). If you've already had your cessation month, this month's check is **paused** — suspended, not terminated. Your eligibility is alive the whole EPE.

What happens next. A month back under the line = a paid month again, **no new application**. Social Security may start a Work Activity Review; you'll get a form (SSA-821-BK) — answer it fully and on time, and claim every deduction (Chapter 4) before their decision, including **income averaging** if your pay bounces around, or an **Unsuccessful Work Attempt** if the work ends because of your disability.

Your exact steps

1. Confirm the month's countable earnings (gross minus IRWE/subsidy you can document) — you may not actually be over.
2. Note whether your grace months are unused (first cessation) or used.
3. Report as usual; keep the stubs.
4. If a review form arrives, calendar the return date — the form says 15 days and complete it with your counselor.

5. Plan next month's hours with the line in view — knowledge, not fear.

What NOT to do. Don't assume termination — during the EPE, earnings alone cannot terminate you. Don't hide the month; unreported over-line months are overpayment fuel.

What to say (responding to the review)

> "For [month], my gross earnings were [amount]. I am claiming the following deductions: [IRWE items with receipts / subsidy described by my employer]. Please apply them before making the SGA decision, and let me know if you need Form SSA-821-BK information from my employer."

Worked numbers. Cessation month (March): paid. Grace: April, May: paid. June over the line again: **paused**. July under the line: **paid again.** Same job, same benefits — the EPE working exactly as designed.

Scenario 6: The Job Ends Because of Your Disability

The moment arrives. Months or a few years after benefits ended for work, your disability forces you to stop or cut back below the SGA level. This is the moment the safety net was built for.

What it means. Expedited Reinstatement (EXR): if your benefits stopped because of work within the last **5 years**, and your condition — the same or related — now keeps you from SGA-level work, you can ask SSA to restart benefits **without a new application**.

What happens next. You can receive **up to 6 months of provisional payments** while SSA decides. If denied, provisional payments usually don't have to be repaid — unless you knew or should have known you weren't eligible. If approved, your reinstated months start your **Initial Reinstatement Period**: after **24 months of reinstated payments**, you earn a **new Trial Work Period, a new EPE, and a fresh 5-year EXR window**.

Your exact steps

1. Confirm the calendar: benefits stopped for work **within 60 months**? You must not be performing SGA in the month you ask.

2. Call or visit SSA and say the words: **"I want to request Expedited Reinstatement."** Ask them to explain EXR versus a new application — they're required to, and the right choice depends on your record.
3. Sign the statement certifying your condition (Form SSA-371) and file promptly — provisional payments can start from the month you submit the signed request.
4. Keep medical evidence current; SSA reviews whether your condition meets the standard. **Paperwork:** an EXR packet can also include a Work Activity Report (SSA-821-BK or SSA-820-BK), the **SSA-454-BK** Continuing Disability Review Report, and **SSA-827**, your authorization for doctors and other sources to send SSA your records. For SSI, the reinstatement request twin is **SSA-372** (SSA-371 is Title II/ SSDI).
5. If no decision by month 4–5 of provisional payments, follow up — your counselor can help push.
6. Tell your Employment Network the same week: your plan and Ticket update with you.

What NOT to do. Don't file a brand-new application without asking about EXR first — EXR is faster and protects your history. Don't wait past the 5-year window; put the date on a calendar today if it might ever matter.

What to say

> "My SSDI stopped because of work in [month/year]. My condition has worsened and I can no longer work at the substantial level. I want to request Expedited Reinstatement, and I'd like you to explain how it compares with a new application for my record, including provisional payments."

Scenario 7: A Short Job That Doesn't Work Out

The moment arrives. You took a job, worked hard for three months, and your disability made it impossible to continue. You feel like you failed — and you're scared those months "count against you."

What it means. A work effort at the substantial level that **ends within about six months because of your impairment** — or because essential special help was taken away — can be treated as an **Unsuccessful Work Attempt (UWA)**. UWA months may be **disregarded** when SSA decides whether your work was substantial. If your earnings bounce above and below the line with a steady pattern, **income averaging** is the other tool. Both can **delay or prevent a cessation** — but both must be raised **before** SSA makes its cessation decision.

What happens next. SSA looks at why the job ended. Evidence helps: the short duration, your medical records from that period, an employer's note, your own dated account of what happened.

Your exact steps

1. Write down, now, while it's fresh: start date, end date, what the job required, what your disability did, what you tried.
2. Keep any separation paperwork and the final pay stub.
3. Report the job's end (Chapter 5) — stopping work is a reportable change.

4. At any Work Activity Review — or as soon as you hear one is coming — say the words: **"I'd like this evaluated as an Unsuccessful Work Attempt,"** and ask about income averaging if your pay fluctuated.
5. Bring the file to your counselor before responding to any cessation letter.

What NOT to do. Don't assume the months automatically count — or automatically don't. UWA is claimed, not automatic. And don't let embarrassment keep you from reporting the job at all: an unreported short job is far more dangerous than a reported one that ended.

What to say

> "I worked at [employer] from [date] to [date]. I had to stop because [impairment-related reason]. I'm asking that this be evaluated as an Unsuccessful Work Attempt. I have my dates, pay records, and can describe the circumstances."

Scenario 8: A Student Under 22 Working

The moment arrives. You're 20, in school, on SSI, and the campus job is yours if you want it — but your family is worried work will cut your check.

What it means. The **Student Earned Income Exclusion (SEIE)** was written for you: if you're **under 22 and regularly attending school**, SSA excludes up to **$2,500 a month** of your earnings — up to **$10,080 a year** (2027) — before any other math. "Regularly attending" means real enrollment: roughly 12 hours a week in grades 7–12 or a job-training course, 8 hours a week in college (less can qualify when circumstances beyond your control reduce your hours).

What happens next. For most student jobs, **all** of the earnings fall inside the exclusion — your SSI payment doesn't change at all.

Your exact steps

1. Confirm your school status counts (ask SSA or your counselor — one call).
2. Take the job. Report the earnings monthly like everyone (Chapter 5), and mention you're a student claiming the SEIE.
3. Track your yearly total against the $10,080 cap as the year goes on.
4. If you're saving the money, remember the $2,000 resource line — an ABLE account (Chapter 9) protects savings; a PASS (Chapter 10) can too, if the saving is for a work goal.

What NOT to do. Don't turn down the job "to protect the check" before running the SEIE numbers — the protection is the point of the rule. Don't forget reporting just because the payment doesn't change; the exclusion is claimed through reporting.

What to say (to your family)

> "There's a rule made for students — Social Security doesn't count the first $2,500 a month I earn while I'm in school, up to $10,080 a year. My check stays the same, and I get work experience for my plan. Let me show you the chapter."

Worked numbers. Campus job pays **$600/month**. SEIE excludes all $600 (under the $2,500 monthly cap). SSI payment: **unchanged.** Yearly tally after 10 months: $6,000 of the $10,080 cap used.

Scenario 9: Unemployment Checks While on SSI

The moment arrives. You lost a job and filed for unemployment. The UI checks start — and someone mentions your SSI might change.

What it means. For SSI, unemployment benefits are **unearned income**. Your SSI payment drops by about the UI amount (after the $20 exclusion). The sharper danger is Medicaid: **1619(b) protection applies only when earnings alone pushed your SSI cash to $0.** If unearned income — like UI — is what passed the break-even point, **1619(b) does NOT apply**, and Medicaid can be at risk through a different door.

What happens next. SSA will count the UI once it knows about it — and it will learn about it. Reporting it yourself, promptly, is what keeps a manageable adjustment from becoming an overpayment.

Your exact steps

1. Report the UI award to SSA as soon as you're approved (amount and start date) — don't wait for them to find it.
2. Expect the SSI payment to drop by roughly (UI − $20) while UI lasts.
3. Ask your counselor **immediately** about your Medicaid: which category protects you now (a Buy-In program or another category may — Chapter 8).

4. Keep job-searching as UI requires, and tell your Employment Network you're back in the market — your plan continues.
5. When UI ends, report that too; your SSI payment recovers.

What NOT to do. Don't assume UI is "not income" because it isn't wages — for SSI it's unearned income, fully countable. Don't assume 1619(b) covers you; with UI in the picture, that's exactly the case it doesn't cover.

What to say

> "I've been approved for unemployment benefits of [amount] starting [date], and I receive SSI. I'm reporting this now. I also need to know what protects my Medicaid while the unemployment lasts."

Scenario 10: Saving Toward a Work Goal

The moment arrives. You know what you need — a certification course, tools, a dependable car — and it costs real money. On SSI, saving feels forbidden. It isn't — if you use the right containers.

What it means. Two tools, often combined: - **PASS (Chapter 10):** an approved written plan. Money you set aside under it doesn't count for SSI — and your payment can rise dollar-for-dollar while you save. Chapter 10 carries the full list of what PASS money can pay for. - **ABLE (Chapter 9):** the first $100,000 saved doesn't count toward the $2,000 resource limit. Family can contribute without it counting as your income. Chapter 9 carries the full list of what ABLE money can pay for.

What happens next. With a PASS, SSA excludes your set-aside as you fund the plan, as long as you follow it: separate account, approved items, receipts. With ABLE, you simply save inside the protected account.

Your exact steps

1. Name the goal and price it, item by item.
2. Meet your counselor; draft the PASS on Form SSA-545-BK (passonline.org helps).
3. Open the separate PASS account when approved; open the ABLE account if you're eligible — family gifts belong in ABLE, not handed to you as cash.
4. Set up the monthly set-aside the day the plan starts.

5. Keep receipts for every goal purchase; amend the plan in writing if life changes it.

What NOT to do. Don't save a goal fund in your regular checking account and hope — on the 1st of the month, over $2,000 is over, however good the reason. Don't claim the same expense under both PASS and IRWE.

What to say (to family who want to help)

> "The safest way to help me save is to contribute to my ABLE account — that way it doesn't count as my income or break my resource limit. Checks to me personally can actually hurt my benefits. Let me show you how it works."

Worked numbers. Goal: a $1,800 training course in 9 months. PASS set-aside: $200/month, excluded — your SSI payment rises by up to that $200 while you save (when the plan's conditions are met), so the course effectively funds itself out of restored benefits. (Your counselor runs your exact numbers — every plan is personal.)

Scenario 11: Work Expenses Are Piling Up

The moment arrives. The job is going fine — but getting there is eating your paycheck: special transport, medication co-pays, gear, a coach's help. You wonder if anyone counts what work costs you.

What it means. Social Security does — if you claim it. **IRWE** subtracts disability-related work costs you pay for. **Subsidy/ special conditions** subtract the value of help you get at work. If you're **blind and on SSI, Blind Work Expenses** subtract nearly any normal cost of earning money — **including your taxes and work meals** — and come back to you dollar for dollar (Chapter 4).

What happens next. Claimed deductions lower your countable earnings. In the EPE that can keep a month under the SGA line; on SSI it raises your payment. Claimed late or without receipts, they do nothing.

Your exact steps

1. List one month of real numbers: every cost of working, by category.
2. Sort it: disability-related and needed for work (IRWE) / employer or coach help (subsidy & special conditions) / blind on SSI → everything work-related (BWE).
3. Attach receipts to this month's wage report; mark recurring items as recurring.

4. Keep a simple log going forward (date, item, amount) — a notes app is fine.
5. Review once with your counselor to make sure nothing claimable is being missed (big purchases can sometimes be spread across months).
6. Check your list against **the Big IRWE List in Chapter 4** — most people find at least one cost they would never have guessed counts.

What NOT to do. Don't guess amounts — estimates without receipts get denied, and honest claims get weakened by sloppy ones. Don't assume a cost "doesn't count" without asking; the list of qualifying costs surprises most people.

What to say (handing in your report)

> "Along with this month's wages, I'm reporting work expenses: [items and amounts, receipts attached]. The transportation and [item] are impairment-related work expenses. Please apply them to my countable earnings, and confirm they're noted as recurring."

Worked numbers. Gross $1,720. Paid transport to work because your disability prevents driving: $150 (receipts). Medication co-pays you pay to be able to work: $60. Countable: $1,720 − $210 = **$1,510** — comfortably under the 2027 SGA line of $1,770, and on SSI the same deductions would have raised your payment instead.

Scenario 12: "I Got Turned Down — Again"

The moment arrives. Another no. Or silence, which feels like the same thing. Your motivation falls off a cliff, and quitting the whole search sounds reasonable.

What it means. It means this employer hired someone else. It does **not** mean: you are unemployable, your plan failed, or the next ten applications are pointless. Hiring is a matching process with timing, internal candidates, and luck baked in — professionals with no barriers get turned down constantly. Everyone's search includes a pile of noes under the yes.

What happens next. Nothing — unless you decide what happens next. This is the one scenario where you write the next page.

Your exact steps (this week)

1. **Feel it, briefly and honestly.** A rejection stings. Give it an evening, not a month.
2. **Write the facts, not the story.** Facts: applied, interviewed (or not), decision on [date]. Story ("nobody will ever hire me") is not a fact — cross it out.
3. **Extract one usable thing.** Was the posting a stretch? Did one interview answer wobble? One fixable item goes in the log; the rest, let go.

4. **Send the next application within 48 hours.** Momentum is a decision, not a feeling. Same-day applying (Chapter 17) applies double after a no.
5. **Tell your Employment Network.** They adjust the aim — different titles, trainee pipelines, a resume tune-up — that's literally what they're for. Silence is the only move that helps nobody.
6. **Run your Bad-Day Plan** (below) if the week is heavy.

Your Bad-Day Plan (fill in now, use when needed)

- My reason (from Chapter 1): _____
- One small thing I can do in 15 minutes: _____
- A person I can tell honestly: _____
- I will NOT decide anything about my whole future on a bad day: ☐ agreed

What NOT to do. Don't ghost your plan or your counselor — disappearing feels like relief and works like quitting. Don't torch applications in anger (mass-applying to anything). Don't compare your month 2 to someone else's year 2.

What to say (to yourself — say it like it's true, because it is)

> "One employer said no to one application. My reason hasn't changed, my plan hasn't changed, and my next application goes out this week. Help opens doors — walking through them, including after a no, is my part. And I can do my part."

When to ask for more help: if low mood lasts most days for two weeks or more, that's health, not job search — call your provider, dial **988** for the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline (free, 24/7), and tell your Employment Network or counselor. Getting support is doing the work.

> **You can do this — the whole book, done.** You have the rules, the tools, the words, and the steps. Keep this book where you keep your pay stubs. When a new letter or a new offer arrives, you know where its chapter is — and you know our number.

Appendices

Appendix A: Master Cheat Sheet

Photocopy these pages. Fridge, folder, wallet — wherever letters land.

A-1 · The Numbers (2027, verified — Appendix D)

Rule	2027
Trial Work month (SSDI)	Month's gross over **$1,270** (or 80+ self-employment hrs)
SGA — non-blind	**$1,770**/mo
SGA — blind	**$2,950**/mo
SSI maximum payment	**$1,029** individual · **$1,544** couple
SSI math	Ignore $20, ignore $65 of earnings, count **half** the rest
Student exclusion (SEIE)	**$2,500**/mo · **$10,080**/yr (under 22, in school)
SSI resource limit	**$2,000** individual · **$3,000** couple (counted on the 1st)
Medicare Part A after TWP	Premium-free for **at least 93 months**

These are the 2027 amounts. SSA updates most figures every January — before acting in a new year, confirm the newest numbers at ssa.gov or with your benefits counselor.

A-2 · The Whole SSDI Road

TWP (9 months, full check) → EPE, 36 months (at/below SGA = paid; above = paused; first over-SGA month + 2 = grace) → after benefits end for work: Medicare ≥93 months; **EXR within 5 years** restarts without a new application; up to 6 months provisional pay; 24 reinstated payments = a fresh TWP and a fresh 5-year window.

A-3 · The SSI Essentials

Work always raises your total. 1619(b) keeps Medicaid when earnings alone zero out your cash — unearned income over the line is **not** covered by 1619(b). Resources: $2,000/$3,000 on the 1st; home, one car, burial funds to $1,500, PASS money, and ABLE money to $100,000 don't count. Non-work stop: **12 months suspended → terminated → new application** — act in month 1. ABLE: disability before age 46; $20,000/yr contributions; first $100,000 protected. PASS: approved plan (SSA-545-BK); set-asides don't count.

A-4 · Deductions

IRWE (disability-related, needed, paid by you — receipts!) · Subsidy (employer help) · Special conditions (coach help) · **BWE for blind SSI: nearly all work costs incl. taxes and meals, dollar-for-dollar — use BWE, not IRWE** · Income averaging & UWA: claim before a cessation decision. **The full IRWE list and**

the countable-income toolkit: Chapter 4. What ABLE and PASS money can pay for: Chapters 9 and 10. Building wealth legally on SSI or SSDI: Chapter 11.

A-5 · Reporting & Overpayments

Report: SSI by the **6th**, SSDI by the **10th**, both if you get both. Phone 1-866-772-0953 (first 6 days). **Always get a receipt; file it with the pay stub.** Overpayment letter: open it, note the 60-day appeal date; **Appeal** = SSA-561 (pauses collection) · **Waiver** = SSA-632-BK (≤$2,000: ask for the verbal waiver) · **Plan** = lower rate / SSA-634. Defaults if you do nothing: withholding up to 10% (SSI) / 50% (SSDI). **Free help first: Help Line 1-866-968-7842 · your Employment Network.**

A-6 · Job Search in One Page

Your Employment Network first → state job bank → CareerOneStop / USAJOBS → career centers. Search trainee titles exactly: **Claims Examiner Trainee · Veterans Service Representative · Claims Specialist · bank fraud/disputes**. Posting check: fresh (~14 days)? open? employer's own page? duties fit? Apply **the same day**. Resume: argument, not autobiography; gaps brief and honest; PDF + plain text. Interview: prove you can do it and will show up. Follow up in a week. Log everything.

A-7 · Every Chapter's Cheat Sheet, Collected

Each cheat sheet from the chapters — the Phase Finder (Part 1 opener) and every chapter — is printed in its chapter and repeated here in the print edition as standalone tear-out pages, in the same large type, so any one of them can be photocopied on its own and kept with your pay stubs. In this file edition, use your PDF reader's "print current pages" on Appendix A plus any chapter cheat sheet you need.

A-8 · The Easy Order — Five Stops (tear-out)

Stop 1 — Before work: my Social Security account · BPQY · Ticket assignment + BWIA · ABLE (open early) · PASS paperwork (approval first). **Stop 2 — Job starts:** tell SSA (get receipt) · students claim SEIE · expense folder from day one · pick your wage-reporting method. **Stop 3 — Every month:** the Monthly Routine · IDA if a local program fits · Medicare Savings Programs if your premiums get hard to afford (apply any time). **Stop 4 — As you grow:** SGA check before big raises · 1619(b) is automatic, not a signup · ABLE-to-Work extras — confirm the amount with

your state program. **Stop 5 — If things change:** EXR inside 5 years · EPE suspension = keep reporting · overpayment = Scenario 1, deadlines first.

My Numbers — Copy 2 (numbers change; that's why there are two)

- I receive: ☐ SSDI ☐ SSI ☐ Both · Amounts: $_____ / $_____
- My phase: ☐ Phase 1 ☐ Phase 2 ☐ Phase 3 ☐ SSI Monthly Path · Date checked: _____
- Trial Work months used: ____ of 9 · EPE: _____ → _____
- My SGA number: $_____ · My reporting method & deadline: _____
- Employer / start date: _____
- EXR deadline (if Phase 3): _____ · Premium-free Part A ends: _____
- My Employment Network: _____ · Phone: _____ · Help Line: 1-866-968-7842 · SSA: 1-800-772-1213

Appendix B: Resource Directory

Start here, in this order:

1. **Work questions — free help first.** An **Employment Network** or **WIPA project** gives you job search help, resumes, matched leads, and free BWIA benefits advisement — always free to you. Find yours through the Ticket to Work Help Line (item 4 below) or the Find Help directory at choosework.ssa.gov — this book's publisher, Prestige Path Consulting, is an Employment Network you can choose: prestigepathconsulting.com · hello@prestigepathconsulting.com. (The Easy Order chapter in Part 2 shows how to choose an EN.)
2. **Food, rent, utilities, shelter, rides — dial 2-1-1.** Free, confidential, 24/7 referrals in your county (GA, AL, FL, IL, LA). Or 211.org.
3. **In crisis — call or text 988.** Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, free and confidential, 24/7. Emergency: 911.
4. **Benefits questions (brief/official):** Social Security 1-800-772-1213 · ssa.gov · **Ticket to Work Help Line 1-866-968-7842** (TTY 1-866-833-2967, Mon–Fri 8am–8pm ET) — program questions and free **WIPA** counseling referrals · choosework.ssa.gov.

Official starting points:

- Choose Work (Ticket to Work home): https://choosework.ssa.gov/
- The Red Book (SSA's guide to work incentives): https://www.ssa.gov/redbook/
- Find Help (locate ENs, WIPA, counselors): https://choosework.ssa.gov/findhelp
- Current SGA amounts: https://www.ssa.gov/oact/cola/sga.html · Current TWP amount: https://www.ssa.gov/oact/cola/twp.html
- WorkSource Georgia: https://worksourcegaportal.com/ · AlabamaWorks: https://alabamaworks.alabama.gov/ · Employ Florida: https://www.employflorida.com/ · Illinois workNet: https://www.illinoisworknet.com/ · Louisiana Works: https://www.louisianaworks.net/
- CareerOneStop: https://www.careeronestop.org/ · USAJOBS: https://www.usajobs.gov/ · Goodwill locator: https://www.goodwill.org/locator/
- Training: TCSG https://www.tcsg.edu/ · HOPE Career Grant tuition-free fields https://www.tcsg.edu/free-tuition/ · West Georgia Tech https://www.westgatech.edu/ · Chattahoochee Tech https://

www.chattahoocheetech.edu/ · Georgia Piedmont Tech https://www.gptc.edu/ · Professor Messer (free IT cert training) https://www.professormesser.com/ · Cisco Networking Academy https://www.netacad.com/

- Job Accommodation Network (workplace accommodations, free & confidential): 1-800-526-7234 · TTY 1-877-781-9403 · JAN@AskJAN.org · askjan.org — see Chapter 20
- American Job Centers: 1-877-872-5627 · TTY 1-877-889-5627 (via CareerOneStop)
- Veterans: VA Benefits 1-800-827-1000 · va.gov

More national help:

Benefits, planning, and legal help:

- **ABLE National Resource Center** — (202) 296-2040 — ablenrc.org — Plain-language information, state-plan comparisons, and webinars on ABLE savings accounts for people with disabilities
- **National Disability Institute** — (202) 296-2040 — nationaldisabilityinstitute.org — Works to improve the financial health and well-being of people with disabilities; runs the ABLE National Resource Center
- **National Disability Rights Network (NDRN)** — 202-408-9514 · TTY 202-408-9521 — ndrn.org — The national network of Protection & Advocacy agencies; NDRN does not take individual cases — its site lists your state P&A, which does
- **LawHelp.org** — web only (no national phone) — lawhelp.org — Free finder for nonprofit legal aid programs in every state
- **Legal Services Corporation (LSC)** — 202-295-1500 — lsc.gov — The federal funder of civil legal aid; this line points legal-aid seekers to their local program
- **Eldercare Locator** — 800-677-1116 — eldercare.acl.gov — Federally funded call center connecting older adults and people with disabilities to local aging and disability services; also routes callers to local SHIP Medicare counseling
- **State Health Insurance Assistance Program (SHIP)** — 1-877-839-2675 — shiphelp.org — Free, unbiased one-on-one Medicare counseling through your state's SHIP (may be called HICAP, SHINE, SHIIP, or VICAP locally)
- **SNAP Information Line (USDA)** — 1-800-221-5689 — fns.usda.gov/snap — National information line for food assistance (SNAP/food stamps) questions and state application routes
- **Feeding America** — 1-800-910-5524 — feedingamerica.org — The national food bank network; its line and site connect you to your local food bank

- **LIHEAP / National Energy Assistance Referral (NEAR)** — 1-866-674-6327 — energyhelp.us — Referral line for help paying home energy bills through LIHEAP
- **HUD Housing Counseling** — 800-569-4287 · TTY 202-708-1455 — hud.gov — Connects you to a HUD-approved housing counseling agency near you for renting, buying, or avoiding foreclosure
- **IRS VITA / TCE Tax Help** — 800-906-9887 — irs.gov — Finds your nearest free Volunteer Income Tax Assistance / Tax Counseling for the Elderly site
- **Social Security Administration (TTY)** — 1-800-325-0778 — ssa.gov — SSA's TTY line for deaf and hard-of-hearing callers (the voice line, 1-800-772-1213, is listed at the top of this directory)
- **National Council on Independent Living (NCIL)** — (844) 778-7961 · direct (202) 207-0334 — ncil.org — National independent-living advocacy network; find your local Center for Independent Living in the ILRU directory at ilru.org

Crisis and safety:

- **National Domestic Violence Hotline** — 1-800-799-7233 (1-800-799-SAFE) · text "START" to 88788 — thehotline.org — 24/7 confidential help for anyone experiencing domestic abuse
- **National Runaway Safeline** — 1-800-786-2929 (1-800-RUNAWAY) — 1800runaway.org — 24/7 crisis help for runaway, homeless, and at-risk youth and their families
- **Veterans Crisis Line** — dial 988, then press 1 · text 838255 · TTY 1-800-799-4889 — veteranscrisisline.net — 24/7 confidential crisis support for veterans and those who support them
- **NAMI HelpLine** — 800-950-6264 · text "HelpLine" to 62640 · Mon–Fri 10 a.m.–10 p.m. ET — nami.org/help — Information, referrals, and support for people affected by mental illness
- **Mental Health America** — (800) 969-6642 — mhanational.org — Free online mental-health screening tools and a local affiliate finder
- **National Human Trafficking Hotline** — 1-888-373-7888 · TTY 711 · text 233733 — humantraffickinghotline.org — 24/7 help and reporting for human trafficking situations
- **Childhelp National Child Abuse Hotline** — 1-800-422-4453 — childhelp.org — 24/7 crisis counseling and referrals for child abuse concerns

Veterans:

- **VA Vet Centers Call Center** — 877-927-8387 (877-WAR-VETS) — vetcenter.va.gov — 24/7 call center connecting combat veterans and their families to Vet Center readjustment counseling
- **VA National Call Center for Homeless Veterans** — 877-424-3838 (1-877-4AID-VET) — va.gov/homeless — 24/7 line connecting homeless or at-risk veterans to VA housing and support services
- **Wounded Warrior Project Resource Center** — 888-997-2586 (888-WWP-ALUM) · Mon–Fri 9 a.m.–9 p.m. ET — woundedwarriorproject.org — Connects wounded veterans and families to WWP programs and community resources

Work and disability community:

- **Goodwill Industries International** — 1-800-466-3945 (800-GOODWILL) — goodwill.org — National line for finding a local Goodwill for job training, career services, and stores (the book previously listed the Goodwill locator as web only; the phone is new)
- **Easterseals (national)** — 800-221-6827 · TTY 312-726-4258 — easterseals.com — Disability services, therapies, job training, and support through local affiliates nationwide
- **The Arc of the United States** — 800-433-5255 · 202-534-3700 — thearc.org — Advocacy and services for people with intellectual and developmental disabilities, with local chapters
- **American Association of People with Disabilities (AAPD)** — 202-521-4316 — aapd.com — The nation's largest cross-disability membership and advocacy organization
- **National Federation of the Blind (NFB)** — 410-659-9314 — nfb.org — National organization of blind Americans; advocacy, training, and local chapters
- **State Vocational Rehabilitation Agencies (RSA directory)** — web only (no single national phone) — rsa.ed.gov/about/states — The federal Rehabilitation Services Administration's official directory of all state VR agencies

Transportation:

- **National Aging and Disability Transportation Center (NADTC)** — (866) 983-3222 — nadtc.org — Federally funded center promoting accessible transportation for older adults, people with disabilities, and caregivers; information and referral to local transportation options

Local help, by area (compiled from public listings and verified October 2026; call to confirm hours before you go. Not your area? Dial 2-1-1 — every community has equivalents.):

Georgia — statewide

- **Catholic Charities (Georgia)** — 404-920-7725 — Rent, utility, and food assistance statewide.
- **Georgia Vocational Rehabilitation Agency (GVRA)** — (844) 367-4872 — gvs.georgia.gov — The state vocational rehabilitation agency; helps people with disabilities train for, find, and keep jobs
- **Georgia DFCS Customer Contact Center** — (877) 423-4746 — dfcs.georgia.gov — The statewide route for questions about SNAP (food stamps), Medicaid, and TANF
- **Georgia Legal Services Program (GLSP) — statewide intake** — 1-833-457-7529 — glsp.org — Free civil legal help for low-income Georgians in the counties outside the five-county metro Atlanta area
- **Atlanta Community Food Bank** — (404) 892-3333 · or text "FINDFOOD" to 888-976-2232 — acfb.org/get-help — Finds you a free food pantry near you across 29 metro Atlanta and north Georgia counties, including Douglas, Cobb, Fayette, Fulton, and Clayton
- **Goodwill of North Georgia — career services line** — (844) 344-9675 — goodwillng.org — Regional line for Goodwill's free career centers across north Georgia and metro Atlanta
- **United Way of Greater Atlanta / 2-1-1** — (404) 527-7200 · or just dial 211 — unitedwayatlanta.org — Runs the 211 help line that refers metro Atlanta callers to food, rent, utility, and job help in 13 counties

Douglasville / Douglas County, GA

- **WorkSource Atlanta Regional — Career Resource Center, Douglas Branch (Douglasville)** — (470) 249-4633 — atlantaregional.org — Douglas County's career center for job search help, training, and WIOA employment services
- **GVRA — Carrollton VR Office (serves Douglas County)** — (844) 367-4872 — gvs.georgia.gov — The vocational rehabilitation office assigned to Douglas County; call the GVRA line to reach it
- **Goodwill of North Georgia — Douglasville Crossings Career Center** — (844) 344-9675 — goodwillng.org — Free career center in Douglasville for job search, résumé, and training help; use the regional career services line

- **The Salvation Army — Marietta Corps (serves Douglas County)** — (770) 724-1640 — southernusa.salvationarmy.org — Nearest Salvation Army corps for Douglas County; emergency food, rent, and utility help (there is no corps located in Douglasville itself)
- **Tallatoona Community Action Partnership** — (770) 773-7730 — tallatoonacap.org — Douglas County's community action agency; energy assistance (LIHEAP), weatherization, and family self-sufficiency programs
- **West Georgia Regional Library System** — (770) 830-2233 — wgrls.org — Public library system for Douglas County; free computers, internet, and job-search resources

Powder Springs / Cobb County, GA

- **WorkSource Cobb / CobbWorks (Marietta)** — (770) 528-4300 — worksourcecobb.org — Cobb County's American Job Center for job search, training, and employment services
- **GVRA — Marietta VR Office** — (844) 367-4872 — gvs.georgia.gov — Vocational rehabilitation office for Cobb County, in Marietta
- **Goodwill of North Georgia — Smyrna Career Center (serves the Powder Springs / Cobb area)** — (844) 344-9675 — goodwillng.org — Free career center in Smyrna for job search and training help; use the regional career services line
- **The Salvation Army — Marietta Corps** — (770) 724-1640 — southernusa.salvationarmy.org — Cobb County corps in Marietta; emergency food, rent, and utility assistance
- **Tallatoona Community Action Partnership** — (770) 773-7730 — tallatoonacap.org — Community action agency serving Cobb County; energy assistance (LIHEAP), weatherization, and self-sufficiency programs
- **Atlanta Legal Aid Society** — (404) 524-5811 — atlantalegalaid.org — Free civil legal help for low-income Cobb County residents, including housing, benefits, and family matters
- **Powder Springs Library — Cobb County Public Library** — (770) 439-3600 — cobbcounty.gov/library — Public library in Powder Springs; free computers, internet, and job-search resources

Peachtree City / Fayette County, GA

- **WorkSource Atlanta Regional — Career Resource Center, Fayette Branch (Fayetteville)** — (678) 271-3541 — atlantaregional.org — Career center serving Fayette County, including Peachtree City, for job search and training services
- **GVRA — College Park VR Office (serves Fayette County)** — (844) 367-4872 — gvs.georgia.gov — Vocational rehabilitation office assigned to Fayette County
- **The Salvation Army — Jonesboro Corps (serves Fayette County)** — (770) 724-1680 — southernusa.salvationarmy.org — The Salvation Army unit serving Fayette County, based in Jonesboro; emergency food and financial help
- **Clayton County Community Services Authority** — (404) 363-0575 — claytoncountycsa.org — Community action agency serving Fayette County (with Clayton and Henry); utility, food, housing, and LIHEAP help
- **Peachtree City Library — Flint River Regional Library System** — (770) 631-2520 — frrls.net — Public library in Peachtree City; free computers, internet, and job-search resources

Columbus, GA

- **Columbus Career Center (Georgia Department of Labor / WorkSource Georgia)** — (404) 982-7985 — worksourcegaportal.com — State career center for job search and unemployment help. Note: GDOL announced a temporary closure of this center in July 2026 — call before going
- **GVRA — Columbus VR Office** — (844) 367-4872 — gvs.georgia.gov — Vocational rehabilitation office for the Columbus area
- **Goodwill Industries of the Southern Rivers — Midtown Career Center (Columbus)** — (706) 256-1837 — goodwillsr.org — Free career and training center in Columbus for job search, skills classes, and GED help
- **The Salvation Army — Columbus Corps** — (706) 561-9026 — salvationarmyusa.org — Columbus corps on Warm Springs Road; shelter, food, and family social services
- **Feeding the Valley Food Bank** — (706) 561-4755 — feedingthevalley.org — The regional food bank for the Columbus area; connects you to local pantries and food distributions
- **Georgia Legal Services Program — Columbus Regional Office** — (706) 649-7493 — glsp.org — Free civil legal help for low-income Muscogee County residents, including housing, benefits, and family matters

- **Enrichment Services Program** — (706) 649-1600 — enrichmentservices.org — Muscogee County's community action agency; energy assistance, employment training, and family stabilization services
- **United Way of the Chattahoochee Valley** — (706) 327-3255 — unitedcv.org — Local United Way for the Columbus area; also runs the local 211 referral service (dial 211)
- **Muscogee County DFCS Office** — (706) 321-2673 — dfcs.georgia.gov — County DFCS office in Columbus for SNAP, Medicaid, and TANF (the statewide Customer Contact Center, (877) 423-4746, is listed in the Georgia statewide group)
- **Chattahoochee Valley Libraries** — (706) 243-2669 — cvlga.org — Public library system for Columbus; free computers, internet, printing, and job-search resources

South Atlanta, GA

- **WorkSource Fulton — South Fulton Career Center (College Park)** — (404) 613-6800 — fultoncountyga.gov — South Fulton County's American Job Center for job search, training, and GED help
- **WorkSource Atlanta Regional — Career Resource Center, Clayton Branch (Morrow)** — (678) 271-3554 — atlantaregional.org — Career center serving Clayton County for job search and training services
- **WorkSource Atlanta** — (404) 546-3000 — worksourcegaportal.com — City of Atlanta's workforce center for job seekers and training programs
- **GVRA — College Park VR Office (serves Fulton and Clayton Counties)** — (844) 367-4872 — gvs.georgia.gov — Vocational rehabilitation office for the south metro area
- **Goodwill of North Georgia — Old National Career Center (South Atlanta)** — (844) 344-9675 — goodwillng.org — Free career center on Old National Highway serving south Fulton; use the regional career services line
- **The Salvation Army — Red Shield Services (Atlanta)** — (404) 486-2700 — southernusa.salvationarmy.org — Emergency and transitional shelter plus social services in Atlanta for Fulton County
- **The Salvation Army — Jonesboro Corps (serves Clayton County)** — (770) 724-1680 — southernusa.salvationarmy.org — Corps serving Clayton County; emergency food and financial assistance

- **Fulton Atlanta Community Action Authority (FACAA)** — (404) 320-0166 — facaa.org — Community action agency for Fulton County and Atlanta; emergency assistance, LIHEAP, and self-sufficiency programs
- **Clayton County Community Services Authority** — (404) 363-0575 — claytoncountycsa.org — Community action agency for Clayton County; utility, food, housing, and LIHEAP help
- **Atlanta Legal Aid Society** — (404) 524-5811 — atlantalegalaid.org — Free civil legal help for low-income Fulton and Clayton County residents
- **Fulton County Library System — Central Library** — (404) 612-8700 — fulcolibrary.org — Main library for Fulton County; free computers, internet, and job-search resources

Alabama — statewide

- **Alabama Disabilities Advocacy Program (ADAP)** — 800-826-1675 — adap.ua.edu — Free legal advocacy and rights help for Alabamians with disabilities — Alabama's Protection & Advocacy program.

Birmingham, AL

- **Birmingham Career Center** — 205-582-5200 — Job search help and career services.
- **Alabama Goodwill (Birmingham)** — 205-323-6331 — Job training and career help.
- **Community Food Bank of Central Alabama** — 205-942-8911 — Food assistance across the Birmingham area.
- **Salvation Army Birmingham** — 205-328-2420 — Emergency help with food, shelter, and bills.
- **Legal Services Alabama** — 866-456-4995 — Free civil legal help for low-income Alabamians.
- **Alabama Department of Rehabilitation Services (ADRS) — Vocational Rehabilitation, Homewood** — 205-290-4400 — rehab.alabama.gov — Free job training, counseling, and placement help for people with disabilities who want to work
- **Disability Rights & Resources (Center for Independent Living)** — 205-251-2223 — drradvocates.org — Free independent-living skills, benefits and housing guidance, and advocacy run by people with disabilities; serves Jefferson County and also Calhoun County

- **United Way of Central Alabama** — 205-251-5131 — uwca.org — Connects Jefferson County residents to local help with food, housing, utilities, and crisis needs
- **United Way Area Agency on Aging of Jefferson County — Aging & Disability Resource Center (ADRC)** — 1-800-243-5463 (1-800-AGE-LINE) — uwca.org — Free information and referrals on aging and disability services, benefits, and in-home help in Jefferson County
- **Alabama DHR — Jefferson County Food Assistance (SNAP)** — 205-423-4200 — dhr.alabama.gov — Apply for or ask about SNAP food assistance and other county DHR services (2001 12th Ave. N.)
- **Birmingham Public Library (Central)** — 205-226-3600 — cobpl.org — Free computers, job-search and résumé help, and printing at the central library
- **Grace Klein Community (FeedBHM)** — 205-490-7516 — gracekleincommunity.com — Free drive-thru food distribution sites across the Birmingham metro, no appointment needed
- **NAMI Birmingham** — 205-515-6150 — namibham.org — Free mental-health support groups, classes, and peer help for Jefferson County

Anniston, AL

- **Anniston Career Center** — 256-832-0147 — Job search help and career services.
- **211 First Call For Help (United Way of East Central Alabama)** — 256-236-8229 — Local help line for food, rent, utility, and crisis referrals.
- **Interfaith Ministries of Calhoun County** — 256-237-1472 — Rent, utility, and ride help.
- **Legal Services Alabama (Anniston)** — 256-399-2548 — Free civil legal help.
- **Alabama Department of Rehabilitation Services (ADRS) — Vocational Rehabilitation, Anniston** — 256-240-8800 — rehab.alabama.gov — Free job training, counseling, and placement help for people with disabilities who want to work
- **Community Action Agency of TCRCC — Anniston Office** — 256-237-4114 — communityactiontcrcc.com — Help with utility bills, housing, and emergency needs for Calhoun County households (1427 Wilmer Ave.)
- **The Salvation Army — Anniston Corps** — 256-236-5643 — southernusa.salvationarmy.org — Food, clothing, utility, and emergency assistance in Anniston

- **Alabama DHR — Calhoun County Food Assistance (SNAP)** — 256-240-2100 — dhr.alabama.gov — Apply for or ask about SNAP food assistance and other county DHR services (415 W. 11th St.)
- **Public Library of Anniston-Calhoun County** — 256-237-8501 — publiclibrary.cc — Free computers, job-search help, and community resources (108 E. 10th St.)
- **East Alabama Regional Planning and Development Commission (EARPDC) — Area Agency on Aging** — 256-237-6741 — eastalabamaaging.org — Free information and referrals on aging and disability services for Calhoun and nine nearby counties

Montgomery, AL

- **Montgomery Career Center** — 334-286-1746 — Job search help and career services.
- **Goodwill of Central Alabama** — 334-263-4633 — Job training and career help.
- **Heart of Alabama Food Bank** — 334-263-3784 — Food assistance across the Montgomery area.
- **Legal Services Alabama** — 866-456-4995 — Free civil legal help for low-income Alabamians.
- **Alabama Department of Rehabilitation Services (ADRS) — Vocational Rehabilitation, Montgomery** — 334-293-7500 — rehab.alabama.gov — Free job training, counseling, and placement help for people with disabilities who want to work (560 S. Lawrence St.)
- **Independent Rights & Resources (Center for Independent Living)** — 334-240-2520 — independentrandr.org — Free independent-living skills, benefits and housing guidance, and advocacy run by people with disabilities (345 Molton St.)
- **Montgomery Community Action Committee & CDC** — 334-263-3474 — mcaccdinc.org — Help with utility bills, housing, weatherization, and Head Start for Montgomery County households (1066 Adams Ave.)
- **River Region United Way** — 334-264-7318 — rruw.org — Connects Montgomery-area residents to local help with food, housing, utilities, and crisis needs
- **The Salvation Army — Montgomery** — 334-265-0281 — salvationarmyusa.org — Food, shelter, and emergency assistance in Montgomery (3460 Carter Hill Rd.)

- **Alabama DHR — Montgomery County (main number)** — 334-293-3100 — dhr.alabama.gov — County DHR office for SNAP food assistance, family assistance, and other services
- **Montgomery City-County Public Library** — 334-625-4999 — mccpl.lib.al.us — Free computers, job-search help, and community resources (245 High St.)
- **Central Alabama Aging Consortium (CAAC) — Area Agency on Aging** — 334-240-4666 — centralalabamaaging.org — Free information and referrals on aging and disability services for Montgomery, Autauga, and Elmore counties

Marianna, FL

- **CareerSource Chipola (Marianna)** — 850-633-4419 — Job search help and career services.
- **211 Northwest Florida** — dial 2-1-1 — Local help line for community referrals.
- **Tri-County Community Council** — 850-547-3689 — Energy assistance and family support.
- **Legal Services of North Florida** — 850-385-9007 — Free civil legal help.
- **Disability Rights Florida** — 800-342-0823 — Florida's Protection & Advocacy agency for disability rights.
- **Florida Division of Vocational Rehabilitation, Unit 3 (Marianna office)** — 850-482-9600 — rehabworks.org — State vocational rehabilitation services for people with disabilities in Calhoun, Holmes, Jackson, Liberty, and Washington counties
- **Florida DCF ACCESS (MyACCESS)** — (850) 300-4323 — myflfamilies.com — The statewide route to apply for and manage SNAP food assistance, Medicaid, and cash assistance
- **Goodwill Industries of the Big Bend — Marianna Career Resource Center** — (850) 266-7836 — goodwillbigbend.org — Free job-placement help, career coaching, and training certifications (2800 Hwy. 71 North, Marianna)
- **The Salvation Army, Panama City Corps (serves Jackson County)** — 850-769-5259 — salvationarmyflorida.org — Emergency assistance, shelter, food, and financial help; its service area includes Jackson County (corps at 1824 W. 15th St., Panama City)
- **Second Harvest of the Big Bend** — (850) 562-3033 — fightinghunger.org — Regional food bank supplying food pantries across the Big Bend, including Jackson County

- **Chipola Family Ministries (food pantry, Marianna)** — (850) 573-1465 — fightinghunger.org (Second Harvest agency network) — Local food pantry at 3004 FL-71, Marianna, open Tue–Thu mornings
- **United Way of Northwest Florida** — 850-785-7521 — unitedwaynwfl.org — Community help and referrals across Northwest Florida, including Jackson County; also the partner behind 211 Northwest Florida
- **Jackson County Public Library (Marianna)** — (850) 482-1257 — jcplfl.org — Public library at 2929 Green St., Marianna, with free computers, printing, and job-search help

Country Club Hills / Chicago Southland, IL

Start with Illinois workNet (above), 2-1-1, or your local American Job Center (1-877-872-5627) — then:

- **South Suburban Cook County American Job Center at Prairie State College** — 708-709-7975 · 855-994-8300 — chicookworks.org — The comprehensive American Job Center for the south suburbs — job search, training, veterans and youth services (202 S. Halsted St., Chicago Heights)
- **Illinois DHS, Division of Rehabilitation Services — Chicago Heights office** — (708) 709-3333 — dhs.state.il.us — Vocational rehabilitation and home services for people with disabilities
- **IDHS Family Community Resource Center — South Suburban (Blue Island)** — (708) 293-4700 — dhs.state.il.us — The local DHS office for SNAP, cash, and medical assistance for the Country Club Hills area (3301 Wireton Rd., Blue Island)
- **Greater Chicago Food Depository** — 773-247-3663 — chicagosfoodbank.org — Cook County's food bank; its benefits team helps people apply for SNAP/Link and Medicaid and finds nearby food pantries
- **CEDA (Community and Economic Development Association of Cook County)** — (800) 571-2332 — cedaorg.net — Cook County's community action agency; runs LIHEAP utility-bill help and other assistance for Chicago and suburban Cook County
- **211 Metro Chicago (United Way of Metro Chicago)** — dial 2-1-1 · or text your ZIP code to 898-211 — 211metrochicago.org — Free 24-hour helpline connecting Cook County residents to food, housing, utility, and job help
- **Legal Aid Chicago** — 312-341-1070 — legalaidchicago.org — Free civil legal aid for people living in poverty in Chicago and suburban Cook County; all clients are screened by phone at this number

- **The Salvation Army, Blue Island (Crossgenerations) Corps** — 708-332-0100 — salvationarmyusa.org — Food, emergency assistance, and community programs at 2900 Burr Oak Ave., Blue Island, serving the south suburbs
- **Respond Now (Chicago Heights)** — (708) 755-4357 — respondnow.org — Food pantry plus rent, utility, and homelessness-prevention help for south suburban residents (1439 Emerald Ave., Chicago Heights)
- **South Suburban PADS** — 708-332-7700 — sspads.org — Emergency shelter network and housing help across south Cook County, including its Country Club Hills Wellness Center
- **Goodwill Greater Milwaukee & Chicago — Englewood Workforce Connection Center** — 773-627-5770 — goodwillgreatermc.org — Free résumé, job-search, and digital-skills help; Goodwill has no south-suburban center — Englewood (6054 S. Western Ave., Chicago) is its Chicago South Side workforce center

Baton Rouge, LA

- **Capital Area United Way** — (225) 383-2643 — cauw.org — Funds and connects community help across the 10-parish Capital Area and operates the local 211 service (700 Laurel St., Baton Rouge)
- **East Baton Rouge North American Job Center (EmployBR)** — (225) 358-4579 — louisianaworks.net — Job search, training, and workforce services at 4523 Plank Road, Baton Rouge (the South center is listed as temporarily closed; both centers use this number)
- **Louisiana Rehabilitation Services — Baton Rouge Region (Region II)** — (225) 295-8900 · toll-free 1-800-737-2959 — laworks.net — Vocational rehabilitation for people with disabilities in the Baton Rouge region (950 North 22nd St., Baton Rouge)
- **Goodwill Industries of Southeastern Louisiana — Baton Rouge (Coursey Blvd.)** — 225-295-1921 — goodwillno.org — Store and donation center at 10778 Coursey Blvd., Baton Rouge, funding Goodwill's job training and disability employment programs
- **The Salvation Army of Greater Baton Rouge** — 225-355-4483 — salvationarmyusa.org — Food, shelter, recovery, and emergency assistance; corps at 7361 Airline Hwy., Baton Rouge
- **Greater Baton Rouge Food Bank** — (225) 359-9940 — brfoodbank.org — Feeding America food bank supplying 100+ partner pantries across an 11-parish area (10600 S. Choctaw Dr., Baton Rouge)

- **Southeast Louisiana Legal Services — Baton Rouge office** — (225) 448-0080 — slls.org — Free civil legal aid for low-income people — housing, consumer, benefits, and job-related problems (715 St. Ferdinand St., Baton Rouge)
- **City of Baton Rouge / East Baton Rouge Parish Office of Social Services** — 225-358-4561 — brla.gov — The parish community-action office: LIHEAP utility help, CSBG services, and rent/mortgage assistance
- **Capital Area Human Services District** — (225) 922-2700 · clinic access 225-925-1906 — cahsd.org — Public behavioral-health, addiction, and developmental-disability services for the Baton Rouge area (12301 Coursey Blvd.)
- **Louisiana SNAP / cash assistance line (LAHelpU)** — 1-888-524-3578 (1-888-LA-HELP-U) — ldh.la.gov — Statewide line to apply by phone for SNAP, FITAP cash assistance, and Kinship Care and to complete your interview (SNAP is now administered by the Louisiana Department of Health)
- **East Baton Rouge Parish Library — Career Center** — (225) 231-3733 — ebrpl.com — Free one-on-one résumé, interview, and job-search help inside the Main Library at Goodwood (7711 Goodwood Blvd., Baton Rouge)
- **Disability Rights Louisiana** — 1-800-960-7705 — disabilityrightsla.org — Louisiana's Protection & Advocacy agency: free legal advocacy and information for people with disabilities statewide

Directories go stale. If a number fails, dial 2-1-1 for the current local listing — and know that every region has the same kinds of help listed here: a workforce board, career centers, Goodwill, legal aid, and a food bank network.

Appendix C: Glossary — Plain Words

- **1619(a):** shorthand for the situation where you work, your SSI payment shrinks by the formula, and you keep receiving some SSI cash.
- **1619(b):** the rule that keeps your **Medicaid** (and SSI status) when earnings alone bring your SSI cash payment to $0. Does not apply when unearned income caused the stop.
- **ABLE account:** a protected savings account for disability expenses; first $100,000 doesn't count toward SSI resources.
- **BWIA:** Benefits and Work Incentive Advisement — a one-on-one review of your benefits and work, free through Ticket to Work (offered by Employment Networks and WIPA projects).
- **BPQY:** Benefits Planning Query — SSA's printout of your status: Trial Work months used, EPE dates, Medicare info. The document that settles your phase.
- **BWE (Blind Work Expenses):** for SSI recipients who are blind — nearly any cost of earning money is deductible, dollar for dollar.
- **CDR:** Continuing Disability Review — SSA's medical review of whether your condition has improved.
- **Cessation month:** the first month SSA finds you worked above SGA in the EPE. It's paid, plus the two months after (grace period).
- **Countable earnings/income:** what's left after exclusions and deductions — the number SSA actually judges.
- **Disclosure:** telling an employer a disability is involved, so accommodations can start. You choose how much to say; you can start with your limitation, not your diagnosis (Chapter 20).
- **EPE (Extended Period of Eligibility):** the 36 months after your Trial Work Period; checks pause and restart with your earnings.
- **EXR (Expedited Reinstatement):** the 5-year way back: restart benefits without a new application if work ends because of your disability. 24 reinstated payments earn a fresh TWP and a new 5-year window.
- **Grace period:** cessation month + 2 following months — all paid.
- **IDA:** Individual Development Account — matched savings; federally funded IDA savings are excluded from SSI counting.

- **IRP:** Initial Reinstatement Period — the period after EXR approval until you've received 24 payments.
- **IRWE:** Impairment-Related Work Expenses — disability-related costs you pay to be able to work; deductible.
- **IWP:** Individual Work Plan — your written plan with your Employment Network: goals, services, steps.
- **Interactive process:** the conversation where you and your employer work together to find an accommodation that works (Chapter 20).
- **Medicare Savings Programs:** state programs (QMB, SLMB, QI, QDWI) that pay some or all Medicare premiums/costs by income level.
- **Overpayment:** money SSA says it paid you that you weren't due. Appealable and sometimes waivable (Chapter 6).
- **PASS:** Plan to Achieve Self-Support — approved plan to set aside income/resources for a work goal, excluded from SSI counting.
- **Reasonable accommodation:** a change to a job, the workplace, or how things are done that lets you do the essential work despite a disability-related barrier (Chapter 20).
- **SEIE:** Student Earned Income Exclusion — under-22 students: up to $2,500/mo and $10,080/yr of earnings excluded (2027).
- **SGA (Substantial Gainful Activity):** the earnings line SSA uses after the TWP — $1,770/mo non-blind, $2,950 blind (2027).
- **Subsidy / Special Condition:** extra help you get at work (from your employer / from someone else) whose value can be subtracted from countable earnings.
- **TWP (Trial Work Period):** 9 months in a rolling 60-month window to test work with full SSDI checks; a month counts when gross tops $1,270 (2027) or self-employment exceeds 80 hours.
- **UWA (Unsuccessful Work Attempt):** SGA-level work ending within ~6 months because of the disability; may be disregarded if claimed before a cessation decision.
- **Undue hardship:** the legal limit on accommodations — a change an employer does not have to make because it would be significantly difficult or expensive for that employer (Chapter 20).
- **WIPA:** Work Incentives Planning and Assistance — free, in-depth benefits counseling projects; reach one through the Help Line.

Appendix D: Sources and a Note About These Numbers

Where this book's rules come from:

- **Social Security Administration** — this book's primary SSA reference is **The Red Book** (Publication No. 64-030, June 2026), SSA's own guide to employment supports and work incentives. Also cited: Working While Disabled: How We Can Help (EN-05-10095, July 2026), Your Ticket to Work (EN-05-10061, June 2026), Understanding the Extra Help With Your Medicare Prescription Drug Plan (EN-05-10508, August 2026), SSA's 2027 COLA fact sheet, and SSA's SGA, Trial Work Period, and Student Earned Income Exclusion pages (ssa.gov). All dollar figures in this book are SSA's published 2027 figures, verified against SSA on October 29, 2026. The big reference lists come straight from the primary sources: the IRWE list and countable-income toolkit (Chapter 4) from the Red Book's own deductible/non-deductible tables and work-incentive chapters; the PASS spending list (Chapter 10) from SSA's PASS rules, POMS SI 00870.025; the ABLE spending list (Chapter 9) from the ABLE statute itself, 26 U.S.C. §529A, with IRS guidance; and the wealth-building paths and traps (Chapter 11) from the Red Book's resource-exclusion chapters and SSA's SSI resource and transfer rules (20 CFR Part 416, Subpart L).
- **Justice in Aging** — the "Go Deeper" readings throughout come from Justice in Aging's Resource Library catalog (1,181 items, harvested October 29, 2026): fact sheets, issue briefs, toolkits, and webinars on SSI, Social Security, Medicaid, and Medicare. Justice in Aging is a national legal advocacy organization fighting senior poverty; their materials are written for advocates, which is why this book translates rather than copies them.
- **Cornell University, Yang-Tan Institute** — Work Incentive Planning for Benefit Practitioners (2026 WIP-C manual, Parts 1–3). The practitioner details behind Chapters 4, 6, 8, 9, and 10 — Blind Work Expenses, overpayment remedies, Medicare Savings Programs, the 1619(b) "but for" rule, and the EXR 24-payment payoff — were confirmed against this manual and rewritten here in participant language. Where sources disagreed (the ABLE-to-Work extra contribution amount), this book tells you to confirm with your state program rather than guessing.

- **Job Accommodation Network (JAN), U.S. Department of Labor** — Insights on the ADA: Q&A for Workers, the Employees' Practical Guide to Requesting and Negotiating Reasonable Accommodation, the sample request letters, and the Cost and Benefits of Accommodations report (updated September 17, 2025), all at askjan.org. Chapter 20 is built on JAN's worker guidance. JAN's materials are U.S. Government works — not copyrighted — and are used here with credit, as JAN asks; the letter templates in Chapter 20 were written for this book, modeled on JAN's samples.
- **Prestige Path Consulting LLC (the publisher)** — the practitioner materials behind this book: the publisher's website (phase framework, FAQ, worked examples), the Back to Work Benefits Cheat Sheet (Sept 2026; rebuilt as Appendix A), and the Prestige Path Resource List workbook (verified October 2026; source of Appendix B's local listings).

The numbers note. Figures in this book are **2027 figures** — this is the 2027 edition. SSA adjusts most amounts every January, so before acting in a new year, check the current figure (ssa.gov or ask us) before you act on it — that's the habit Chapter 5 builds.

General information only — not personal advice, and not legal advice. Only the Social Security Administration holds your official record. For your situation: your Employment Network, a WIPA counselor (Ticket to Work Help Line 1-866-968-7842), or SSA (1-800-772-1213).

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Appendix E: Paperwork You Can Copy

The right form, filled in right, sent with proof — that's half of winning every interaction in this book. Two kinds of pages live here: **official SSA forms** (verified against SSA's own forms library at ssa.gov/forms on October 29, 2026 — always download or pick up the CURRENT edition, because forms get revised and old editions say "Discontinue Prior Editions") and **worksheets from this book** (labeled as worksheets, safe to photocopy forever). Accommodation letters to an employer live in Chapter 20, with the rights chapter they belong to.

Where everything goes: form after form says the same thing — "Send the completed form to your local Social Security office." There is **no national fax number** for this paperwork. Find your office (and its fax number) with SSA's Office Locator at ssa.gov, or call 1-800-772-1213. **Never send originals** — completed forms and copies of evidence go to SSA; originals stay home. Keep your fax confirmation page or mailing proof with your copy, every time.

E-1 · Your Forms Library — The Complete Index

Your forms library — read this first. Every form and booklet in this index is **Social Security's own paperwork**, and it is **always free** from SSA: download the current edition at **ssa.gov/forms** (forms) or **ssa.gov/pubs** (booklets), pick one up at your local office, or ask SSA to mail it. **Never pay anyone for an SSA form** — anyone charging for one is charging for something SSA gives away. Forms get revised: most say **"Discontinue Prior Editions"** on their face, which means an old photocopy from a drawer can be the wrong edition. The edition dates and page counts below were read from the actual downloaded PDFs themselves (ssa.gov, October 29, 2026) — but when you file, the live ssa.gov copy is the one that counts.

Form / Publication	Exact official title — what it's for	Pages · Edition	Where it appears in this book
SSA-545-BK	**Plan to Achieve Self-Support (PASS)** — set aside money for a work goal under an approved plan	12 pp. · 07-2025	Ch. 10, Scenario 10
SSA-821-BK	**Work Activity Report - Employee** — SSA's report on your job when it reviews your work; return within 15 days	12 pp. · 09-2025	Ch. 5, Scenario 5
SSA-820-BK	**Work Activity Report - Self-Employment** — the same report for gig, 1099, and self-employment; return within 15 days	10 pp. · 03-2026 (as printed)	Ch. 5, Ch. 24
SSA-766	**Statement of Self-Employment Income** — a short signed statement of self-employment earnings for a period SSA asks about	2 pp. · 06-2025	Ch. 24
SSA-795	**Statement of Claimant or Other Person** — a blank signed statement: tell SSA anything in your own words	2 pp. · 06-2022	Ch. 5–6; examples in E-5
SSA-454-BK	**Continuing Disability Review Report** — the long medical-review (CDR) report: condition, treatment, recent work	12 pp. · 09-2026	Ch. 7, Scenario 6
SSA-632-BK	**Request for Waiver of Overpayment Recovery** — ask SSA to forgive an overpayment (not your fault + can't afford / unfair)	10 pp. · 06-2025	Ch. 6, Scenario 1
SSA-634	**Request for Change in Overpayment Recovery Rate** — agree you owe it; ask SSA to take less each month	7 pp. · 12-2023	Ch. 6, Scenario 1

Form / Publication	Exact official title — what it's for	Pages · Edition	Where it appears in this book
SSA-561	**Request for Reconsideration** — the general appeal when a decision's facts or amount are wrong (60 days)	3 pp. · 08-2025	Ch. 6, Scenario 1
SSA-789	**Request for Reconsideration - Disability Cessation Right to Appear** — the appeal when SSA stops a check for medical reasons (60 days)	2 pp. · 04-2026	Ch. 7, Letter Decoder
SSA-3441-BK	**Disability Report - Appeal** — updates your condition, treatment, doctors, and work for a disability appeal	11 pp. · 07-2026	Ch. 7, Letter Decoder
SSA-792	**Statutory Benefit Continuation Election Statement** — elect to keep benefits going while a medical cessation is appealed; SSA must receive it within 15 calendar days of the cessation notice	5 pp. · 07-2026	Ch. 7, Letter Decoder
HA-501	**Request for Hearing by Administrative Law Judge** — ask a judge to decide after reconsideration is denied (60 days)	2 pp. · 06-2022	Ch. 6–7, Letter Decoder
SSA-371	**Request for Reinstatement - Title II** — Expedited Reinstatement for SSDI after benefits ended for work	2 pp. · 07-2024	Ch. 2, Scenario 6
SSA-372	**Request for Reinstatement - Title XVI** — Expedited Reinstatement for SSI after benefits ended for work	2 pp. · 01-2025	Ch. 3, Scenario 6
SSA-1021	**Appeal of Determination for Extra Help with Medicare Prescription Drug Plan Costs** — appeal an Extra Help decision; mail to the address printed on the form	4 pp. · 02-2025	Ch. 8, Letter Decoder

Form / Publication	Exact official title — what it's for	Pages · Edition	Where it appears in this book
SSA-44	**Medicare Income-Related Monthly Adjustment Amount - Life-Changing Event** — ask SSA to lower a premium surcharge after work stopped or hours dropped	8 pp. · 12-2025	Ch. 8, Letter Decoder
SSA-1696	**Claimant's Appointment of a Representative** — name the person SSA must deal with and send your notices to	6 pp. · 12-2024	Ch. 5–6, Letter Decoder
SSA-3288	**Consent for Release of Information** — your consent for SSA to release your information to a person or organization you name	3 pp. · 04-2026	Ch. 5–6
SSA-827	**Authorization to Disclose Information to the Social Security Administration (SSA)** — lets your doctors and other sources send SSA your medical records	2 pp. · 06-2024	Ch. 7, Scenario 6
EN-64-030	**The Red Book** (SSA publication — read it, never file it) — SSA's guide to employment supports and work incentives; this book's primary SSA reference	62 pp. · June 2026	Appendix D; rules chapters
EN-05-10095	**Working While Disabled: How We Can Help** (SSA publication) — SSA's plain-language booklet on working while on disability	25 pp. · July 2026	Appendix D, Ch. 5
EN-05-10061	**Your Ticket to Work** (SSA publication) — SSA's booklet on the Ticket to Work program and Employment Networks	20 pp. · June 2026	Appendix D, Ch. 7, Ch. 21

Form / Publication	Exact official title — what it's for	Pages · Edition	Where it appears in this book
EN-05-10508	**Understanding the Extra Help With Your Medicare Prescription Drug Plan** (SSA publication) — who qualifies for Extra Help, what it pays, how to apply	20 pp. · August 2026	Appendix D, Ch. 8

One more form you will meet in this book is route-only, by SSA's design: **SSA-1020 / i1020 — Application For Help With Medicare Prescription Drug Plan Costs.** SSA offers no downloadable paper copy to print (the paper version is a scannable original SSA must supply), so it is not one of the 24 library files above — apply online at ssa.gov/medicare/part-d-extra-help, by phone (1-800-772-1213), or at an office. See the trap in E-4.

E-2 · The Three Overpayment Doors — Don't Knock on the Wrong One

(Printed on the forms themselves, in plain words:)

- **Dispute the facts** ("I wasn't overpaid" / "the amount is wrong") → **SSA-561** Reconsideration. **60-day clock** from the notice; on SSI, appeal within **10 days** to keep payments going while it's decided.
- **Can't afford to repay / it wasn't your fault** → **SSA-632-BK** Waiver. (Note: the old combined title "…or Change in Repayment Rate" is obsolete — waiver and rate change are separate forms now.)
- **You owe it, but slower** → **SSA-634** Rate Change — not the waiver form.

- **The $2,000 shortcut (printed on the SSA-632-BK itself):** if the overpayment is **$2,000 or less** and you believe you were not at fault, **do not complete the form** — call 1-800-772-1213 or your local office; SSA may process the waiver by phone.
- Financial proof for the 632/634 should be **dated within 3 months** (printed on both forms).

E-3 · Deadlines Printed on the Forms

- **SSA-821-BK and SSA-820-BK (Work Activity Reports): "complete and return this form within 15 days."** If SSA doesn't hear back, it decides on the records it has — and may contact your employer. Fifteen days, not "whenever."
- **Reconsideration (SSA-561): 60 days** from the notice (SSA counts receipt as 5 days after the notice date unless you prove otherwise).
- **SSI payment continuation: 10 days** — appeal within 10 days of an advance notice to keep SSI payments going during the appeal.
- **Medical cessation reconsideration (SSA-789): 60 days** from the cessation notice — and use SSA-789, not SSA-561, when the stop is for medical reasons.
- **Benefit continuation election (SSA-792): SSA must RECEIVE it within 15 calendar days** of the date on the cessation notice. Receipt is what counts — hand-deliver it or confirm receipt; a mailbox on day 14 is a gamble.

- **Hearing request (HA-501): 60 days** from the reconsideration decision, when you ask an Administrative Law Judge to decide.

E-4 · Things That Have NO SSA Form (Don't Let Anyone Sell You One)

- **Monthly wage reporting — no paper form.** Report by phone, fax, mail, in person, or through your my Social Security account. SSI recipients also have SSA's automated wage-reporting phone system and mobile app. **SSA gives a receipt — save it with the pay stub.**
- **IRWE / Blind Work Expenses — no standalone form.** Expenses are reported inside the Work Activity Reports (both SSA-821-BK and SSA-820-BK have a work-expenses section — and warn "we may ask for proof"), supported by your receipts, with an **SSA-795** carrying your explanation. Our worksheet (E-7) is a preparation tool for that section.
- **ABLE accounts — no SSA form, by design.** You open an ABLE account directly with a **state ABLE program** (online or by phone) — never with SSA.
- **Medicare Savings Programs — no SSA form.** You apply at your **state Medicaid office**; the state decides. (Getting an MSP also automatically qualifies you for Extra Help.)
- **SSA-1020 trap:** the paper Extra Help application is a **scannable original** — there is no fillable PDF to print and fax. Apply online (i1020), by phone, or request the original paper application from SSA.

E-5 · Filled Examples — Copy the Style, Use Your Own Facts

Every example below is FICTIONAL — invented person, invented employer — written to show what a clear, complete answer looks like. Head every real statement with your own facts. Never copy an example onto an SSA form as if it were your information, and never make an example look like an SSA letter.

EXAMPLE — SSA-795 statement: "I started a job" (copy the words, use your own facts)

> "My name is Jordan Example. I am writing to report that I started working. My employer is [Employer Name], [address], phone [number]. My first day was [date]. I earn [$ amount] per hour and work about [number] hours per week. I am paid every [Friday / two weeks]. My supervisor is [name]. Please add this employer to my account so I can report my wages each month. I will report my earnings by [the 6th / the 10th] of each month and keep my pay stubs. — Signed, Jordan Example, [date]."

EXAMPLE — SSA-795 statement: "My job ended" (copy the words, use your own facts)

> "My name is Jordan Example. I am reporting that my job at [Employer Name] ended on [date]. My final paycheck, for [$ amount], was paid on [date], and I have attached a copy. I am not currently working. Please update my record. If my benefits were reduced because of these earnings, please tell me when they will be reviewed. — Signed, Jordan Example, [date]."

EXAMPLE — SSA-795 statement: good cause for a late appeal (copy the words, use your own facts)

> "My name is Jordan Example. I received the notice dated [date] on [actual date received, if later]. I am filing my Request for Reconsideration [number] days after the notice date because [honest reason: e.g., 'the notice went to my old address,' 'I was in the hospital from (date) to (date) — records attached,' 'I could not read the notice and needed help, which I got on (date)']. I am asking that my late filing be accepted for good cause. — Signed, Jordan Example, [date]."

EXAMPLE — the "my reasons are" box on the SSA-561 (copy the style, use your own facts)

> "I disagree with the overpayment amount for [months]. I reported my wages on [dates] by phone and received confirmation numbers [numbers]. Copies of my pay stubs and my wage-report log are attached. My countable earnings for [month] should be [$ amount] after my impairment-related work expenses of [$ amount] (receipts attached). Please recalculate."

EXAMPLE — a mini PASS plan outline (SSA-545-BK style)
(copy the structure, use your own facts)

> **Goal:** "I will complete the [certificate] program at [school] and work as a [job title] by [realistic month/year]." **Steps & dates:** apply by **; classes ___ to ; exam . Costs: tuition $; books $; exam/licence $**; transportation $**; total $** over ___ months. **Set-aside:** $___ per month from my [SSI/earnings] into a separate account at [bank]. **How it reduces my need for SSI:** the job pays about $___/month, which lowers my SSI by the formula and moves me toward self-support.

E-6 · Fax Cover Sheet (Worksheet — not an SSA form — copy freely)

> FAX — To: Social Security Administration, [local office name] · Office fax: [from SSA Office Locator] From: [your full name] · Phone: [your phone] (Never write your full Social Security number on a cover sheet — put it only where a form itself asks for it.) Enclosed: [form numbers / documents, e.g., "SSA-561 + wage-report log + pay stub copies"] Date sent: [date] · Pages (including this cover): [number] "Please confirm receipt. Copies sent — originals retained by sender." Confirmation page received? ☐ Yes — filed with my copy on [date]

E-7 · Monthly Wage-Report Log (Worksheet — not an SSA form)

Month	Job	Gross	Date sent	Method (phone/ online/fax/ mail)	Receipt #	Stub filed?

EXAMPLE — copy the words, use your own facts. (Fictional person and employer; amounts use this book's 2027 figures.)

Month	Job	Gross	Date sent	Method	Receipt #	Stub filed?
April 2027	Example Market	$1,150	May 4, 2027	Phone (1-866-772-0953)	Conf. 0417	☑ Yes
May 2027	Example Market	$1,320	June 3, 2027	Phone	Conf. 0522	☑ Yes

"Jordan Example" earned under the $1,270 Trial Work line in April (no Trial Work month used) and over it in May (one month used — marked on the Trial Work Counter). The log, the stubs, and the confirmation numbers together are the proof file Chapter 5 teaches. This same log is what makes an SSA-821-BK easy when one arrives.

E-8 · Work-Expense Worksheet — IRWE / BWE (Worksheet — not an SSA form — built to drop into the Work Activity Report's expense section)

Date	Item or service	Why I need it to work	Amount	Receipt kept?
Month total			$	

Blind and on SSI? Head the sheet "Blind Work Expenses (BWE)" — Chapter 4 explains why BWE is the better tool for you. Attach copies of receipts when you submit; keep the originals.

E-9 · Document Checklist — Your Folder System (Worksheet — not an SSA form)

- ☐ Pay stubs, in order, one envelope or phone folder per year
- ☐ Every SSA letter, with the date you received it written on the envelope
- ☐ Reporting receipts / fax confirmations, filed with the matching stubs
- ☐ Work-expense receipts (E-8 sheets on top)
- ☐ My BPQY, my phase worksheet, and My Numbers (updated)
- ☐ Copies of everything I've ever sent SSA — with the date sent

E-10 · Before You Fax or Mail — Checklist

- ☐ **Copies only.** Never send original pay stubs, receipts, or letters.
- ☐ Your Social Security number appears **only where the form itself instructs** — never on extra pages or cover sheets.
- ☐ The deadline check: is mailing time safe, or does this need fax/in-person filing? Under 30 days = get one-on-one help first (red-flag list, Part 1).
- ☐ Financial documents for a waiver/rate request are dated within **3 months**.
- ☐ After faxing: **keep the confirmation page stapled to your copy.** After mailing: write the mailing date on your copy; for deadline items, ask the post office about proof of mailing.

- ☐ Log it (E-7): date sent, method, confirmation.
- ☐ No word back in a reasonable time? Call the office, confirm receipt, write down who you spoke with.

E-11 · NESE Monthly Log — Self-Employment (Worksheet — not an SSA form)

Month	Income in	Business expenses	Net (NESE)	Hours worked	Trial Work month? (net over $1,270 or 80+ hrs)
Year total					

Keep this log from your first day of self-employment (Chapter 24). At tax time it's your Schedule C worksheet; if an SSA-820-BK ever arrives, it's how you answer inside the 15-day window.

End of book — keep it with your pay stubs. When life changes, your chapter is in here. And when it isn't, the free help is real: Ticket to Work Help Line 1-866-968-7842 (TTY 1-866-833-2967) · choosework.ssa.gov.